PRODUCT REQUIREMENTS DOCUMENT

# prd-forge

A domain expert, or a product manager who speaks for one, with no product management training, reaches an approved PRD in which every section is graded with no blocking defect and every buildability gap is closed or owned before anyone estimates.

| | |
|---|---|
| VERSION | 0.12.0 |
| STATUS | draft |
| OWNER | Richard Hightower |
| DOMAIN | product management tooling |
| CREATED | 2026-10-23 |
| UPDATED | 2026-10-29 |
| GOLDEN THREAD | J-001 |
| STAKEHOLDERS | Product managers who are, or speak for, the domain expert; Engineering leads who build from the resulting PRD; Sponsors who approve the PRD for a release. For this PRD the approver is Richard Hightower, the owner of the place where it is kept, named under FR-021.; Delivery leads who run story-mapping workshops |

## Executive summary

| | |
|---|---|
| **PROBLEM** | A domain expert knows exactly what their product must do, but what they can write down is a feature list with no named users, no pass-or-fail criteria and the technology already chosen. The team cannot build from it, and the expert is asked the same questions again by each engineer who tries. |
| **USERS** | Product managers who are, or speak for, the domain expert, the engineering leads who build from what they write, the sponsors who approve it, and the delivery leads who derive a backlog from it. |
| **WHY NOW** | In October 2025, 98% of 117 product managers surveyed said they use AI at work, and only 39% had received job-specific AI training (General Assembly, 6 Nov 2025). A PRD that reads well but cannot be built from costs more than no PRD at all, because it is believed. |
| **BET** | A domain expert, or a product manager who speaks for one, with no product management training, reaches an approved PRD in which every section is graded with no blocking defect and every buildability gap is closed or owned before anyone estimates. |
| **OBJECTIVE** | O-001 |
| **MEASURE** | Share of the 5 pilot PRDs that pass the buildability review on first submission, where a pass is the verdict `buildable`, or `buildable with gaps` with every gap closed or owned. The pilot PRDs are written between REL-001, on 2027-03-31, and 2027-09-30. Target: 80%, at least 4 of 5, by 2027-09-30, provisional until Q-001 sets the baseline, by 2027-02-28. |

## Contents


| § | SECTION | STATUS | GRADE | BLOCKING |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Problem and opportunity | draft | 83/100 | — |
| 2 | Target customer and market | draft | 75/100 | — |
| 3 | Business objectives and success metrics | draft | 88/100 | — |
| 4 | Users and personas | draft | 82/100 | — |
| 5 | User journeys | draft | 94/100 | — |
| 5 | Scenarios | draft | 89/100 | — |
| 6 | Scope | draft | 88/100 | — |
| 7 | Functional requirements | draft | 88/100 | — |
| 7 | Wireframes | draft | 91/100 | — |
| 8 | Non-functional requirements | draft | 89/100 | — |

| § | SECTION | STATUS | GRADE | BLOCKING |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 9 | Constraints | draft | 95/100 | — |
| 10 | Decision rights and trust rules | draft | 84/100 | — |
| 11 | Assumptions, risks and dependencies | draft | 96/100 | — |
| 12 | Open questions | draft | 88/100 | — |
| 13 | Release plan | draft | 88/100 | — |
| 14 | Glossary | draft | 85/100 | — |
| 15 | Change log and approvals | draft | 75/100 | — |

## Approvers

- Richard Hightower, Sponsor

## In scope

- IN-001: State the idea and the domain's vocabulary once, and see every section of the set and its state
- IN-002: Be taught each section before its interview, be asked one or two questions at a time with follow-ups, end a section early with its gaps recorded, and stop being asked once the section would meet the gate
- IN-003: Record no invented domain fact, and convert a stated technology into the need beneath it, kept for the engineering lead
- IN-004: Read the draft as prose with its grade and every blocking defect, refute a finding, move to any section, refresh to see a change, and be told when the set states one item two ways
- IN-005: Answer one question about the weakest part, see the section re-graded against the same rubric, and resume after a break without repeating an answer
- IN-006: Get a buildability review of the whole set, read as an engineer would, and see which release-line stages no requirement covers and which requirements cannot be tested
- IN-007: Let the expert name each approver, give the sponsor one document with the summary, the scope, the grades, and the open questions, bring the sponsor's comments on an exported copy back into the set with a response to each, and let the expert record the sponsor's decision, given outside the product, with any conditions, against a named version

## Out of scope

- OUT-001: Deriving features, epics and stories from the approved PRD - journey J-002
- OUT-002: More than one expert working on the same set at the same time
- OUT-004: An engineering lead reading the set and recording their own confirmation that it can be built from
- OUT-003: Any view of the document set other than reading the documents themselves and stepping through them beside the conversation
- OUT-005: A reviewer commenting on a section inside the set, not on an exported copy

## Undecided

- Q-001: What share of specifications reaching a development team today pass a buildability review on first submission? Decider: Richard Hightower. By: 2027-02-28.
- Q-002: How many working days does it take today from the first question put to the domain expert about a product to an approved specification? Decider: Richard Hightower. By: 2027-02-28.
- Q-003: What share of `must` functional requirements in today's specifications can an engineer who was not in the interview write a test from? Decider: Richard Hightower. By: 2027-02-28.
- Q-004: How many organizations are in each segment in section 2? Decider: Richard Hightower. By: 2027-06-30.
- Q-005: Given what three sponsors say about a set shown with and without grades, does FR-013 stay `must`, with each section's grade shown to the sponsor? Decider: Richard Hightower. By: 2027-01-31.
- Q-006: How many sections does an expert complete in one sitting before stopping? Decider: Richard Hightower. By: 2027-02-28.
- Q-007: Does writing the requirements send an expert back to the journeys? Decider: Richard Hightower. By: 2027-02-28.
- Q-008: Does an engineering lead read a PRD that names no technology as disciplined or as incomplete? Decider: Richard Hightower. By: 2027-02-28.
- Q-009: Which version of the rubric and the eleven derivability checks does release 1 grade against? Decider: Richard Hightower. By: 2027-01-31.
- Q-010: Must an answer the expert gave survive the end of the session before its section is drafted, given A-005, that domain content stays in the expert's own session and in the documents? Decider: Richard Hightower. By: 2027-01-31.
- Q-012: Which segment in section 2 converts first? Decider: Richard Hightower. By: 2027-06-30.
- Q-013: What day rate does a buyer pay to contract a product manager for the writing of one set? Decider: Richard Hightower. By: 2027-06-30.
- Q-014: Given how experts describe a loop-back in D-002's sittings, does ST-004 keep its step that sends the expert back to an earlier section? Decider: Richard Hightower. By: 2027-02-28.
- Q-015: Who owns the rubric and the eleven derivability checks? Decider: Richard Hightower. By: 2027-01-15.
- Q-016: Must a grade show which version of the rubric it was made against? Decider: Richard Hightower. By: 2027-01-31.
- Q-017: Whom does the decider record as owner of NFR-006's accessibility, given that the product's output is read in places the non-goals in section 6 say we do not own? Decider: Richard Hightower. By: 2027-02-28.
- Q-018: What does each problem in section 1 cost, as one counted case per problem? Decider: Richard Hightower. By: 2027-01-31.
- Q-019: Will both parties behind D-002 and D-003 commit in writing to report by 2027-01-31, so that REL-001 keeps 2027-03-31? Decider: Richard Hightower. By: 2027-01-31.
- Q-020: Which section do experts stop at most often? Decider: Richard Hightower. By: 2027-02-28.
- Q-021: Whom does the decider record as owner of NFR-012's access control, given that a set is stored where the organization already stores documents? Decider: Richard Hightower. By: 2027-02-28.
- Q-022: If D-002 or D-003 reports after 2027-01-31, does REL-001 move or ship as an experiment? Decider: Richard Hightower. By: 2027-01-31.
- Q-023: Do delivery leads run a story-mapping workshop about once per release and want a backbone agreed before it, as PER-004 assumes? Decider: Richard Hightower. By: 2027-05-31.

## Blocking defects

None.

## About this document

A domain expert knows exactly what their product must do, but what they can write down is a feature list with no named users, no pass-or-fail criteria and the technology already chosen. The team cannot build from it, and the expert is asked the same questions again by each engineer who tries. The users are product managers who are, or speak for, the domain expert, the engineering leads who build from what they write, the sponsors who approve it, and the delivery leads who derive a backlog from it. In October 2025, 98% of 117 product managers surveyed said they use AI at work, and only 39% had received job-specific AI training (General Assembly, 6 Nov 2025). A PRD that reads well but cannot be built from costs more than no PRD at all, because it is believed.

The bet is one outcome: the expert, with no product management training, reaches an approved PRD in which every section is graded with no blocking defect and every buildability gap is closed or owned before anyone estimates. We will know it worked when at least 4 of the 5 pilot PRDs, 80%, pass the buildability review on first submission by 2027-09-30. The pilot PRDs are the first 5 written with release 1, between REL-001 on 2027-03-31 and 2027-09-30, by people other than the product's author. The target is provisional until Q-001 sets the baseline, by 2027-02-28.

### Contents


| SECTION | DOCUMENT |
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| 1 | Problem and opportunity |
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| 4 | Users and personas |
| 5 | User journeys |
| 5 | Scenarios |
| 6 | Scope |
| 7 | Functional requirements |
| 7 | Wireframes |
| 8 | Non-functional requirements |
| 9 | Constraints |
| 10 | Decision rights and trust rules |
| 11 | Assumptions, risks and dependencies |
| 12 | Open questions |
| 13 | Release plan |
| 14 | Glossary |

| SECTION | DOCUMENT |
| --- | --- |
| 15 | Change log and approvals |

### How this document set is numbered

A PRD has **fifteen numbered sections** and this set has **seventeen section documents**, because section 5 holds two of them, journeys and scenarios, and section 7 holds two, functional requirements and wireframes. The two section 7 files share the prefix `08`. From section 5 onward, the file prefix and the section number differ: `07-scope.md` is section 6, and `16-change-log.md` is section 15. **Every cross-reference in this set is by section number, never by file number.** Three independent reviewers misread this, so it is stated here rather than left to be inferred.

### A note on this PRD

This is prd-forge's PRD, written with prd-forge's own conventions. The requirements in section 7 describe only what a person does and sees, and section 15 records what each version changed.

SECTION 1

# Problem and opportunity

DRAFT 83/100 NO BLOCKING DEFECTS

| ID | PROBLEM | WHO |
|---|---|---|
| P-001 | What the expert writes is a feature list with no user and no testable outcome | Product manager or domain expert |
| P-002 | The steps between requirements are never written, so paths have gaps | Engineering lead |
| P-003 | Buildability is invisible until the team starts building | Sponsor |
| P-004 | The expert does not know what a section is for, so they fill it badly | Product manager or domain expert |

The four compound. P-004 means the expert does not know what good looks like; P-001 is what they produce as a result; P-002 is the specific gap a build trips over; and P-003 is why none of it is caught before it is expensive. P-002 is the engineering lead's problem, and the delivery lead, PER-004, meets it too, at the story-mapping workshop.

**Evidence note.** Each problem now has one counted case, with its source and date. The counts for P-001 to P-003 come from one engagement, this product's own PRD, written and graded with prd-forge. The count for P-004 comes from two public templates. One engagement shows that each problem occurs. It does not show how often. The other evidence items describe a pattern and are not measured. Each why-now claim cites the General Assembly survey of 117 product managers, run in October 2025. No cost has a number yet, and Q-018 asks for one per problem. All three objectives in section 3 still have no baseline. See Q-001, Q-002, and Q-003.

### P-001

**STATEMENT**
A domain expert can describe what their product must do out loud, but what they write down is a feature list: no named user, no outcome anyone could check, and a technology already chosen for reasons they cannot defend.

**WHO**
Product manager who is, or speaks for, the domain expert

**PERSONA**
PER-001

**EVIDENCE**
- Claim: In this PRD at version 0.1.0, the grading pass found 2 of 14 functional requirements, FR-003 and FR-004, with no outcome a person could see. Both were fixed at version 0.2.0; Source: prd-forge repository, commits 5ba59cb (version 0.1.0) and 5d4d936 (version 0.2.0); As of: 2026-10-26
- A team that receives a feature list re-derives the user and the acceptance criteria itself before it can estimate.
- Experts asked to write requirements reach for the words of the software they have used, because that is the only requirements language they have been exposed to.

**WHY NOW**
In October 2025, 98% of 117 product managers surveyed said they use AI at work (General Assembly, "AI is everywhere in product management, but skills gaps and 'shadow AI' are holding teams back", 6 Nov 2025), which means drafts written with AI help arrive fluent. Fluent and unbuildable is a worse failure than rough and unbuildable, because nobody queries it.

**COST OF INACTION**
The gap is closed by an engineer guessing, during build, at what the expert meant, and the guess is discovered at review or in production. Q-018 asks for one counted cost.

**STATUS QUO**
The expert writes a feature list from a template, and an engineer re-derives the user and the criteria before estimating.

**DESIRED OUTCOME**
Every requirement names a user and an outcome that someone else can check.

### P-002

| | |
|---|---|
| STATEMENT | Requirements are written one at a time, so the steps between them are never written at all, and nobody notices until the team tries to assemble a working path through the product. |
| WHO | Engineering lead building from the PRD |
| PERSONA | PER-002 |
| EVIDENCE | • Claim: At version 0.1.0, the buildability review of this PRD failed 4 of 11 derivability checks and named 4 gates an engineer would have to invent; Source: prd-forge repository, the commit messages of 5ba59cb (version 0.1.0) and 5d4d936 (version 0.2.0); As of: 2026-10-26<br>• A specification with no user journey gives a story-mapping workshop no backbone, so features and epics cannot be derived from it at all.<br>• Gaps surface as mid-iteration questions about what happens between two requirements that both looked complete. |
| WHY NOW | In the same survey, 44% of product managers use AI for backlog grooming and QA support (General Assembly, "AI is everywhere in product management, but skills gaps and 'shadow AI' are holding teams back", 6 Nov 2025), which means more backlog items are written with AI help, and each one needs the path through the product that it serves. |
| COST OF INACTION | The release line is drawn across a feature list rather than a journey, and a release ships features that no user can complete anything with. Q-018 asks for one counted cost. |
| STATUS QUO | Gaps between requirements surface as questions in the middle of an iteration. |
| DESIRED OUTCOME | Every step a user must take to reach the goal is written down, and every gap is closed or owned before build. |

### P-003

| | |
|---|---|
| STATEMENT | Nobody can tell a buildable specification from a readable one until the team has already started building from it. |
| WHO | Sponsor approving the PRD |
| PERSONA | PER-003 |
| EVIDENCE | • Claim: At version 0.8.0, this PRD passed every schema and cross-reference check with 0 errors and 0 warnings. The grading pass found 23 blocking defects in 8 of 18 documents; Source: prd-forge repository, commit 6f77bc0 (version 0.8.0); As of: 2026-10-27<br>• Approval is given on readability and completeness of headings, because those are the only properties an approver can assess unaided.<br>• The first real assessment of buildability happens when an engineer estimates, which is after approval and after the plan was made. |
| WHY NOW | In the same survey, only 39% of product managers had received comprehensive, job-specific AI training (General Assembly, "AI is everywhere in product management, but skills gaps and 'shadow AI' are holding teams back", 6 Nov 2025), which means 61% of product managers judge AI drafts without that training, and a fluent draft is no evidence that it can be built. |
| COST OF INACTION | Plans and commitments are made on an approved document whose defects are found by the people asked to deliver against them. Q-018 asks for one counted cost. |
| STATUS QUO | The sponsor approves on readability, and buildability is first assessed when an engineer estimates. |
| DESIRED OUTCOME | The sponsor knows, before deciding, which parts of the PRD a team could not build from and what is still undecided. |

## P-004

| | |
|---|---|
| STATEMENT | An expert filling in a section of a PRD does not know what the section is for, so they fill it with what they have seen elsewhere: adjectives, feature names, and headings copied from a template. |
| WHO | Product manager who is, or speaks for, the domain expert |
| PERSONA | PER-001 |
| EVIDENCE | • Claim: Of 20 sections in two public PRD templates, all 20 say what to write, and 0 say what makes an entry good or how a reader checks it. The Aha! Agile PRD template has 6 sections, and the Product School PRD template has 14; Source: Aha! Agile PRD template, https://www.aha.io/roadmapping/guide/requirements-management/what-is-a-good-product-requirements-document-template, and Product School PRD template, https://productschool.com/blog/product-strategy/product-template-requirements-document-prd; As of: 2026-10-26<br>• The craft exists in books and in experienced product managers, and neither is at hand at the moment the expert is typing. |
| WHY NOW | In the same survey, 47% of product managers want to prototype and validate products without engineering, and 38% can (General Assembly, "AI is everywhere in product management, but skills gaps and 'shadow AI' are holding teams back", 6 Nov 2025), which means more of the specifying falls on the person with the domain knowledge, with no specialist between them and the page. |
| COST OF INACTION | Each expert reinvents the form badly, and the organization's PRDs cannot be compared to one another or improved as a body of work. Q-018 asks for one counted cost. |
| STATUS QUO | The expert fills a template whose headings say what to write but not what makes an entry good. |
| DESIRED OUTCOME | The expert knows what each section is for when they write it. |

SECTION 2

# Target customer and market

DRAFT 75/100 NO BLOCKING DEFECTS

| ID | SEGMENT | BUYER | USER |
|---|---|---|---|
| S-001 | Consultancies and advisory firms turning client domain knowledge into PRDs | Partner or director of the consultancy, the budget holder, as the sponsor | The consultant with the domain knowledge, as the product manager |
| S-002 | Regulated-industry organizations where practitioners specify their own internal software | Director of product or transformation, the budget holder, as the sponsor | The practitioner, as the product manager or domain expert |

Neither segment is sized yet. Both count organizations, and Q-004 asks for the count and its source.

| COMPETITOR | KIND |
|---|---|
| ChatPRD | Direct |
| A blank PRD template | Indirect |
| A general-purpose assistant conversation | Indirect |
| A product manager contracted without the domain | Indirect |
| A product manager who already holds the domain | Indirect |
| The status quo | Status quo |

Product teams entering a domain they do not know are a non-goal in section 6. They already employ the product skill and want the domain, which this product does not supply.

### Why we win

The expert confirmed each sponsor's words on 2026-10-27.

- **S-001, the consultancy partner:** "Before we hand the PRD to the client's engineers, I can see which parts they could not build from, and my senior people bill fewer hours fixing it later." The partner weighs it against the consultant's billable hours.
- **S-002, the director:** "Before I approve the budget, I can see which parts of the PRD my team could not build from." The director weighs it against contracting a product manager without the domain, whose day rate is Q-013.

In S-002 the organization works under regulation, so its PRDs may cite regulations. The set states no regulation the expert did not supply (FR-006, TR-005), which is what lets such a PRD be circulated.

**Honest weakness.** Against a product manager who already holds the domain, we have no quality edge, only availability. Any cost edge is unproven until Q-013. A skeptical buyer is right to test that.

## Segments

### S-001 · Consultancies and advisory firms turning client domain knowledge into PRDs

| | |
|---|---|
| BUYER | Partner or director of the consultancy, the budget holder, as the sponsor |
| BUYER PERSONA | PER-003 |
| USER | The consultant with the domain knowledge, as the product manager |
| USER PERSONAS | • PER-001 |
| SIZE | Not yet measured; see Q-004. |
| SIZE UNIT | organizations |
| WILLINGNESS TO PAY | Already pays for the consultant's time; the comparison is billable hours saved, not a software budget. |
| ADOPTION BARRIERS | • We may trust a machine's grade less than our own partner review (Q-005).<br>• We must approve client knowledge going into the assistant session our consultants already use before anyone works that way (A-004). |

### S-002 · Regulated-industry organizations where practitioners specify their own internal software

| | |
|---|---|
| BUYER | Director of product or transformation, the budget holder, as the sponsor |
| BUYER PERSONA | PER-003 |
| USER | The practitioner, as the product manager or domain expert |
| USER PERSONAS | • PER-001 |
| SIZE | Not yet measured; see Q-004. |
| SIZE UNIT | organizations |
| WILLINGNESS TO PAY | Compared against contracting a product manager for the project. The day rate is Q-013. |
| ADOPTION BARRIERS | • We may trust a machine's grade less than our own review (Q-005).<br>• Our engineering leads may send back a PRD that names no technology (A-003).<br>• We cannot circulate a PRD that cites a regulation our own expert did not supply (FR-006). |

## Competitors

### ChatPRD, an AI tool that drafts PRDs from a chat

| | |
|---|---|
| KIND | direct |
| OFFER | A structured PRD drafted fast from little input, from a chat. Source: ChatPRD docs, https://www.chatprd.ai/docs/writing-your-first-prd, accessed 2026-10-27. |
| OUR EDGE | Before the budget is committed, the sponsor sees in one document each section's grade and every blocking defect, with the section it is in (FR-013). The sponsor can open any set written with this product and look for the same list in a ChatPRD draft. |

### A blank PRD template in the team's document tool

| | |
|---|---|
| KIND | indirect |
| OFFER | The section headings, immediately, free, in a tool everyone already has. |
| OUR EDGE | When the PRD is done, each fact the expert could not supply is listed with a named person and a date to settle it, and the PRD states no figure or citation that nobody can stand behind. |

### A general-purpose assistant conversation with no structure

| | |
|---|---|
| KIND | indirect |
| OFFER | Fluent prose on any section, instantly, with no setup at all. |
| OUR EDGE | Before buying, the buyer can open any set written with this product, such as this one, and see which sections are not ready, with the quoted reason for each. A general-purpose conversation shows no such list. Writing that reads well is the failure P-003 names. |

### Contracting a product manager without the domain for the project

| | |
|---|---|
| KIND | indirect |
| OFFER | Genuine product judgement, and someone accountable for the outcome. |
| OUR EDGE | The buyer gets a PRD whose domain facts come from the person who holds them, rather than facts filled in by someone without the domain. Any cost advantage is unproven until Q-013 gives the day rate. The buyer can check the PRD for each fact the expert could not supply: each one has a named decider and a date. |

### Contracting a product manager who already holds the domain

| | |
|---|---|
| KIND | indirect |
| OFFER | Product judgement and the domain in one person, accountable for the outcome. |
| OUR EDGE | No quality edge. The buyer gets availability only: the work starts when their own domain expert can start, with no search for a person who holds both. Any cost advantage is unproven until Q-013 gives the day rate. |

### The status quo: a smart practitioner, a document, and a willing engineer

| | |
|---|---|
| KIND | status-quo |
| OFFER | No tool, no cost, no adoption, and it does sometimes work. |
| OUR EDGE | At handover, an engineer who was not in the room gets each fact the PRD does not yet know, with a named person and a date to settle it, so they can estimate without first interviewing the author. |

SECTION 3

# Business objectives and success metrics

DRAFT 88/100 NO BLOCKING DEFECTS

| ID | OBJECTIVE | METRIC | BASELINE | TARGET |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| O-001 | Buildable without re-derivation | Share of the 5 pilot PRDs that pass the buildability review first time | unknown (Q-001) | 80%, at least 4 of 5 |
| O-002 | Days to an approved PRD | Median working days, first interview question to approval, for pilot PRDs with one journey | unknown (Q-002) | under 5 |
| O-003 | Requirements testable as written | Share of `must` requirements an outside engineer can test | unknown (Q-003) | 95% |

### Why there are no baselines

All three baselines are unknown, and each has a matching open question with a decider and a date. This is deliberate and it is the honest state: this product has not run against a real engagement yet. Each target is provisional until its question is answered, by 2027-02-28, and section 15 records the moment each baseline arrives and each target is either confirmed or changed.

The pilot PRDs are the first 5 PRDs written with release 1 by people other than the product's author, between REL-001 on 2027-03-31 and 2027-09-30. A PRD passes the buildability review when the verdict is `buildable`, or `buildable with gaps` with every gap closed or owned. For O-003, a `must` requirement counts as testable when at least two of three engineering leads, scoring independently, say a test can be written from it.

A reader should push on this. An objective with an invented baseline is worse than one with an admitted gap, because the invented one gets planned against.

### What would move these without this product

Worth asking, and recorded here because the answer is not nothing: a single experienced product manager embedded with the expert would move all three. The bet is on availability and cost, not on beating that person. See section 2.

## Objectives

### O-001

| | |
|---|---|
| OBJECTIVE | A PRD handed to a development team can be built from without the team re-deriving it first. |
| PROBLEMS | • P-001<br>• P-002<br>• P-003 |
| METRIC | Share of the pilot PRDs that pass the buildability review, the eleven derivability checks, on first submission. The pilot PRDs are the first 5 PRDs written with release 1 by people other than the product's author, between REL-001, on 2027-03-31, and 2027-09-30. A PRD passes when the verdict is `buildable`, or `buildable with gaps` with every gap closed or owned. |
| MEASUREMENT | The verdict of the buildability review on each pilot PRD at its first submission. |
| INDICATOR | lagging |
| BASELINE | unknown - not measured; see Q-001. |
| BASELINE QUESTION | Q-001 |
| TARGET | 80% of the pilot PRDs, at least 4 of 5, pass on first submission. Provisional until Q-001 is answered, by 2027-02-28. |
| BY | 2027-09-30 |
| OWNER | Richard Hightower |

### O-002 · A domain expert, or a product manager who speaks for one, reaches an approved PRD in days.

| | |
|---|---|
| PROBLEMS | • P-004 |
| METRIC | Median elapsed working days, across the pilot PRDs that have one journey, from the first interview question to an approval recorded in section 15. |
| MEASUREMENT | The date of the first interview question and the date of the approval recorded in section 15, for each pilot PRD that has one journey. |
| INDICATOR | lagging |
| BASELINE | unknown - not measured; see Q-002. |
| BASELINE QUESTION | Q-002 |
| TARGET | Under 5 working days for a single-journey product. Provisional until Q-002 is answered, by 2027-02-28. |
| BY | 2027-09-30 |
| OWNER | Richard Hightower |

## O-003

| | |
|---|---|
| OBJECTIVE | Requirements are testable as written, so a team can close them without asking the author what they meant. |
| PROBLEMS | • P-001<br>• P-004 |
| METRIC | Share of `must` functional requirements whose acceptance criteria an engineer who was not in the interview judges sufficient to write a test from. |
| MEASUREMENT | Three engineering leads who were not in the interview score each `must` requirement of each pilot PRD independently, as Q-003 does. A requirement counts as testable when at least two of the three say a test can be written from its acceptance criteria. |
| INDICATOR | leading |
| BASELINE | unknown - not measured; see Q-003. |
| BASELINE QUESTION | Q-003 |
| TARGET | 95% of `must` requirements. Provisional until Q-003 is answered, by 2027-02-28. |
| BY | 2027-09-30 |
| OWNER | Richard Hightower |

SECTION 4

# Users and personas

DRAFT 82/100 NO BLOCKING DEFECTS

| ID | ROLE | PER PRD | FREQUENCY | DECIDES |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| PER-001 | Senior product manager in a consultancy or an in-house product team: the domain expert, or a proxy who speaks for one | One; 2 PRDs at once and 6 a year per organization | 3 working sittings a week of 1 to 2 hours, for 1 to 3 weeks per PRD | What the product must do, scope, the domain's terms, when an interview ends, drafts, section states, whether to accept or refute a grade, domain facts, whether the domain check may research outside the session, and when the set is offered; not the PRD itself where a sponsor exists |
| PER-002 | Engineering lead (staff or principal engineer) on the development team | One or two | At estimation and at each release planning | How it is built, and whether a set can be built from, with its gaps (TR-006) |
| PER-003 | Sponsor: the budget holder (director or partner), who is also the approver | One | Once per version, about 6 a year | Approves the PRD for a release, with or without conditions, or rejects it (TR-001) |
| PER-004 | Delivery lead (delivery manager or product owner) on the development team | One | Once per release, about 6 a year | The backlog's shape and order, and whether a backlog can be mapped at all |

No persona is external. Under a client contract, in segment S-001, the sponsor, the engineering lead, and the delivery lead all work for the consultancy. The client's staff only supply domain knowledge to the expert, and they do not use the product.

### PER-001 is the primary persona

PER-001 is the product manager who writes the PRD: either the domain expert, or a product manager who speaks for one. The set calls this person the expert, because they hold the domain knowledge in the interview. Everything is designed around someone with deep domain knowledge, no product training, and a burst of intense use followed by months away. Two consequences run through the rest of this PRD: nothing may assume prior knowledge of product vocabulary, and the work must survive being put down for a week and picked back up. See FR-015 and NFR-004.

### Who is deliberately not a persona

No mechanism is a persona. Whatever delivers the teaching, the interview, and the grading is how the product reaches PER-001, and the set keeps it out of the requirements: section 6 makes a separate application a non-goal, and section 11 records the session as dependency D-001. What matters to this PRD is that PER-001 sees a grade they did not produce themselves.

> **PER-001**
>
> NAME — Product manager (senior: manager to principal), in a consultancy or an in-house product team: the domain expert, or a proxy who speaks for one
>
> SHORT NAME — DomainExpert
>
> PRIMARY — yes

POPULATION
One per PRD. Per organization, 2 PRDs run at once and 6 start in a year.

EXTERNAL
no

PROBLEMS
- P-001
- P-004

BASIS
Assumed, not researched. Section 1's evidence note says the evidence comes from one engagement. The ten observed sittings in D-002 test it.

CONTEXT
Works inside the session they already use, as section 11 records (D-001), in bursts weeks apart (NFR-004).

GOALS
- Get what is in my head into a form the development team can build from
- Stop being asked the same question by four different engineers
- Not be the reason the project is late

PAINS
- I know what it must do, and I cannot write it the way they need it
- I am told my requirements are not testable and I do not know what that means
- I reach for the names of software I have used, because that is the only requirements language I have

FREQUENCY
Three working sittings a week of 1 to 2 hours each, for one to three weeks per PRD, about 6 to 9 sittings per PRD, then rarely until the next one.

AUTHORITY
Decides what the product must do and what is out of scope; decides the domain's own terms; decides when a section's interview is finished and when a section may be left at draft; accepts or corrects a drafted section; sets a section to final; accepts or refutes a grade; decides whether the set may be offered for approval; decides whether the domain check may research the set's domain outside the session; and is the only one who may state a domain fact as true. May not approve the PRD for a release on their own where a sponsor exists.

PROFICIENCY
Either deep in the domain with no product management training, or a product manager who speaks for such an expert. The product assumes the first: no familiarity with MoSCoW, Given/When/Then, or the word "persona".

## PER-002

NAME
Engineering lead (staff or principal engineer) on the development team, who must build from the PRD

SHORT NAME
EngineerLead

POPULATION
One or two per PRD, so 2 to 4 at once in an organization running 2 PRDs at once.

EXTERNAL
no

PROBLEMS
- P-001
- P-002

BASIS
Assumed, not researched, as section 1's evidence note says. The three engineering leads in D-003 test it.

CONTEXT
Reads the set cold at estimation and at each release planning, without having been in the interview.

GOALS
- Estimate without first interviewing the author
- Know which decisions are mine and which have been made for me
- Find out now, not in iteration three, what the document does not say

PAINS
- Specifications that name a technology and so pre-empt my decision badly
- Requirements I cannot write a test for
- Gaps between two requirements that both looked complete

FREQUENCY
Reads each PRD at estimation and at each release planning, so at least 12 reads a year in an organization that starts 6 PRDs a year.

| | |
|---|---|
| AUTHORITY | Decides how it is built. Judges whether a set can be built from and reports the gaps, under TR-006, and records a verdict that a set is not buildable when it is not. |
| PROFICIENCY | Expert in delivery, usually knows nothing about the expert's domain. |

### PER-003 · Sponsor: the budget holder (director or partner), who is also the approver

| | |
|---|---|
| SHORT NAME | Sponsor |
| POPULATION | One per PRD, and one organization starts 6 PRDs a year. |
| EXTERNAL | no |
| PROBLEMS | • P-003 |
| BASIS | Assumed, not researched, as section 1's evidence note says. Q-005 tests it with three sponsors. |
| CONTEXT | Reads the root document or an exported copy outside the product, once per version (ST-006). |
| GOALS | • Be confident enough to commit budget and a date<br>• Know what is still undecided, and who is deciding it |
| PAINS | • I can only judge whether it reads well<br>• I find out it was not buildable after I have committed to the plan |
| FREQUENCY | Once per version offered, about 6 versions a year per organization, plus any conditions. |
| AUTHORITY | Approves the PRD for a release; may approve with conditions; may reject. |
| PROFICIENCY | Senior in the business, not in product or engineering. |

### PER-004

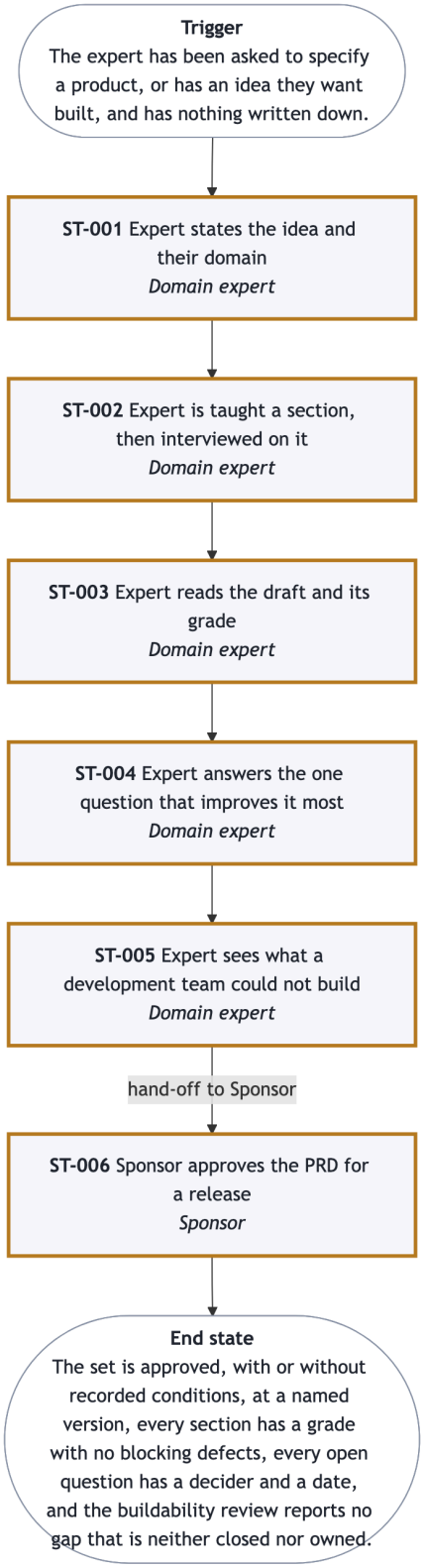
| | |
|---|---|
| NAME | Delivery lead (delivery manager or product owner) on the development team, who runs the story-mapping workshop |
| SHORT NAME | DeliveryLead |
| POPULATION | One per PRD, and one organization starts 6 PRDs a year. |
| EXTERNAL | no |
| PROBLEMS | • P-002 |
| BASIS | Assumed, not researched, as section 1's evidence note says. Q-023 tests it with three delivery leads. |
| CONTEXT | Runs the story-mapping workshop from the approved set (ST-007, ST-008). |
| GOALS | • Walk into the workshop with a backbone already agreed<br>• Trace every story back to something the expert actually said |
| PAINS | • No journey means no backbone, so the workshop invents one in the room<br>• Stories that trace to nothing, so nobody can say why they exist |
| FREQUENCY | Once per release, about 6 workshops a year per organization, plus refinement. |
| AUTHORITY | Decides the backlog's shape and order, and decides whether a backlog can be mapped from a set at all; does not decide scope. |
| PROFICIENCY | Expert in agile delivery; depends entirely on the PRD for the domain. |

SECTION 5

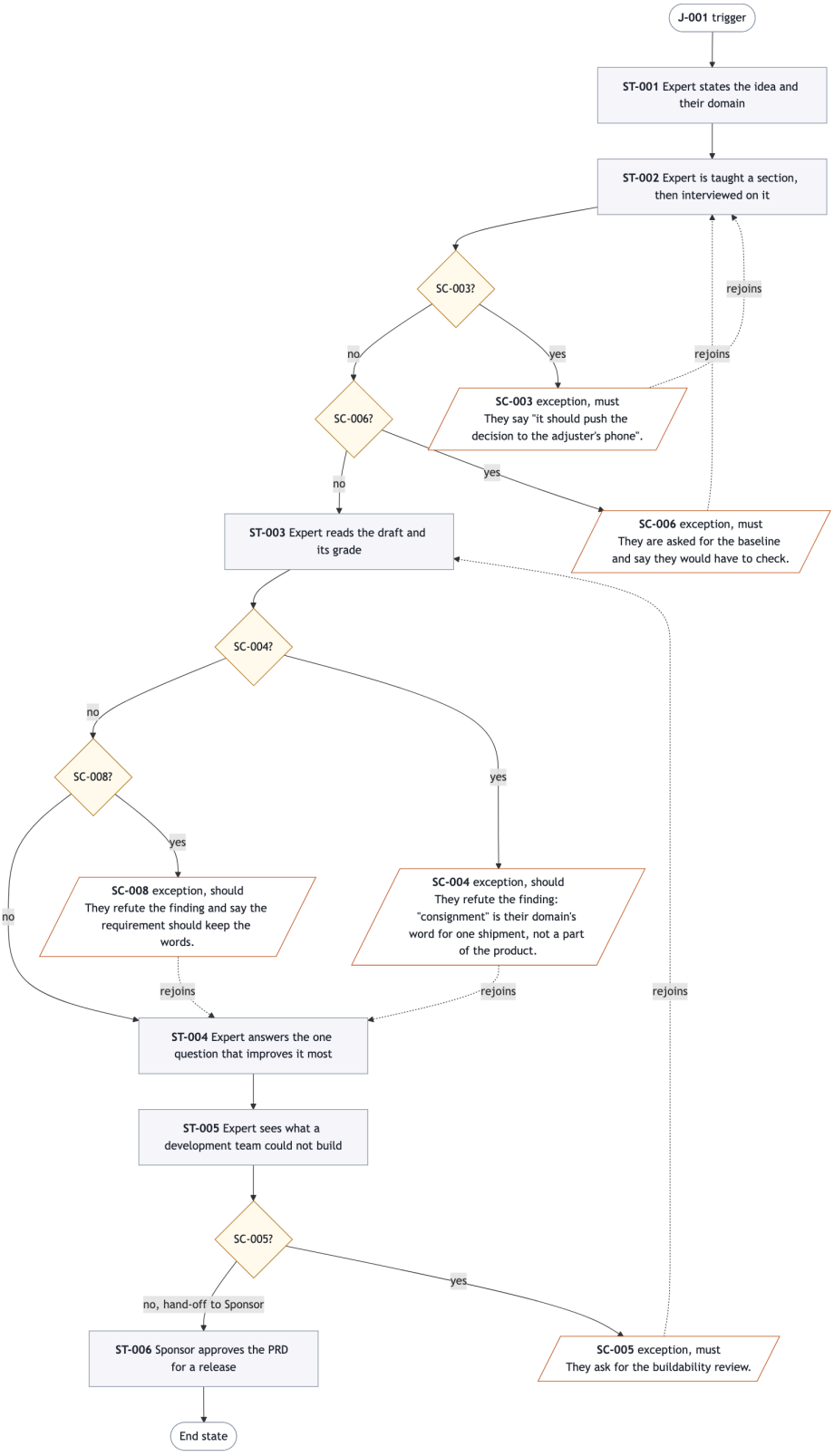
# User journeys

DRAFT 94/100 NO BLOCKING DEFECTS

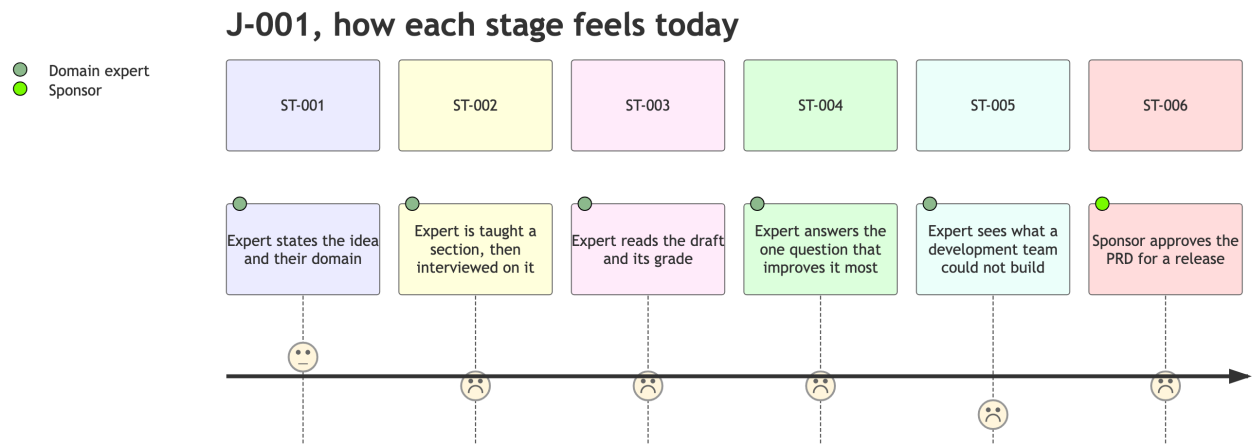
## J-001 - A domain expert reaches an approved PRD whose gaps are known (golden thread)




J-001 journey diagram




J-001 overview with its main alternate and exception paths




J-001 satisfaction

Persona PER-001. Trigger: they have been asked to specify a product and have nothing written. Stages ST-001 to ST-006.

| STAGE | ACTOR | DECISION |
|---|---|---|
| ST-001 States the idea and the domain | Domain expert | What this is, and the domain's own words |
| ST-002 Taught a section, then interviewed | Domain expert | Have the questions reached the end of what they know |
| ST-003 Reads the draft and its grade | Domain expert | Accept, correct, or refute the grade |
| ST-004 Answers the one question that matters most | Domain expert | Is this section done enough to leave |
| ST-005 Sees what a team could not build | Domain expert | May the set be offered to someone who will commit |
| ST-006 Sponsor approves for a release, outside the product | Sponsor | Approve, approve with conditions, or reject |

ST-002 to ST-004 are a loop, run once per section. The loop is the whole product: the expert is taught, asked, shown a draft, shown a grade, and asked one more thing.

End state: approved, with or without recorded conditions, at a named version, every section graded with nothing blocking, every open question with a decider and a date, and no buildability gap left that is neither closed nor owned.

In release 1, ST-006 happens outside the product. The sponsor reads the root document or an exported copy and gives a decision. The expert records it in section 15 under FR-014, with the sponsor's name, role, and date (section 6).

### How each stage feels today

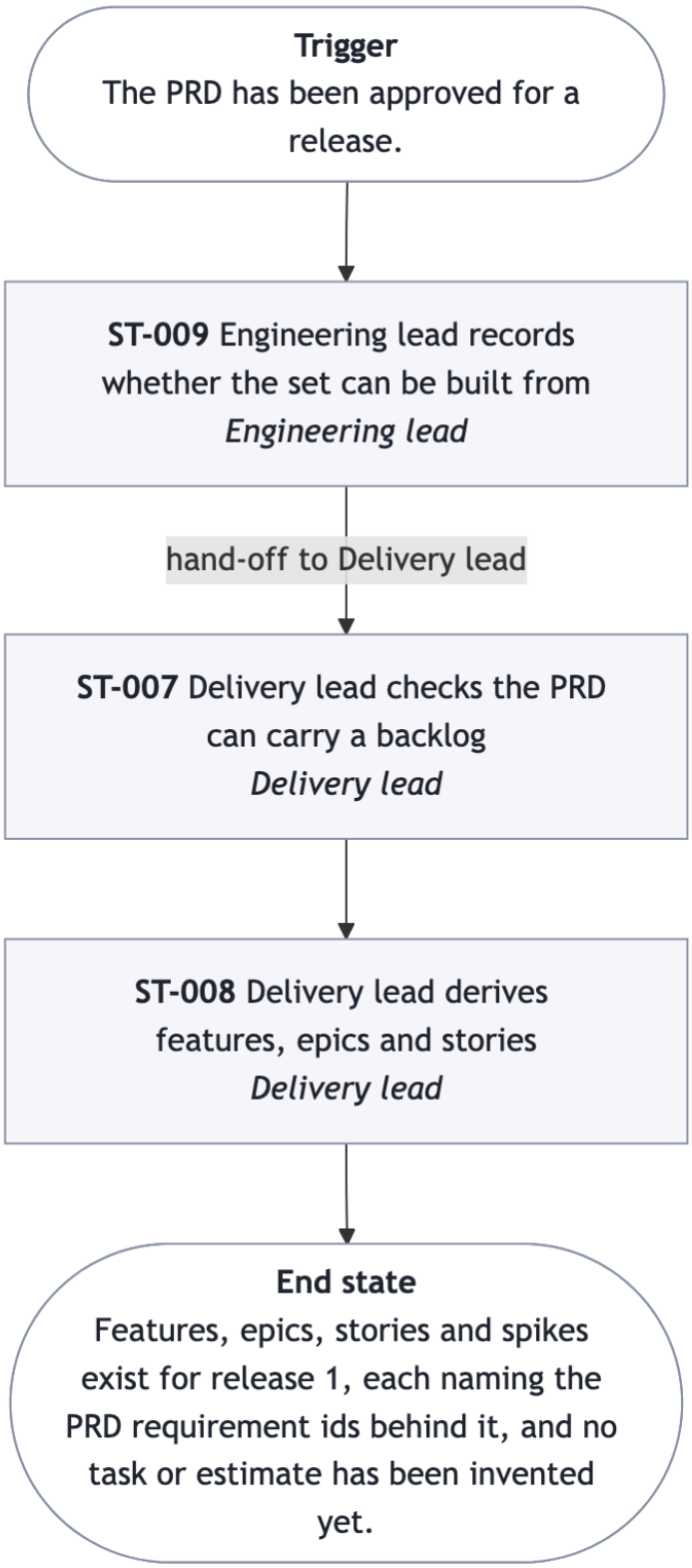
Each stage is scored from 1 (bad) to 5 (good) for how it feels today, without this product. The scores are the expert's.

| STAGE | SCORE | PAIN POINT BEHIND IT |
|---|---|---|
| ST-001 | 3 | None. Stating the idea comes naturally. |
| ST-002 | 2 | Headings filled with adjectives, and software names in place of needs |
| ST-003 | 2 | Cannot tell whether what was written is good |
| ST-004 | 2 | Put down for a week and cannot remember where they were |

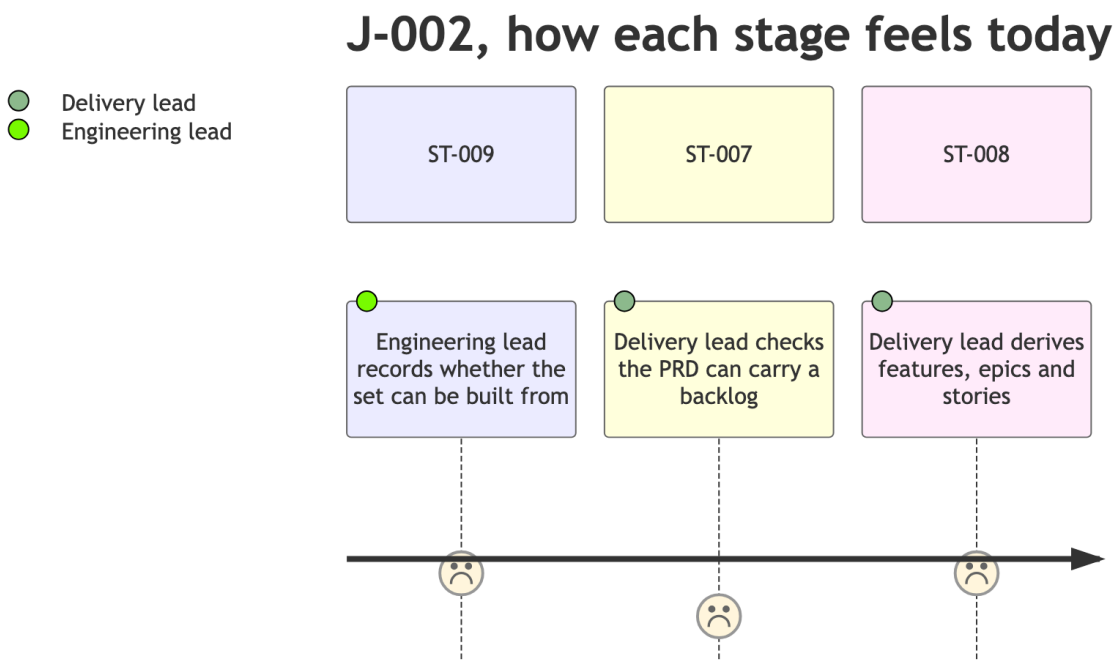
| STAGE | SCORE | PAIN POINT BEHIND IT |
|---|---|---|
| ST-005 | 1 | Nobody says the requirements are untestable until a team tries to build them |
| ST-006 | 2 | The sponsor can only judge whether it reads well |
| ST-009 | 2 | Gaps between two requirements that both looked complete |
| ST-007 | 1 | The workshop invents a backbone in the room |
| ST-008 | 2 | Stories trace to nothing, and constraints arrive late |

The goal deliberately does not claim an engineering lead's confirmation. No stage in ST-001 to ST-006 puts one in the actor seat, so claiming it would promise something the release line cannot deliver. A lead's own recorded confirmation is OUT-004, deferred to release 2 with J-002, where it is stage ST-009.

**J-002 - A delivery lead derives a backlog (not the golden thread)**




J-002 journey diagram




J-002 satisfaction

Persona PER-004, stages ST-009, ST-007, and ST-008. In ST-009 the engineering lead, PER-002, reads the report of the buildability review and records their own verdict under TR-006, before the delivery lead takes over. ST-009 was added at 0.8.1, after ST-008, and ids are never renumbered. Release 1 does not have to complete this journey (see section 6), but the PRD must carry what it needs, which is what ST-007 checks.

### What these journeys deliberately do not say

No stage says where the teaching text comes from, how a grade is computed, or what reviews the set in ST-005. Those are mechanisms. Every stage above names a person, what they do and see, and what they decide.

#### J-001

| | |
|---|---|
| GOAL | An approved PRD whose buildability gaps have been found and either closed or given a decider and a date, before anyone estimates it. |
| PERSONA | PER-001 |
| TRIGGER | The expert has been asked to specify a product, or has an idea they want built, and has nothing written down. |
| GOLDEN THREAD | yes |
| OBJECTIVES | • O-001<br>• O-002<br>• O-003 |

STAGES

### Expert states the idea and their domain

| | |
|---|---|
| ID | ST-001 |
| ACTOR | Domain expert |
| SATISFACTION | 3 |
| ACCEPTANCE | • Given an expert with an idea and nothing written down, when they state the idea, the domain, and three words an outsider would misread, then they see a document set with every section listed and marked as not yet started. |
| STEPS | • Says what they want built, in their own words, however roughly<br>• Is asked what the business domain is and what the unit of work is called, such as a load, a claim, or a case<br>• Names three words their team uses that an outsider would misread<br>• Sees that a set of documents now exists, every section listed and marked as not yet started |
| INPUTS | • The idea, the domain, and the vocabulary |
| OUTPUTS | • A document set with every section visible and honestly marked empty |
| DECISION | What this product is, and what the domain's own words are |

### Expert is taught a section, then interviewed on it

| | |
|---|---|
| ID | ST-002 |
| ACTOR | Domain expert |
| SATISFACTION | 2 |
| ACCEPTANCE | • Given a section not yet interviewed, when the expert reads what it is for and answers its questions one or two at a time, then the interview ends when the question list is finished, when they are told the section already meets the gate, or when they say they have nothing more to add, and they see the section drafted. |
| STEPS | • Reads what the section is, why it matters, and what belongs in it, in under ten lines, with an example from their own domain<br>• Is asked one or two questions at a time, in their own vocabulary<br>• Is asked follow-ups where an answer was thin<br>• Says when they have nothing more to add |
| INPUTS | • Their knowledge of the domain, in answer to each question |
| OUTPUTS | • The answers the section is drafted from |
| DECISION | Whether the questions have reached the end of what they know |

### Expert reads the draft and its grade

| | |
|---|---|
| ID | ST-003 |
| ACTOR | Domain expert |
| SATISFACTION | 2 |
| ACCEPTANCE | • Given a drafted and graded section, when the expert opens it, then they read it as prose and see its score, each blocking defect, and its weakest part. |

| | |
|---|---|
| STEPS | • Reads the drafted section as prose, not as a form<br>• Sees a score, how many blocking defects there are, and what each one is<br>• Sees which part of the section is weakest, and why<br>• Decides whether the grade is fair |
| INPUTS | • The drafted section and its grade |
| OUTPUTS | • A judgement on whether the draft says what they meant |
| DECISION | Accept the draft, correct it, or refute the grade |

**Expert answers the one question that improves it most**

| | |
|---|---|
| ID | ST-004 |
| ACTOR | Domain expert |
| SATISFACTION | 2 |
| ACCEPTANCE | • Given one question about the weakest part of a section, when the expert answers it, then they see the section re-graded against the same rubric.<br>• Given one question whose premise the expert says is wrong, when they say why, then the finding behind the question is checked against the document as a refutation under FR-016, and they see whether it was dropped.<br>• Given an expert returning after a break, when they say they want to carry on, then they resume at the first section not yet at review, and no question they already answered is put to them again. |
| STEPS | • Reads a single question, not a list of twelve<br>• Answers it, or says why the premise is wrong<br>• Sees the section re-graded against the same rubric<br>• Moves to the next section, or goes back to an earlier one when this section showed it was incomplete<br>• Stops when they need to, and later resumes at the first section not yet at review |
| INPUTS | • One answer |
| OUTPUTS | • A section at a grade the expert accepts, and a set that is one section further on |
| DECISION | Whether this section is done enough to leave |
| HANDOFF | Back into ST-002 for the next section, until every section has been through this loop. |

**Expert sees what a development team could not build**

| | |
|---|---|
| ID | ST-005 |
| ACTOR | Domain expert |
| SATISFACTION | 1 |

| | |
|---|---|
| ACCEPTANCE | • Given a set with every section written at least once, when the expert asks for a buildability review, then they see what an engineer could not build and which release-line stages have no requirement behind them.<br>• Given a gap the buildability review reports, when the expert does not close it, then they see it recorded as an open question with a decider and a date. |
| STEPS | • Asks for a buildability review of the whole set, read as an engineer would<br>• Sees what an engineer could not build, and what they would have to guess<br>• Sees which release-line stages have no requirement behind them<br>• Closes each gap, or records it as an open question with a decider and a date<br>• Offers the set to the sponsor for approval |
| INPUTS | • Every section written at least once, so there is something to review |
| OUTPUTS | • A list of what is not buildable, and a set with each gap closed or owned |
| DECISION | May the set be offered to someone who will commit to it |
| HANDOFF | Sponsor, who receives the set offered for approval as its root document or an exported copy. |

**Sponsor approves the PRD for a release**

| | |
|---|---|
| ID | ST-006 |
| ACTOR | Sponsor |
| SATISFACTION | 2 |
| ACCEPTANCE | • Given a set offered for approval, when the sponsor approves, approves with conditions, or rejects it, and the expert records the decision, then the sponsor sees the decision, their name, their role, and the date recorded against the set's version. |
| STEPS | • Reads the root document or an exported copy, outside the product<br>• Sees the summary, the scope, what is still open, each section's grade, and whether anything is still blocking<br>• Approves, approves with conditions naming what the condition is, or rejects, and tells the expert<br>• Sees the expert record the decision in section 15 against this version |
| INPUTS | • The set offered for approval, as its root document or an exported copy |
| OUTPUTS | • An approved PRD at a named version, with the approval recorded |
| DECISION | Approve, approve with conditions, or reject |
| HANDOFF | Engineering lead, to record a verdict on the approved set in ST-009 |

PAIN POINTS

| | |
|---|---|
| PAIN | I do not know what the section is for, so I fill the heading with adjectives |
| STAGE | ST-002 |
| NEED | Teach me the section before you ask me about it, in my own domain |
| PAIN | Nobody tells me my requirements are untestable until a team tries to build them |
| STAGE | ST-005 |
| NEED | Show me, before anyone builds, what an engineer cannot build |
| PAIN | I reach for the names of software I have used |
| STAGE | ST-002 |
| NEED | Convert my technology talk into the need underneath it, without arguing |
| PAIN | I put this down for a week and cannot remember where I was |
| STAGE | ST-004 |
| NEED | Let me stop and resume without starting over |
| PAIN | I cannot tell whether what I have written is good |
| STAGE | ST-003 |
| NEED | Tell me where it is weak, against a stated standard, and ask me one thing |
| PAIN | As the sponsor, I can only judge whether it reads well |
| STAGE | ST-006 |
| NEED | Show the sponsor each grade and every blocking defect before they decide |

NEEDS

- Teach me the section before you ask me about it, in my own domain
- Tell me where it is weak, against a stated standard, and ask me one thing
- Convert my technology talk into the need underneath it, without arguing
- Let me stop and resume without starting over
- Show me, before anyone builds, what an engineer cannot build
- Show the sponsor each grade and every blocking defect before they decide

END STATE

The set is approved, with or without recorded conditions, at a named version, every section has a grade with no blocking defects, every open question has a decider and a date, and the buildability review reports no gap that is neither closed nor owned.

### J-002 · A backlog whose every story traces to a requirement the expert actually stated.

PERSONA

PER-004

TRIGGER

The PRD has been approved for a release.

OBJECTIVES

- O-001

STAGES

### Engineering lead records whether the set can be built from

| | |
|---|---|
| ID | ST-009 |
| ACTOR | Engineering lead |
| SATISFACTION | 2 |
| ACCEPTANCE | • Given an approved set and the report of its buildability review, when the engineering lead records a verdict that differs from the report's, then they see their verdict recorded as the verdict, with the report kept alongside it.<br>• Given an approved set and the report of its buildability review, when the engineering lead records a verdict that agrees with the report's, then they see their verdict recorded with the report.<br>• Given a gap in the set, when the engineering lead records it, then they see the document quoted for it. |
| STEPS | • Reads the report of the buildability review, its verdict, and the gaps it quotes<br>• Checks each reported gap against the document it quotes<br>• Records their own verdict on whether the set can be built from |
| INPUTS | • An approved set and the report of its buildability review |
| OUTPUTS | • The engineering lead's own recorded verdict, with the report kept alongside it |
| DECISION | Can a team build from this set |
| HANDOFF | The delivery lead, to check the PRD can carry a backlog |

### Delivery lead checks the PRD can carry a backlog

| | |
|---|---|
| ID | ST-007 |
| ACTOR | Delivery lead |
| SATISFACTION | 1 |
| ACCEPTANCE | • Given an approved set and the release it is mapped for, when the delivery lead checks it, then they see whether a golden-thread journey exists and what would block deriving a backlog.<br>• Given an approved set with no journey, when the delivery lead checks it, then they see a no-go, with the reason that a backlog cannot be derived, and the workshop waits. |
| STEPS | • Sees whether a journey exists and which one is the golden thread<br>• Sees which release-line stages have requirements behind them<br>• Sees what would block deriving a backlog, before the workshop |
| INPUTS | • An approved set, and the release it is being mapped for |
| OUTPUTS | • A go or no-go on holding the story-mapping workshop |
| DECISION | Is there a backbone to map against |

### Delivery lead derives features, epics and stories

| | |
|---|---|
| ID | ST-008 |
| ACTOR | Delivery lead |
| SATISFACTION | 2 |

| | |
|---|---|
| ACCEPTANCE | • Given an approved set, when the delivery lead derives a backlog from it, then they see one feature per journey stage, epics scoped by the release line, and a story per requirement, each naming the id it came from. |
| STEPS | • Sees one feature per journey stage, with the requirement ids it carries<br>• Sees epics scoped by the release line<br>• Sees a story per requirement, in the persona's own words, with the requirement's criteria as its acceptance criteria<br>• Sees spikes for the open questions that block the release line<br>• Sees each non-functional requirement and constraint that applies to a story as a definition-of-done item on it |
| INPUTS | • The approved set |
| OUTPUTS | • A backlog whose every level names what it came from |
| DECISION | Which epics come first, and why |
| HANDOFF | The development team, for iteration planning |

**PAIN POINTS**

| | |
|---|---|
| PAIN | The workshop invents a backbone in the room because the PRD has none |
| STAGE | ST-007 |
| NEED | A journey to map against, agreed before the workshop |

| | |
|---|---|
| PAIN | Stories trace to nothing, so nobody can say why they exist |
| STAGE | ST-008 |
| NEED | Every story carrying the requirement id it came from |

| | |
|---|---|
| PAIN | Non-functional requirements and constraints are forgotten until late |
| STAGE | ST-008 |
| NEED | Constraints arriving as definition-of-done items, not as surprises |

| | |
|---|---|
| PAIN | As the engineering lead, I find gaps between two requirements that both looked complete |
| STAGE | ST-009 |
| NEED | Every gap quoted from the document, before the team estimates |

**NEEDS**

- A journey to map against, agreed before the workshop
- Every story carrying the requirement id it came from
- Constraints arriving as definition-of-done items, not as surprises
- Every gap quoted from the document, before the team estimates

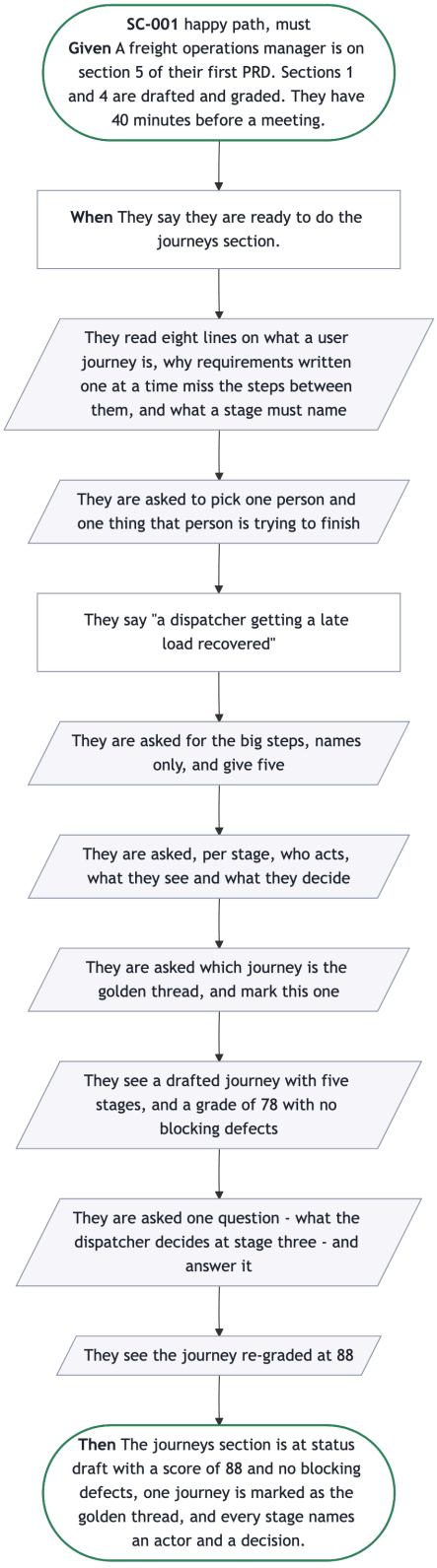
**END STATE**

Features, epics, stories and spikes exist for release 1, each naming the PRD requirement ids behind it, and no task or estimate has been invented yet.

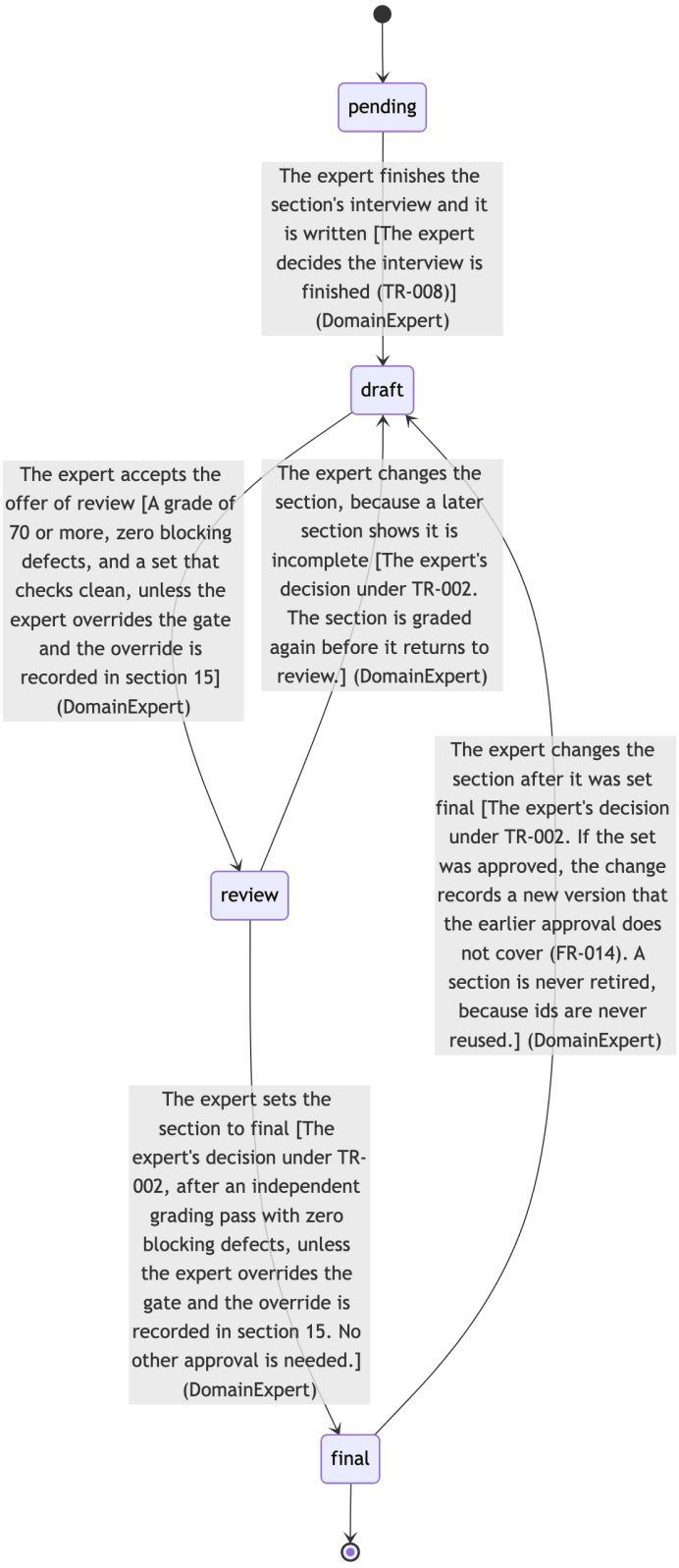
SECTION 5

# Scenarios

DRAFT 89/100 NO BLOCKING DEFECTS

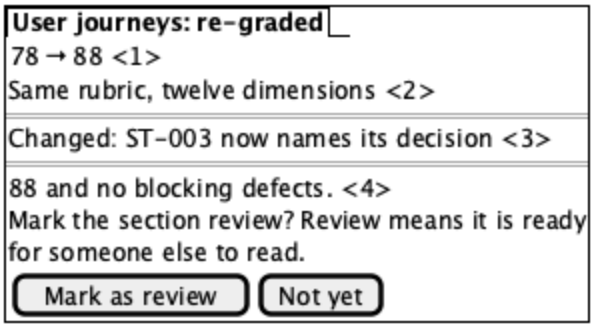



SC-001 scenario

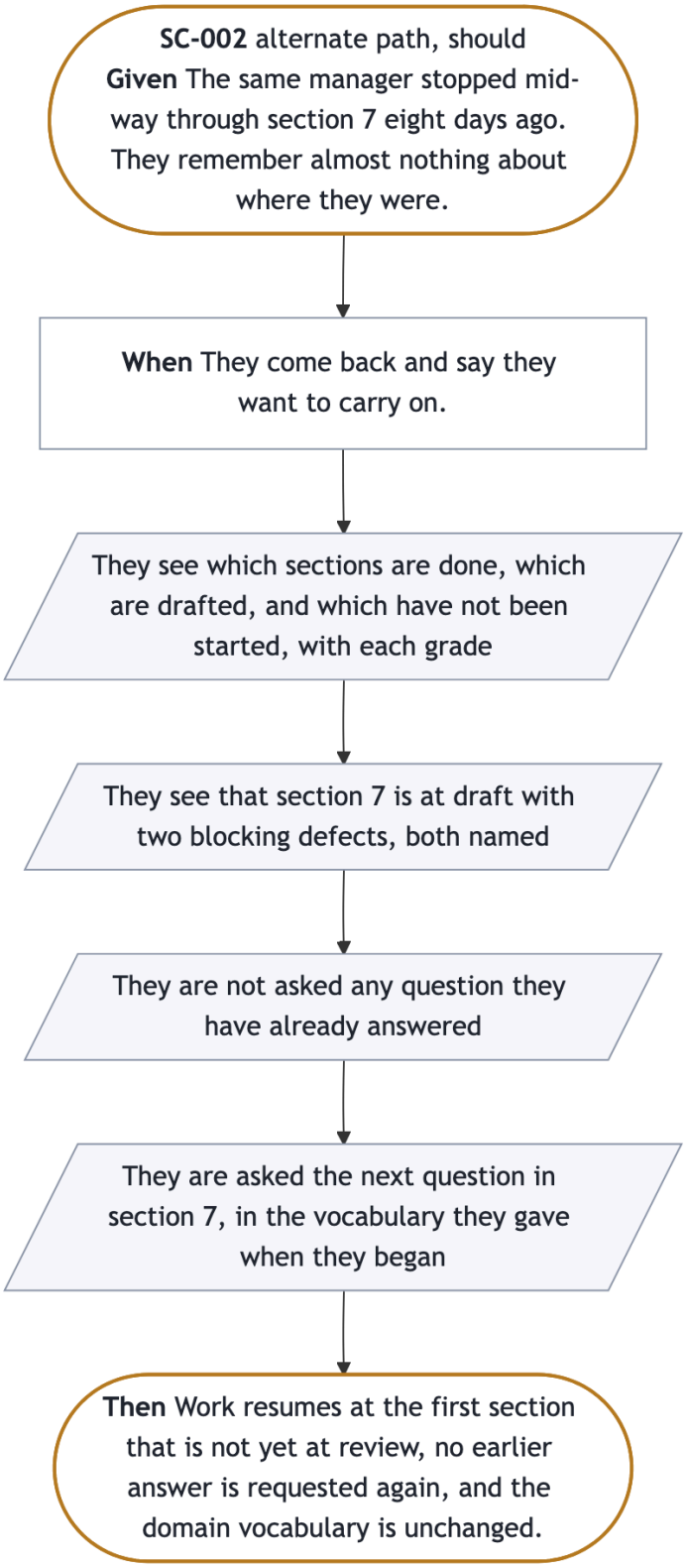



LC-001 lifecycle of a section of the PRD

## WF-008 A section re-graded after one answer

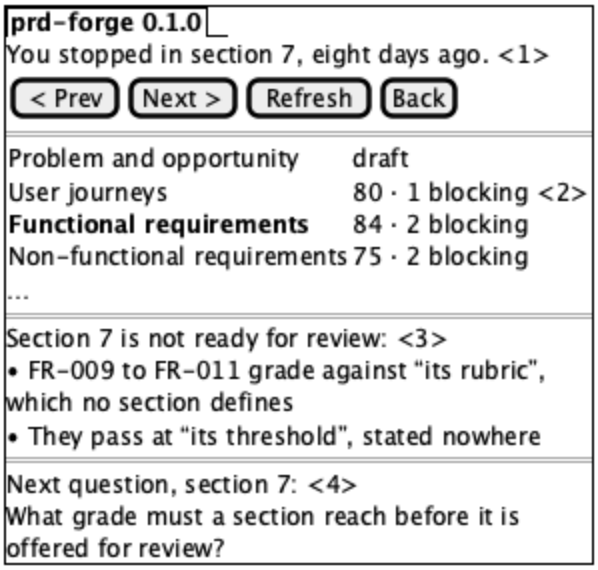



WF-008 drawing

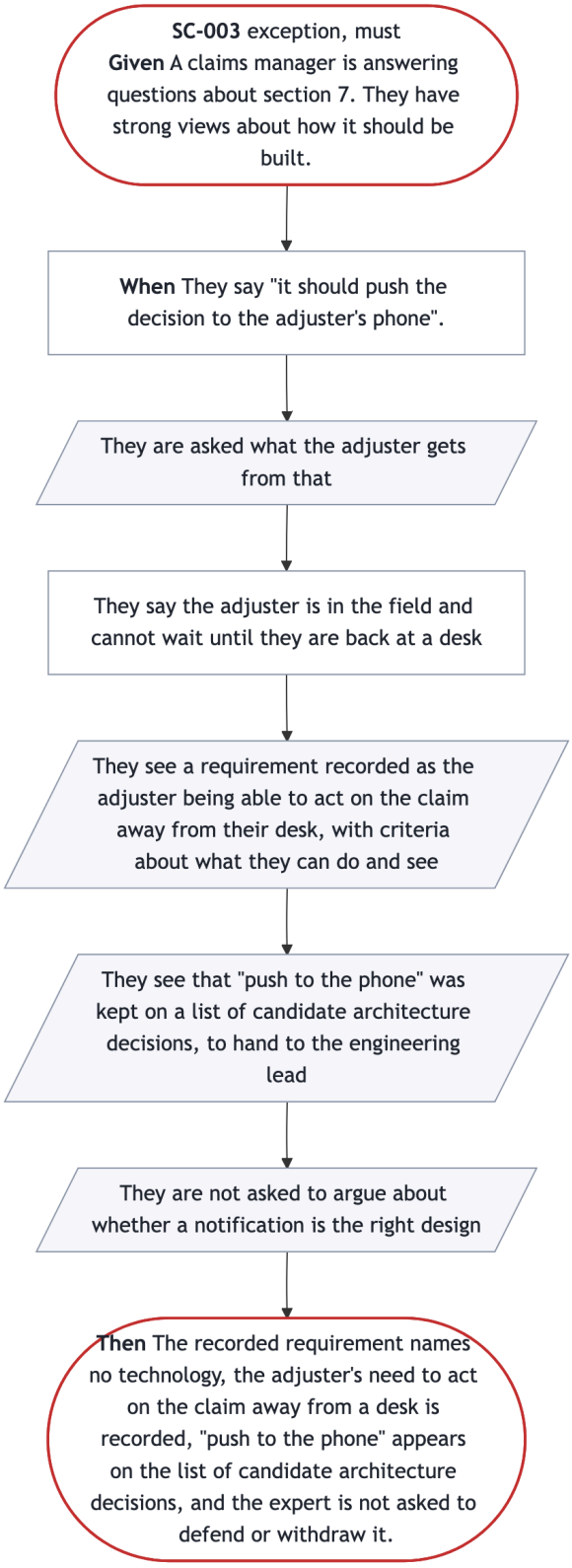



SC-002 scenario

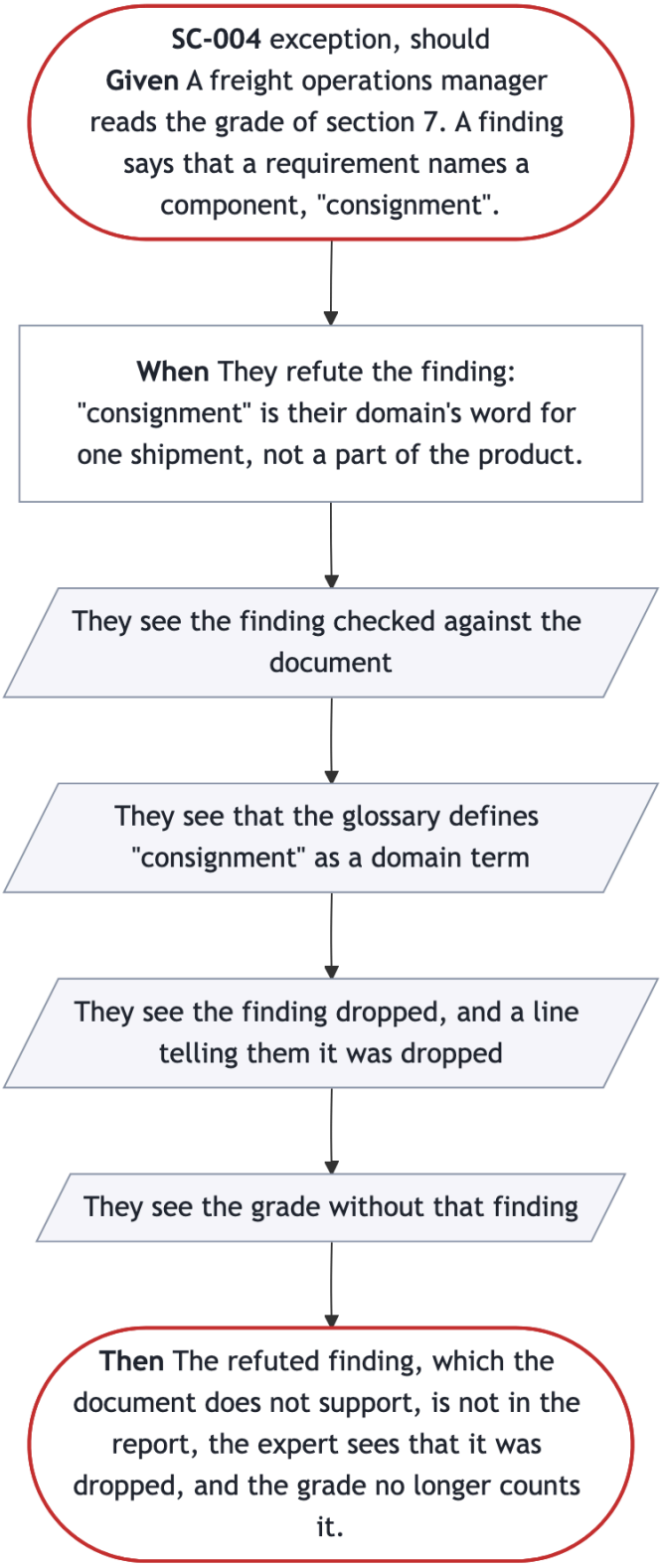
## WF-010 Resuming a set after a week away



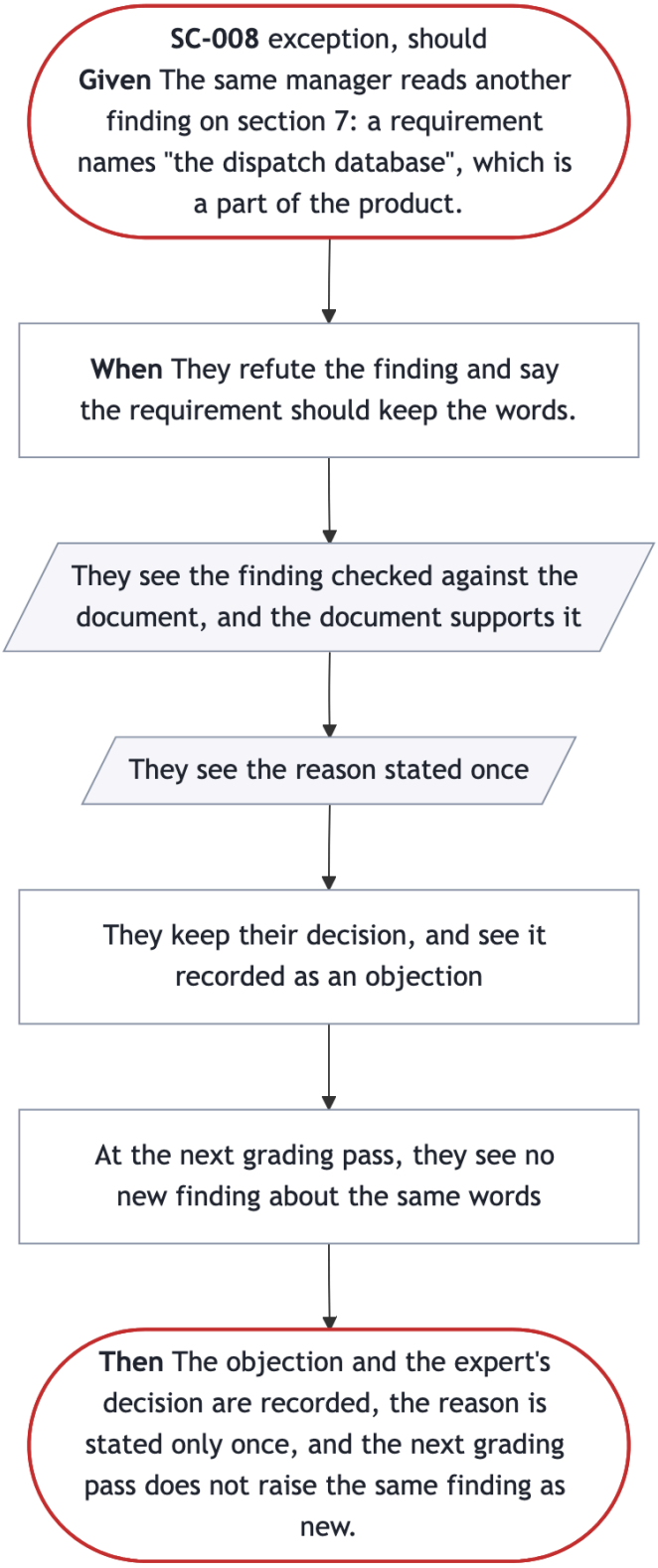

WF-010 drawing



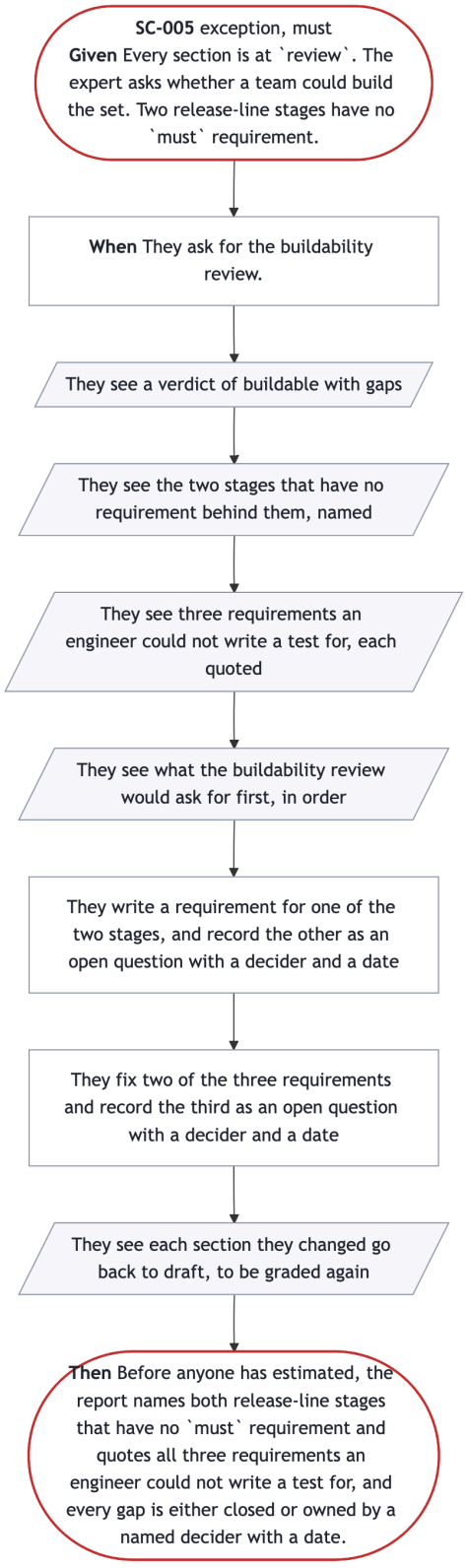

SC-003 scenario




SC-004 scenario




SC-008 scenario




SC-005 scenario

## WF-009 A buildability review that finds gaps

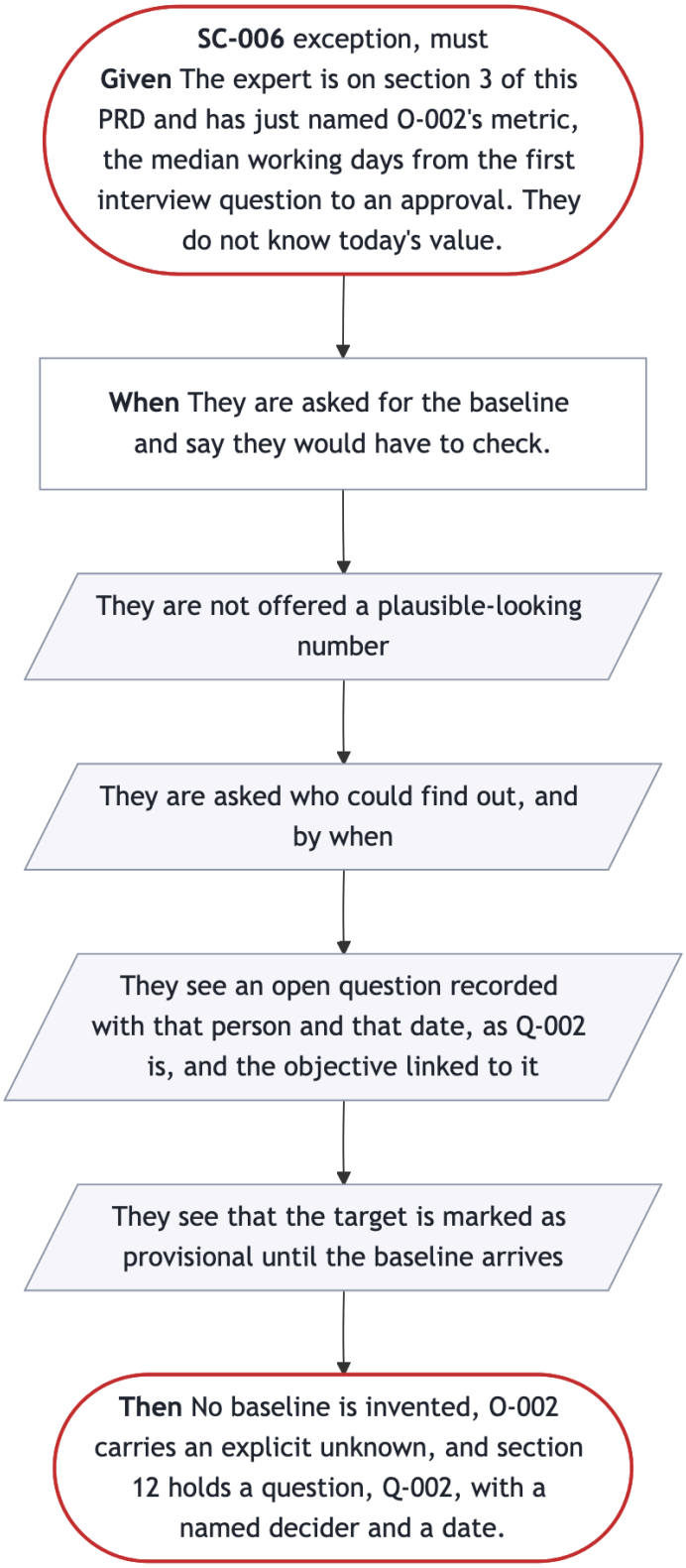
| What a team could not build from this set |
| --- |
| Buildable with gaps. <1> |
| ✗ ST-004 no must requirement <2><br>✗ ST-005 no must requirement<br>✓ ST-001, ST-002, ST-003, ST-006 |
| Each gap becomes a requirement, or an open question with a decider and a date. <3> |

WF-009 drawing

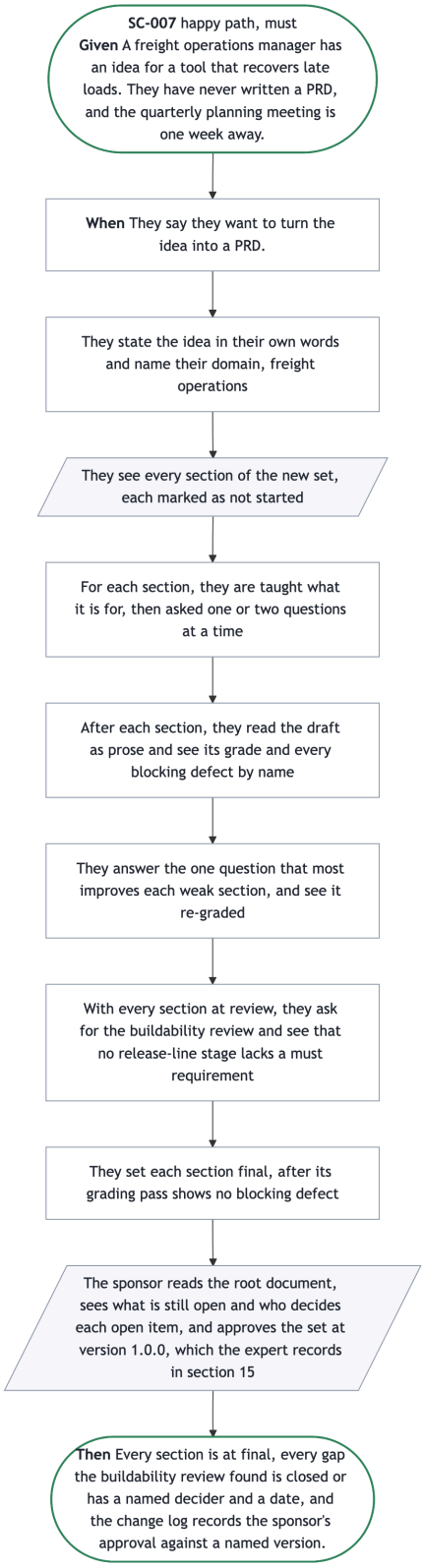
## WF-005 What a team could not build from this set

| What a team could not build from this set |
| --- |
| prd-forge PRD 0.4.0. Buildable with gaps. <1> |
| Release line <2><br>✓ ST-001 FR-001, FR-002, FR-015<br>✓ ST-003 FR-008, FR-009, FR-016, FR-017, FR-018<br>✓ ST-006 FR-013, FR-014<br>… |
| Cannot write a test from <3><br>1. FR-004: “two ways differing in meaning", no judge<br>2. FR-014: no test for a rejection |
| Blocked by an open question <4><br>Q-009 blocks FR-012: which rubric version applies.<br>Richard Hightower, by 2027-01-31 |
| Ask for first <5><br>1. Who judges FR-004's two meanings |

WF-005 drawing

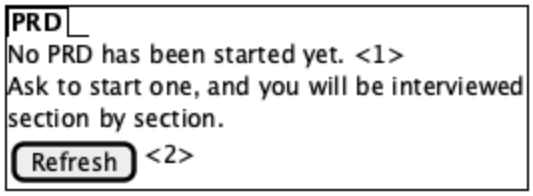



SC-006 scenario



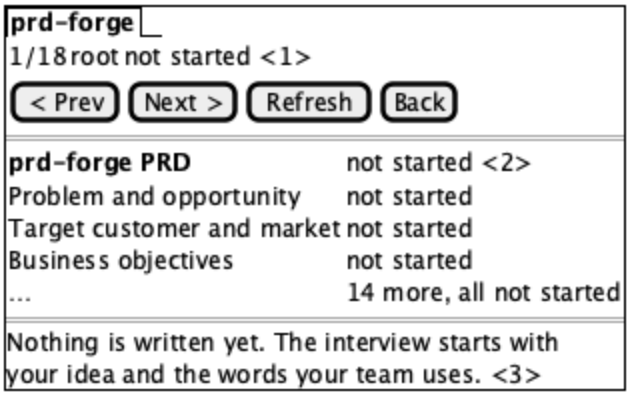

SC-007 scenario

### WF-007 Before any set exists



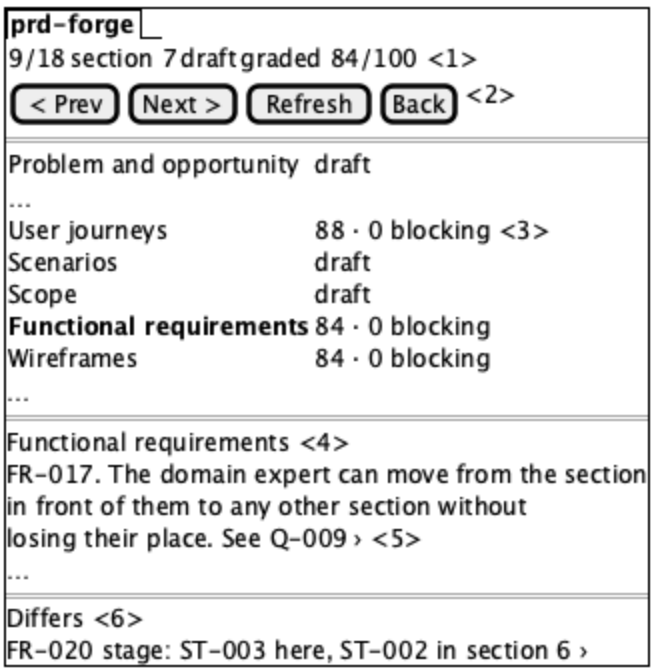

WF-007 drawing

### WF-002 A new set, before the first interview



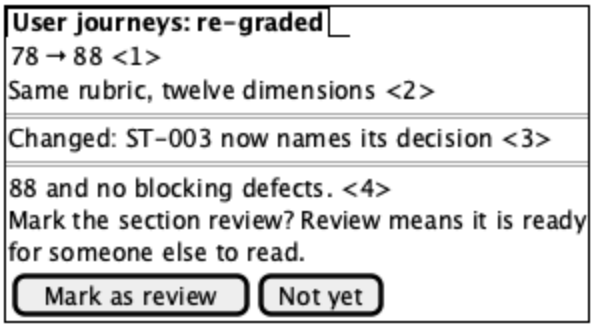

WF-002 drawing

### WF-001 The set with one section open



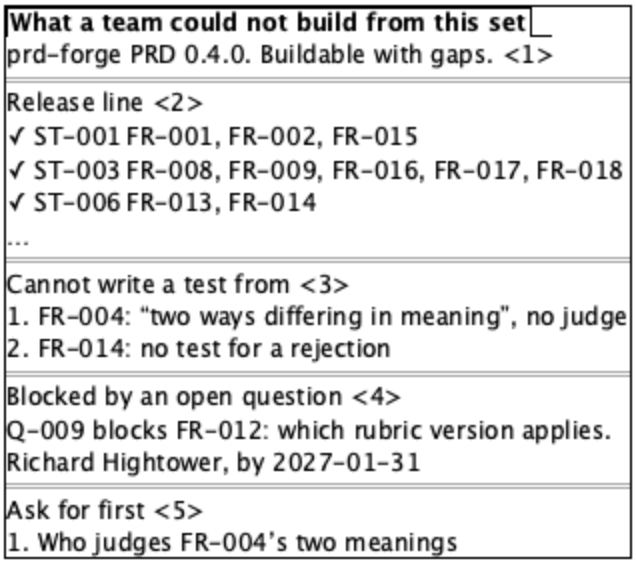

WF-001 drawing

### WF-008 A section re-graded after one answer

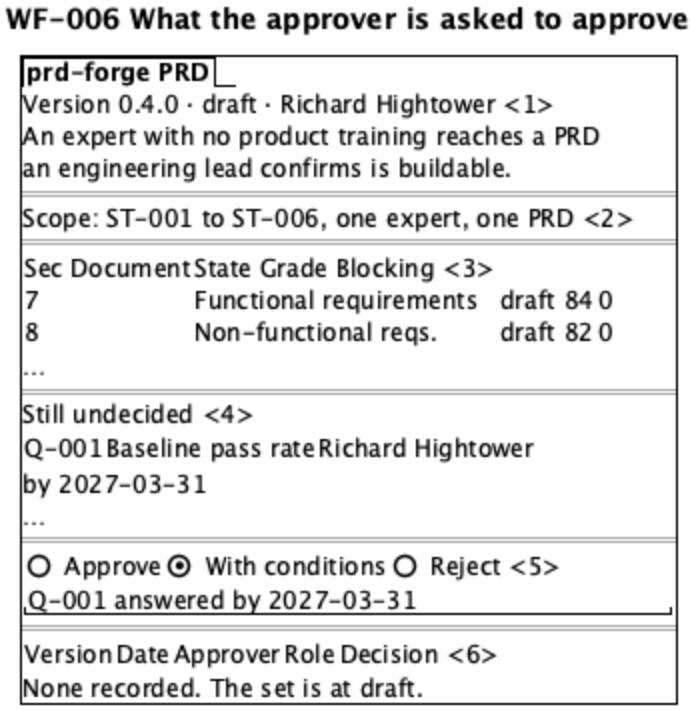



WF-008 drawing

### WF-005 What a team could not build from this set




WF-005 drawing




WF-006 drawing

| ID | STAGE | VARIANT | PRIORITY | WHAT IT COVERS |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| SC-001 | ST-002 | happy | must | A section taught, interviewed, drafted, graded, improved |
| SC-002 | ST-004 | alternate | should | Resuming after eight days away |
| SC-003 | ST-002 | exception | must | The expert states a technology |
| SC-004 | ST-003 | exception | should | The expert refutes a finding that the document does not support |
| SC-005 | ST-005 | exception | must | The buildability review finds gaps |
| SC-006 | ST-002 | exception | must | The expert has no baseline for a metric |
| SC-007 | ST-001 to ST-006 | happy | must | One idea, from the first sentence to an approved set |
| SC-008 | ST-003 | exception | should | The expert refutes a finding that the document supports |

SC-007 is the end-to-end acceptance test for release 1: it follows the golden thread through every release-line stage. SC-001 is the same path inside one section. SC-005 is the expert's own run of the buildability review, which is why its persona is PER-001 and not the engineering lead: no engineering lead is in release 1 at all, per OUT-004.

The priorities follow the requirements. SC-002, SC-004, and SC-008 are `should`, because FR-015 and FR-016, which they exercise, are `should`.

SC-001 and SC-007 are first use, and SC-002 is a return after time away. No scenario has two experts on one set at once, which OUT-002 defers to a later release. A sponsor reading the set while the expert changes it is covered by FR-014: the change records a new version that the earlier approval does not cover.

The five exceptions are the ones that decide whether this product is trustworthy. SC-003 and SC-006 are where a PRD quietly acquires a technology choice or an invented fact. SC-004 and SC-008 are where the grading either earns the

expert's trust or loses it: a grading pass that cannot be refuted is one nobody believes. SC-005 is the moment the product is supposed to pay for itself.

## Scenarios

### SC-001

| | |
|---|---|
| CONTEXT | A freight operations manager is on section 5 of their first PRD. Sections 1 and 4 are drafted and graded. They have 40 minutes before a meeting. |
| JOURNEY | J-001 |
| STAGE | ST-002 |
| STAGES | • ST-002<br>• ST-003<br>• ST-004 |
| PERSONA | PER-001 |
| VARIANT | happy |
| PRIORITY | must |
| SITUATION | first-use |
| SHOWN IN | screen |
| LIFECYCLES | • LC-001 |
| WIREFRAMES | • WF-008 |
| TRIGGER | They say they are ready to do the journeys section. |
| COURSE | • They read eight lines on what a user journey is, why requirements written one at a time miss the steps between them, and what a stage must name<br>• They are asked to pick one person and one thing that person is trying to finish<br>• They say "a dispatcher getting a late load recovered"<br>• They are asked for the big steps, names only, and give five<br>• They are asked, per stage, who acts, what they see and what they decide<br>• They are asked which journey is the golden thread, and mark this one<br>• They see a drafted journey with five stages, and a grade of 78 with no blocking defects<br>• They are asked one question - what the dispatcher decides at stage three - and answer it<br>• They see the journey re-graded at 88 |
| EXPECTED OUTCOME | The journeys section is at status draft with a score of 88 and no blocking defects, one journey is marked as the golden thread, and every stage names an actor and a decision. |

## SC-002

**CONTEXT**
The same manager stopped mid-way through section 7 eight days ago. They remember almost nothing about where they were.

**BRANCHES FROM**

| | |
|---|---|
| SCENARIO | SC-007 |
| STEP | 5 |

**JOURNEY** J-001

**STAGE** ST-004

**REJOINS** ST-004

**PERSONA** PER-001

**VARIANT** alternate

**PRIORITY** should

**SITUATION** return

**SHOWN IN** screen

**LIFECYCLES**
- LC-001

**WIREFRAMES**
- WF-010

**TRIGGER**
They come back and say they want to carry on.

**COURSE**
- They see which sections are done, which are drafted, and which have not been started, with each grade
- They see that section 7 is at draft with two blocking defects, both named
- They are not asked any question they have already answered
- They are asked the next question in section 7, in the vocabulary they gave when they began

**EXPECTED OUTCOME**
Work resumes at the first section that is not yet at review, no earlier answer is requested again, and the domain vocabulary is unchanged.

## SC-003

**CONTEXT**
A claims manager is answering questions about section 7. They have strong views about how it should be built.

**BRANCHES FROM**

| | |
|---|---|
| SCENARIO | SC-007 |
| STEP | 3 |

**JOURNEY** J-001

**STAGE** ST-002

**REJOINS** ST-002

**PERSONA** PER-001

**VARIANT** exception

**PRIORITY** must

**SHOWN IN** conversation

**TRIGGER**
They say "it should push the decision to the adjuster's phone".

COURSE

- They are asked what the adjuster gets from that
- They say the adjuster is in the field and cannot wait until they are back at a desk
- They see a requirement recorded as the adjuster being able to act on the claim away from their desk, with criteria about what they can do and see
- They see that "push to the phone" was kept on a list of candidate architecture decisions, to hand to the engineering lead
- They are not asked to argue about whether a notification is the right design

EXPECTED OUTCOME

The recorded requirement names no technology, the adjuster's need to act on the claim away from a desk is recorded, "push to the phone" appears on the list of candidate architecture decisions, and the expert is not asked to defend or withdraw it.

## SC-004

CONTEXT

A freight operations manager reads the grade of section 7. A finding says that a requirement names a component, "consignment".

BRANCHES FROM

| | |
|---|---|
| SCENARIO | SC-007 |
| STEP | 4 |

JOURNEY

J-001

STAGE

ST-003

REJOINS

ST-004

PERSONA

PER-001

VARIANT

exception

PRIORITY

should

SHOWN IN

conversation

TRIGGER

They refute the finding: "consignment" is their domain's word for one shipment, not a part of the product.

COURSE

- They see the finding checked against the document
- They see that the glossary defines "consignment" as a domain term
- They see the finding dropped, and a line telling them it was dropped
- They see the grade without that finding

EXPECTED OUTCOME

The refuted finding, which the document does not support, is not in the report, the expert sees that it was dropped, and the grade no longer counts it.

### SC-008

**CONTEXT**
The same manager reads another finding on section 7: a requirement names "the dispatch database", which is a part of the product.

**BRANCHES FROM**

| | |
|---|---|
| SCENARIO | SC-007 |
| STEP | 4 |

**JOURNEY** J-001

**STAGE** ST-003

**REJOINS** ST-004

**PERSONA** PER-001

**VARIANT** exception

**PRIORITY** should

**SHOWN IN** conversation

**TRIGGER**
They refute the finding and say the requirement should keep the words.

**COURSE**

- They see the finding checked against the document, and the document supports it
- They see the reason stated once
- They keep their decision, and see it recorded as an objection
- At the next grading pass, they see no new finding about the same words

**EXPECTED OUTCOME**
The objection and the expert's decision are recorded, the reason is stated only once, and the next grading pass does not raise the same finding as new.

### SC-005

**CONTEXT**
Every section is at `review`. The expert asks whether a team could build the set. Two release-line stages have no `must` requirement.

**BRANCHES FROM**

| | |
|---|---|
| SCENARIO | SC-007 |
| STEP | 6 |

**JOURNEY** J-001

**STAGE** ST-005

**REJOINS** ST-003

**PERSONA** PER-001

**VARIANT** exception

**PRIORITY** must

**SHOWN IN** report

**WIREFRAMES**

- WF-009
- WF-005

**TRIGGER**
They ask for the buildability review.

COURSE

- They see a verdict of buildable with gaps
- They see the two stages that have no requirement behind them, named
- They see three requirements an engineer could not write a test for, each quoted
- They see what the buildability review would ask for first, in order
- They write a requirement for one of the two stages, and record the other as an open question with a decider and a date
- They fix two of the three requirements and record the third as an open question with a decider and a date
- They see each section they changed go back to draft, to be graded again

EXPECTED OUTCOME

Before anyone has estimated, the report names both release-line stages that have no `must` requirement and quotes all three requirements an engineer could not write a test for, and every gap is either closed or owned by a named decider with a date.

## SC-006

CONTEXT

The expert is on section 3 of this PRD and has just named O-002's metric, the median working days from the first interview question to an approval. They do not know today's value.

BRANCHES FROM

| | |
|---|---|
| SCENARIO | SC-007 |
| STEP | 3 |

JOURNEY

J-001

STAGE

ST-002

REJOINS

ST-002

PERSONA

PER-001

VARIANT

exception

PRIORITY

must

SHOWN IN

conversation

TRIGGER

They are asked for the baseline and say they would have to check.

COURSE

- They are not offered a plausible-looking number
- They are asked who could find out, and by when
- They see an open question recorded with that person and that date, as Q-002 is, and the objective linked to it
- They see that the target is marked as provisional until the baseline arrives

EXPECTED OUTCOME

No baseline is invented, O-002 carries an explicit unknown, and section 12 holds a question, Q-002, with a named decider and a date.

## SC-007

CONTEXT

A freight operations manager has an idea for a tool that recovers late loads. They have never written a PRD, and the quarterly planning meeting is one week away.

JOURNEY

J-001

STAGE

ST-001

| | |
|---|---|
| **STAGES** | • ST-001<br>• ST-002<br>• ST-003<br>• ST-004<br>• ST-005<br>• ST-006 |
| **PERSONA** | PER-001 |
| **VARIANT** | happy |
| **PRIORITY** | must |
| **SITUATION** | first-use |
| **SHOWN IN** | screen |
| **LIFECYCLES** | • LC-001 |
| **WIREFRAMES** | • WF-007<br>• WF-002<br>• WF-001<br>• WF-008<br>• WF-005<br>• WF-006 |
| **TRIGGER** | They say they want to turn the idea into a PRD. |
| **COURSE** | • They state the idea in their own words and name their domain, freight operations<br>• They see every section of the new set, each marked as not started<br>• For each section, they are taught what it is for, then asked one or two questions at a time<br>• After each section, they read the draft as prose and see its grade and every blocking defect by name<br>• They answer the one question that most improves each weak section, and see it re-graded<br>• With every section at review, they ask for the buildability review and see that no release-line stage lacks a must requirement<br>• They set each section final, after its grading pass shows no blocking defect<br>• The sponsor reads the root document, sees what is still open and who decides each open item, and approves the set at version 1.0.0, which the expert records in section 15 |
| **EXPECTED OUTCOME** | Every section is at final, every gap the buildability review found is closed or has a named decider and a date, and the change log records the sponsor's approval against a named version. |

## Lifecycles

### LC-001 · a section of the PRD

**STATES**

**pending**

MEANING — Listed in the set and not yet interviewed.

**draft**

MEANING — Interviewed and written, and graded or waiting for a grade.

**review**

MEANING — Ready for someone other than the expert to read.

**final**

MEANING — Set final by the expert under TR-002.

**INITIAL** — pending

**FINAL**

- final

TRANSITIONS

| | |
|---|---|
| FROM | pending |
| TO | draft |
| WHEN | The expert finishes the section's interview and it is written |
| RULE | The expert decides the interview is finished (TR-008) |
| BY | PER-001 |

| | |
|---|---|
| FROM | draft |
| TO | review |
| WHEN | The expert accepts the offer of review |
| RULE | A grade of 70 or more, zero blocking defects, and a set that checks clean, unless the expert overrides the gate and the override is recorded in section 15 |
| BY | PER-001 |

| | |
|---|---|
| FROM | review |
| TO | final |
| WHEN | The expert sets the section to final |
| RULE | The expert's decision under TR-002, after an independent grading pass with zero blocking defects, unless the expert overrides the gate and the override is recorded in section 15. No other approval is needed. |
| BY | PER-001 |

| | |
|---|---|
| FROM | review |
| TO | draft |
| WHEN | The expert changes the section, because a later section shows it is incomplete |
| RULE | The expert's decision under TR-002. The section is graded again before it returns to review. |
| BY | PER-001 |

| | |
|---|---|
| FROM | final |
| TO | draft |
| WHEN | The expert changes the section after it was set final |
| RULE | The expert's decision under TR-002. If the set was approved, the change records a new version that the earlier approval does not cover (FR-014). A section is never retired, because ids are never reused. |
| BY | PER-001 |

SECTION 6

# Scope

DRAFT 88/100 NO BLOCKING DEFECTS

## Release line

ST-001 through ST-006 for one expert, one PRD, one golden-thread journey. The expert reaches J-001's end state: the set approved at a named version, every section graded with no blocking defects, every open question with a decider and a date, and no buildability gap that is neither closed nor owned.

ST-006 happens outside the product in REL-001. The sponsor reads the root document or an exported copy and gives a decision. Comments the sponsor leaves in an exported copy come back under FR-023. The expert records the decision in section 15 under FR-014, with the sponsor's name, role, and date.

| ID | IN SCOPE | STAGE | REQUIREMENTS |
|---|---|---|---|
| IN-001 | State the idea and vocabulary once, and see every section and its state | ST-001 | FR-001, FR-002 |
| IN-002 | Be taught each section, be asked one or two questions at a time, end early with gaps recorded, and stop once it would meet the gate | ST-002 | FR-003, FR-004, FR-005, FR-019 |
| IN-003 | Record no invented fact, and convert a stated technology into the need beneath it | ST-002 | FR-006, FR-007 |
| IN-004 | Read the draft with its grade, refute a finding, move to any section, refresh, and see one item stated two ways | ST-003 | FR-008, FR-009, FR-016, FR-017, FR-018, FR-020 |
| IN-005 | Answer one question, see the section re-graded, and resume without repeating an answer | ST-004 | FR-010, FR-011, FR-015 |
| IN-006 | See which release-line stages no requirement covers and which requirements cannot be tested | ST-005 | FR-012 |
| IN-007 | Name each approver, give the sponsor one document, bring back the sponsor's comments on it, and let the expert record their decision against a named version | ST-006 | FR-013, FR-014, FR-021, FR-022, FR-023 |

## Out of scope for REL-001

| ID | OUT OF SCOPE | REVISIT |
|---|---|---|
| OUT-001 | Deriving the backlog (J-002) | REL-002; the PRD already carries what it needs |
| OUT-002 | Two experts on one set at once | When three real engagements have each reached an approved set that passed the buildability review on first submission |
| OUT-003 | Any view beyond reading the documents and stepping through them beside the conversation | When two of the three sponsors in Q-005's spike say the root document is not enough |
| OUT-004 | An engineering lead's own recorded confirmation | REL-002, with J-002 |

| ID | OUT OF SCOPE | REVISIT |
|---|---|---|
| OUT-005 | A reviewer's comments inside the set, not on an exported copy | REL-003, when OUT-002's condition holds; until then, comments come back from an exported copy under FR-022 and FR-023 |

### Non-goals

| NON-GOAL | WHY NOT |
|---|---|
| Supplying domain knowledge | The expert has it; the product supplies product management |
| Deciding scope, priority, or whether to build | The expert decides; the product shows the consequences |
| A backlog's tasks, subtasks, estimates, or sizing | They come from engineering design, not from a PRD |
| Replacing the document store, issue tracker, or approval system, or being the system of record | The organization already stores and approves documents, and the PRD stays readable with no part of this product running (NFR-004) |
| A separate application to open, install, or log into | The expert works in short bursts, and a second place to open would split the work (D-001) |
| Certifying a PRD | A grade is evidence for the expert's judgement, never a warrant |

The first is the one that defines the product: **we do not supply domain knowledge.** Someone without the domain is not served by this and should not buy it. The last is the one that protects its users: **a grade is evidence, not a warrant.** A high score on a PRD for the wrong product is still the wrong product.

Two non-goals were constraints C-002 and C-001 in section 9 until 0.8.1. Product teams new to a domain, once segment S-003 in section 2, fall under the first non-goal: the product never supplies the domain.

### In scope

#### IN-001

SUMMARY: State the idea and the domain's vocabulary once, and see every section of the set and its state

JOURNEY STAGE: ST-001

REQUIREMENTS:
- FR-001
- FR-002

#### IN-002

SUMMARY: Be taught each section before its interview, be asked one or two questions at a time with follow-ups, end a section early with its gaps recorded, and stop being asked once the section would meet the gate

JOURNEY STAGE: ST-002

REQUIREMENTS:
- FR-003
- FR-004
- FR-005
- FR-019

### IN-003

**SUMMARY** Record no invented domain fact, and convert a stated technology into the need beneath it, kept for the engineering lead

**JOURNEY STAGE** ST-002

**REQUIREMENTS**

- FR-006
- FR-007

### IN-004

**SUMMARY** Read the draft as prose with its grade and every blocking defect, refute a finding, move to any section, refresh to see a change, and be told when the set states one item two ways

**JOURNEY STAGE** ST-003

**REQUIREMENTS**

- FR-008
- FR-009
- FR-016
- FR-017
- FR-018
- FR-020

### IN-005

**SUMMARY** Answer one question about the weakest part, see the section re-graded against the same rubric, and resume after a break without repeating an answer

**JOURNEY STAGE** ST-004

**REQUIREMENTS**

- FR-010
- FR-011
- FR-015

### IN-006

**SUMMARY** Get a buildability review of the whole set, read as an engineer would, and see which release-line stages no requirement covers and which requirements cannot be tested

**JOURNEY STAGE** ST-005

**REQUIREMENTS**

- FR-012

### IN-007

**SUMMARY** Let the expert name each approver, give the sponsor one document with the summary, the scope, the grades, and the open questions, bring the sponsor's comments on an exported copy back into the set with a response to each, and let the expert record the sponsor's decision, given outside the product, with any conditions, against a named version

**JOURNEY STAGE** ST-006

**REQUIREMENTS**

- FR-013
- FR-014
- FR-021
- FR-022
- FR-023

## Out of scope

### OUT-001 · Deriving features, epics and stories from the approved PRD - journey J-002

REVISIT — REL-002. The PRD must already carry what J-002 needs, which FR-012 checks, and nothing is lost by deferring the derivation itself.

### OUT-002 · More than one expert working on the same set at the same time

REVISIT — Once the single-expert path is proven: three real engagements have each reached an approved set that passed the buildability review on first submission.

### OUT-004

SUMMARY — An engineering lead reading the set and recording their own confirmation that it can be built from

REVISIT — REL-002, with J-002. REL-001 gives the expert the buildability review (FR-012), and the gaps are found before anyone estimates. A named lead's own confirmation is a second person's time, which REL-001 does not ask for.

### OUT-003

SUMMARY — Any view of the document set other than reading the documents themselves and stepping through them beside the conversation

REVISIT — When at least two of the three sponsors in Q-005's spike say the root document is not enough to decide. Until then the sponsor reads one document, the root document, which FR-013 says carries everything they need.

### OUT-005 · A reviewer commenting on a section inside the set, not on an exported copy

REVISIT — REL-003, when OUT-002's condition holds: three real engagements have each reached an approved set that passed the buildability review on first submission. Until then, the sponsor comments on an exported copy, and the comments come back under FR-022 and FR-023.

SECTION 7

# Functional requirements

DRAFT 88/100 NO BLOCKING DEFECTS

| ID | USER | CAPABILITY | PRIORITY | STAGE |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| FR-001 | PER-001 | State the idea; establish the vocabulary once | must | ST-001 |
| FR-002 | PER-001 | See the whole set's state at a glance | should | ST-001 |
| FR-003 | PER-001 | Be taught the section before being asked | must | ST-002 |
| FR-004 | PER-001 | Be asked one or two questions at a time | must | ST-002 |
| FR-005 | PER-001 | End a section and see what was left behind | should | ST-002 |
| FR-006 | PER-001 | Unknown facts become open questions, never inventions | must | ST-002 |
| FR-007 | PER-001 | Technology talk converted; preference preserved | must | ST-002 |
| FR-008 | PER-001 | Read the draft as prose | should | ST-003 |
| FR-009 | PER-001 | See score, blocking defects, weakest part | must | ST-003 |
| FR-010 | PER-001 | Be asked one question, not twelve | must | ST-004 |
| FR-011 | PER-001 | See the re-grade against the same standard | should | ST-004 |
| FR-012 | PER-001 | See what a team could not build from it | must | ST-005 |
| FR-013 | PER-003 | See what is approved and what is open, on one page | must | ST-006 |
| FR-014 | PER-003 | Approve, with conditions, against a version | must | ST-006 |
| FR-015 | PER-001 | Stop and resume without being asked anything twice | should | ST-004 |
| FR-016 | PER-001 | Refute a finding and have it withdrawn | should | ST-003 |
| FR-017 | PER-001 | Move to any section without losing their place | should | ST-003 |
| FR-018 | PER-001 | See the set as it now stands | should | ST-003 |
| FR-019 | PER-001 | Stop being asked once the section would meet the gate | should | ST-002 |
| FR-020 | PER-001 | Be told when the set states one item two ways | should | ST-003 |
| FR-021 | PER-001 | Name each approver before offering the set | must | ST-006 |
| FR-022 | PER-003 | Comment on an exported copy, and see each comment's response | should | ST-006 |
| FR-023 | PER-001 | Bring an exported copy's review comments into the set, and respond to each | should | ST-006 |

Every release-line stage has at least one `must` requirement. Eleven of the 23 are `must`: without any one of them, REL-001 does not do what it promises. The twelve `should` requirements make the work faster or easier to follow, and the

expert can still reach an approved set without them. The expert set this split at version 0.8.0, and set FR-021 to `must` at version 0.9.0.

Five of the `must` requirements wait on an open question in section 12. FR-004, FR-009, FR-010, and FR-012 wait on Q-009, which version of the rubric and the derivability checks release 1 grades against. The same four also wait on Q-015, who owns the rubric and the checks, because Q-009 cannot fix a version until Q-015 names its owner. FR-010 also waits on Q-007 and Q-014, whether writing the requirements sends the expert back to the journeys and how that feels, because both block ST-004. FR-013 waits on Q-005, whether a sponsor accepts a PRD that carries a grade. FR-014 no longer waits: Q-011 is answered, and in release 1 the expert records the sponsor's decision under FR-014. Three `should` requirements also wait: FR-011 and FR-019 on Q-009, and FR-015 on Q-010.

FR-015 and FR-016 were split out of FR-002 and FR-009 at version 0.2.0, because each has a failure mode of its own: a build could deliver perfect set-state visibility and still re-ask three answered questions, and could report a grade perfectly and still defend a finding the document does not support. Ids are never renumbered, so they sit at the end rather than in stage order.

FR-019 and FR-020 were split out of FR-004 and FR-008 at version 0.9.0, for the same reason. The early stop and the check across the set each have a failure mode of their own, and each needs its own priority. The expert set both to `should`. FR-019 also waits on Q-009, because the early stop applies the rubric.

FR-021 was added at version 0.9.0 on the expert's decision. A set records who will approve it before it is offered, so an approval names a person, not only the sponsor's role in section 10.

FR-022 was added at version 0.10.0 on the expert's decision, as a `should` in REL-001. A sponsor reads an exported copy outside the product at ST-006 and comments in it. FR-023 brings those comments back, and under FR-022 the next copy carries each response and what it changed. WF-011 shows that copy. A comment still without a response when the sponsor approves does not block the approval: the expert records it as a condition under FR-014, as the expert decided.

FR-023 was split out of FR-022 at version 0.11.0, as FR-015 and FR-016 were. FR-022 is what the sponsor sees, and FR-023 is what the expert does to bring the comments in and answer them. Each has a failure mode of its own: a build could import every comment and never show the sponsor a response, or show responses to comments it lost. The approval rule moved into FR-014, which records every condition, and the sponsor sets each condition's date.

### A judgement call worth challenging

FR-002, FR-008 and FR-013 refer to "the set", "the section", "a table row" and "the root document". A reader may read those as naming an output format and therefore failing test 5. The judgement taken here is that a written PRD is the product's subject, not its delivery technology, so these words name the artifact rather than the mechanism. What is deliberately absent everywhere: the assistant the product runs inside, how grading is performed, who or what reviews the set, and what the documents are stored as. Those are in section 6 as non-goals, in section 11 as dependencies, or nowhere.

FR-001, FR-009, FR-013 and FR-014 each read as more than one capability, and a grading pass has called them out for it. They are left whole deliberately: each is one act with several parts, and a build delivering half of one would be visibly unfinished rather than arguably done. FR-015 and FR-016 were split precisely because they were not like that, each had a failure mode the other half could hide.

### FR-001 · State the idea in their own words and establish the domain's vocabulary once

| | |
|---|---|
| USER | PER-001 |
| OUTCOME | Every question they are asked afterwards uses their unit of work and their terms, so they are never translating. |
| ACCEPTANCE | • Given an expert who says the unit of work is a "load", when any later question refers to that unit, then it says "load" and not "item", "record" or "entity".<br>• Given three words the expert says an outsider would misread, when the first section is drafted, then each of those words appears in the glossary with the expert's own meaning.<br>• Given an expert who has not stated a domain, when they ask to begin a section, then they are asked for the domain and the unit of work first. |
| PRIORITY | must |
| SHOWN IN | conversation |
| JOURNEY STAGE | ST-001 |
| OBJECTIVE | O-003 |

### FR-002 · See every section of the set and what state each one is in, at any point

| | |
|---|---|
| USER | PER-001 |
| OUTCOME | They can see at a glance what is done, what is weak and what has not been started, without opening any section. |
| ACCEPTANCE | • Given a set where four section documents are drafted and thirteen are pending, when the expert asks where things stand, then they see all seventeen section documents with each one's state, and the pending ones are shown as not started rather than omitted.<br>• Given a section that has been graded, when the expert sees the set's state, then that section shows its score and how many blocking defects it has.<br>• Given a set where no section has been started, when the expert asks where things stand, then every section is listed and shown as not started. |
| PRIORITY | should |
| SHOWN IN | screen |
| JOURNEY STAGE | ST-001 |
| OBJECTIVE | O-002 |

### FR-003

| | |
|---|---|
| CAPABILITY | Be taught what a section is, why it matters and what belongs in it, before being asked anything about it |
| USER | PER-001 |
| OUTCOME | Before the first question of a section reaches them, what the section is for and what belongs in it is in front of them, in their own domain's terms. |
| ACCEPTANCE | • Given a section the expert has not done before, when they begin it, then they are first told what it is, why it matters and what belongs in it, in no more than ten lines.<br>• Given a stated domain, when a section is taught, then the example used is in that domain and not in another.<br>• Given an expert who says they already know the section, when they ask to skip the teaching, then the questions begin and the teaching is not forced. |
| PRIORITY | must |
| SHOWN IN | conversation |
| JOURNEY STAGE | ST-002 |
| OBJECTIVE | O-003 |

### FR-004 · Be asked one or two questions at a time, never a questionnaire

| | |
|---|---|
| USER | PER-001 |
| OUTCOME | No message puts more than two questions to them, so each answer they give addresses one thing. |
| ACCEPTANCE | • Given any section's interview, when the expert is asked for input, then at most two questions are put to them at once.<br>• Given an answer that leaves something the section needs still unanswered, or that could be written into the section in two ways differing in meaning, when it is received, then a follow-up is asked about that answer before the next topic is opened. |
| PRIORITY | must |
| SHOWN IN | conversation |
| JOURNEY STAGE | ST-002 |
| OBJECTIVE | O-003 |

### FR-005 · Say that they have nothing more to add, and have that end the section's interview

| | |
|---|---|
| USER | PER-001 |
| OUTCOME | They are never trapped in an interview, and what they chose to leave incomplete is recorded rather than hidden. |
| ACCEPTANCE | • Given an expert who says they are done with a section, when the section does not yet meet the gate, then it is written anyway at draft, and what is missing is recorded as an open question or named plainly to them.<br>• Given an expert who ends a section early, when they are told what was left behind, then the statement names the specific gap, not just a score. |
| PRIORITY | should |
| SHOWN IN | conversation |
| JOURNEY STAGE | ST-002 |
| OBJECTIVE | O-002 |

### FR-006

| | |
|---|---|
| CAPABILITY | Have a fact they do not know recorded as an open question with a decider and a date, rather than filled in for them |
| USER | PER-001 |
| OUTCOME | Nothing in their PRD is a number or a citation that nobody can stand behind. |
| ACCEPTANCE | • Given an expert who says they would have to check a figure, when the section is drafted, then no figure is written in its place and an open question records who could find out and by when.<br>• Given an objective whose baseline is unknown, when the section is drafted, then the baseline says so explicitly and an open question exists for it.<br>• Given a regulation or standard the expert has not named, when a constraint is drafted, then no regulation number appears that the expert did not supply. |
| PRIORITY | must |
| SHOWN IN | conversation |
| JOURNEY STAGE | ST-002 |
| OBJECTIVE | O-001 |

### FR-007

| | |
|---|---|
| CAPABILITY | State a technology they want and have the need beneath it recorded instead, with their preference preserved for the engineering lead |
| USER | PER-001 |
| OUTCOME | Their requirement names no technology, their reasoning is not lost, and they do not feel overruled. |
| ACCEPTANCE | • Given an expert who names a technology, when they are asked what the user gets from it and answer, then the recorded requirement states that outcome and names no technology, component, vendor or screen.<br>• Given a technology the expert stated, when the set is handed over, then that preference appears on a list of candidate architecture decisions for the engineering lead.<br>• Given an expert who insists the technology belongs in the requirement, when they have been told once why it does not, then their decision is recorded and is not argued again at the next grading pass. |
| PRIORITY | must |
| SHOWN IN | conversation |
| JOURNEY STAGE | ST-002 |
| OBJECTIVE | O-001 |

### FR-008 · Read the drafted section as prose rather than as a filled-in form

| | |
|---|---|
| USER | PER-001 |
| OUTCOME | They can judge from the prose alone whether it says what they meant. |
| ACCEPTANCE | • Given a drafted section, when the expert reads it, then every item is shown in a sentence or in a table row under named column headings, and no item is shown only as a bare list of names and values. |
| PRIORITY | should |
| SHOWN IN | screen |
| JOURNEY STAGE | ST-003 |
| OBJECTIVE | O-003 |

### FR-009 · See a score, every blocking defect by name, and which part of the section is weakest

| | |
|---|---|
| USER | PER-001 |
| OUTCOME | They know how good the section is against a stated standard, and what specifically is wrong, rather than being told it looks good. |
| ACCEPTANCE | • Given a graded section, when the expert reads the grade, then they see a score, a count of blocking defects, and each blocking defect stated with where it is.<br>• Given a section scoring 70 or more with one blocking defect, when the grade is reported, then the section is not offered as ready, and the defect is named.<br>• Given a graded section, when the expert reads the grade, then the weakest part is named and why it is weak is stated in no more than three lines.<br>• Given a grade that has just been reported, when the expert reads it, then they are asked to accept it or refute it, under TR-014. |
| PRIORITY | must |
| SHOWN IN | screen |
| JOURNEY STAGE | ST-003 |
| OBJECTIVE | O-001 |

### FR-010

| | |
|---|---|
| CAPABILITY | Be asked the single question that would most improve the section, not a list of everything wrong with it |
| USER | PER-001 |
| OUTCOME | They can act immediately, and the section improves one answer at a time instead of stalling under a list. |
| ACCEPTANCE | • Given a graded section scoring under 70, or carrying any blocking defect, when the expert is asked to improve it, then exactly one question is put to them.<br>• Given that one question, when it is asked, then it addresses the weakest part that was just named, and not a different part. |
| PRIORITY | must |
| SHOWN IN | conversation |
| JOURNEY STAGE | ST-004 |
| OBJECTIVE | O-003 |

### FR-011 · See the section re-graded against the same standard after answering

| | |
|---|---|
| USER | PER-001 |
| OUTCOME | They can see whether their answer actually improved the section, and by how much. |
| ACCEPTANCE | • Given an answered question, when the section is re-graded, then it is scored against the same rubric as before and both scores are visible.<br>• Given a re-grade, when the score has risen, then the document has changed; a score never rises without a change to the document.<br>• Given a section scoring 70 or more with no blocking defects, in a set that checks clean, when it is re-graded, then the expert is offered the state `review`, and is told that `review` means the section is ready for someone else to read. |
| PRIORITY | should |
| SHOWN IN | screen |
| JOURNEY STAGE | ST-004 |
| OBJECTIVE | O-003 |

### FR-012

| | |
|---|---|
| CAPABILITY | See what a development team would not be able to build from the set, before anyone has estimated it |
| USER | PER-001 |
| OUTCOME | They learn where their own PRD fails while it is still cheap to fix, rather than at iteration three. |
| ACCEPTANCE | • Given a set in which every section has been written at least once, when the expert asks for a buildability review, then they see a verdict and, for each release-line stage, whether a requirement covers it or it is a gap.<br>• Given a requirement whose acceptance criteria an engineer who was not in the interview judges insufficient to write a test from, when the buildability review reports it, then the requirement is named and the document is quoted.<br>• Given an open question that blocks a `must` requirement, when the buildability review runs, then that requirement's wait on the question is reported.<br>• Given a buildability review finding, when it is reported to the expert, then it has been checked against the document and anything not supported by the document has been dropped. |
| PRIORITY | must |
| SHOWN IN | report |
| JOURNEY STAGE | ST-005 |
| OBJECTIVE | O-001 |

### FR-013

| | |
|---|---|
| CAPABILITY | See, in the set's own root document, what is being approved, what is still undecided and who owns each undecided thing |
| USER | PER-003 |
| OUTCOME | They can commit budget and a date knowing what they are committing to and what is still open. |
| ACCEPTANCE | • Given a set offered for approval, when the approver opens its root document, then that one document carries the summary, the scope, every section's state and grade, and every open question with its decider and date, without the approver opening any other document.<br>• Given a set with any blocking defect anywhere, when the approver opens it, then they see that, with the sections it is in. |
| PRIORITY | must |
| SHOWN IN | report |
| JOURNEY STAGE | ST-006 |
| OBJECTIVE | O-001 |

### FR-014

| | |
|---|---|
| CAPABILITY | Approve, approve with conditions, or reject, and have that recorded against a named version |
| USER | PER-003 |
| OUTCOME | What was approved, when, by whom and on what conditions is answerable later without asking anyone. |

ACCEPTANCE

- Given an approver who approves with conditions, when they state the conditions, then each condition names the open question, requirement, or review comment it depends on and a date.
- Given a recorded approval, when the set is read later, then the version approved, the approver, their role, the date and the decision are all present.
- Given an approved set that is then changed, when the change is written, then a new version is recorded and the earlier approval is not represented as covering it.
- Given an approver who rejects the set, when the expert records it, then the rejection, its reason, the approver, and the date are recorded against the version, and the set reads as not approved.
- Given a sponsor who approves while a review comment has no response, when the expert records the approval, then each such comment is recorded as a condition on it, with the comment's id and the date the sponsor sets for it, and only the sponsor clears it.

PRIORITY: must

SHOWN IN: report

JOURNEY STAGE: ST-006

OBJECTIVE: O-001

### FR-015 · Stop in the middle of a set and resume days later without being asked anything twice

USER: PER-001

OUTCOME: They pick up at the first unfinished section, and nothing they have already told the product is asked for again.

ACCEPTANCE

- Given an expert returning after eight days, when they say they want to carry on, then work resumes at the first section not yet at `review`.
- Given an expert who has already stated their domain and vocabulary, when they resume, then they are not asked for either again and the vocabulary in use is unchanged.
- Given an expert who answered a question in a section before stopping, when they resume that section, then that question is not put to them again.

PRIORITY: should

SHOWN IN: conversation

JOURNEY STAGE: ST-004

OBJECTIVE: O-002

### FR-016 · Refute a grading finding by pointing at the document, and have it withdrawn

USER: PER-001

OUTCOME: They are told the finding was dropped, and it does not reappear at the next grading pass.

ACCEPTANCE

- Given a finding the expert refutes, when it is checked against the document and the document does not support it, then it is dropped and the expert is told it was dropped.
- Given a finding the document does support, when the expert refutes it, then the reason is stated once and their decision is recorded.
- Given a decision the expert reaffirmed after an objection, when the section is graded again, then the objection is not raised as a new finding.

PRIORITY: should

SHOWN IN: conversation

JOURNEY STAGE: ST-003

OBJECTIVE: O-001

### FR-017

| | |
|---|---|
| CAPABILITY | Move from the section in front of them to any other section of the set without losing their place |
| USER | PER-001 |
| OUTCOME | They reach the section they want in one step, and can always return to the view they were on before. |
| ACCEPTANCE | • Given a section in front of them, when they ask for the next or the previous section, then the section after or before it in reading order is shown, and at the first or the last section the view does not change.<br>• Given a section that cites an id another section defines, such as Q-001, when they follow that id, then the section that defines it is shown and the id is named above it.<br>• Given they have moved from a section to three other things in the set, one after another, when they ask to go back three times, then they see each earlier thing again, the most recent first, and end at the section they started from. |
| PRIORITY | should |
| SHOWN IN | screen |
| JOURNEY STAGE | ST-003 |
| OBJECTIVE | O-002 |

### FR-018 · See the set as it now stands after it was changed outside the view in front of them

| | |
|---|---|
| USER | PER-001 |
| OUTCOME | After they ask to refresh, what they read is the set as it now stands. |
| ACCEPTANCE | • Given a section changed after they opened the set, when they ask to refresh, then within 10 seconds that section shows its new text and its new state.<br>• Given a section that is graded again while the set is open, when they ask to refresh, then within 10 seconds the new grade is shown.<br>• Given no set existed when they looked, when a set is written and they ask to refresh, then every section of it is listed. |
| PRIORITY | should |
| SHOWN IN | screen |
| JOURNEY STAGE | ST-003 |
| OBJECTIVE | O-002 |

### FR-019 · Stop being asked once the section would already meet the gate

| | |
|---|---|
| USER | PER-001 |
| OUTCOME | The interview ends when the section has what it needs, so they are not asked questions it no longer needs. |
| ACCEPTANCE | • Given an expert whose answers would already score the section 70 or more with no blocking defects, when further questions remain unasked on the question list, then the interview stops rather than continuing to the end of it.<br>• Given an expert whose answers would score the section under 70, or with a blocking defect, when questions remain on the question list, then the next question is put to them.<br>• Given an answer that FR-004 says needs a follow-up, when the answers would already score the section 70 or more with no blocking defects, then the follow-up is asked first, and the interview stops only after it is answered. |
| PRIORITY | should |
| SHOWN IN | conversation |
| JOURNEY STAGE | ST-002 |
| OBJECTIVE | O-003 |

### FR-020 · Be told when the set states one item two different ways

| | |
|---|---|
| USER | PER-001 |
| OUTCOME | They see every id, priority or link that two places in the set state differently, before anyone builds from either. |
| ACCEPTANCE | • Given an id, priority or link that two places in the set state differently, when the section is read, then the expert is told of the difference rather than it being silently resolved.<br>• Given a set in which every id, priority and link is stated the same way wherever it appears, when the section is read, then no difference is reported. |
| PRIORITY | should |
| SHOWN IN | screen |
| JOURNEY STAGE | ST-003 |
| OBJECTIVE | O-003 |

### FR-021 · Name each approver of a set, by name and role, before offering it for approval

| | |
|---|---|
| USER | PER-001 |
| OUTCOME | The set records who will approve it, and nobody else's decision counts as an approval. |
| ACCEPTANCE | • Given a set the expert is about to offer for approval, when they name an approver, then the set records that approver's name and role, and the root document shows them.<br>• Given a set with no approver named, when the expert asks to offer it for approval, then it is not offered, and they are told an approver must be named first.<br>• Given a decision from someone the set does not name as an approver, when the expert records it, then it is not recorded as an approval. |
| PRIORITY | must |
| SHOWN IN | conversation |
| JOURNEY STAGE | ST-006 |
| OBJECTIVE | O-002 |

### FR-022

| | |
|---|---|
| CAPABILITY | Comment on an exported copy of the set without using the product, and see each comment's response in the next copy |
| USER | PER-003 |
| OUTCOME | A sponsor who never opens the product sees every comment they left in the next copy: with its status, accepted, declined, or answered, its response, and what changed, or marked open while it has no response. |
| ACCEPTANCE | • Given a sponsor who comments on an item in an exported copy, when they read the next exported copy, then they see the comment against that item with their name, the date, and the text they marked.<br>• Given a comment the expert responded to, when the sponsor reads the next exported copy, then they see the comment, its status, the response, and the ids it changed.<br>• Given a comment with no response yet, when the sponsor reads the next exported copy, then they see the comment marked open. |
| PRIORITY | should |
| SHOWN IN | report |
| JOURNEY STAGE | ST-006 |
| OBJECTIVE | O-002 |

### FR-023 · Bring the review comments in an exported copy into the set, and record a response to each

| | |
|---|---|
| USER | PER-001 |
| OUTCOME | Every review comment left in an exported copy is in the set once, against the item it marks, and none is lost in an inbox. |
| ACCEPTANCE | • Given an exported copy with review comments, when the expert brings them into the set, then each one is recorded against the item it marks, with the name of the person who left it, the date, and the text they marked.<br>• Given a copy whose comments were already brought in, when the expert brings it in again, then no comment is recorded twice.<br>• Given a comment that marks no text, when the expert brings the copy's comments into the set, then it is recorded against the section it sits in.<br>• Given a comment in the set, when the expert records a response, then the comment records its status, accepted, declined, or answered, the response, and the ids that changed. |
| PRIORITY | should |
| SHOWN IN | conversation |
| JOURNEY STAGE | ST-006 |
| OBJECTIVE | O-002 |

SECTION 7

# Wireframes

DRAFT 91/100 NO BLOCKING DEFECTS

Every requirement in section 7 whose outcome a person meets on a screen or in a report is drawn here as a text sketch. Each sketch shows what the person sees and what they can do there, with the set's own content. None of them decides how anything looks or how it is built.

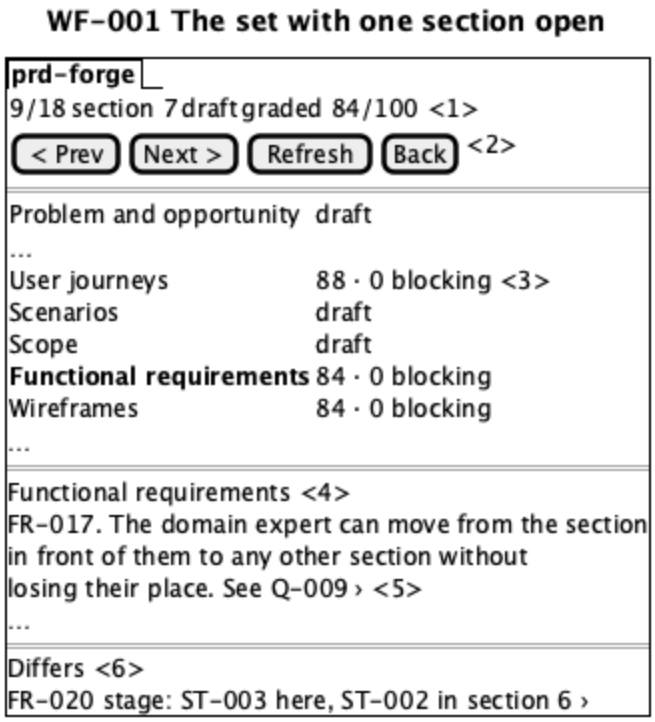
Five sketches follow the domain expert through the golden thread: a new set with nothing started, the set with a section open, why a section got its grade, the rubric behind it, and a re-grade. Two reports decide whether the set is buildable: the buildability review and the approval pack. A third, the review comments with their responses, is what the sponsor reads in the next exported copy. Three smaller sketches draw the other states: no set at all, which FR-018's third criterion names; the review that finds gaps, which SC-005 names; and the return after a week away, which SC-002 names.

The numbered marks in each sketch are explained, in order, by its `shows` list. Each sketch is also drawn for the printed PRD.

### WF-001 The set with one section open

Illustration, not a design. Illustrates FR-002, FR-008, FR-017, FR-018, and FR-020. PER-001 sees it at ST-003.

The expert reads a drafted section with the whole set beside it. Every graded section shows its score and its blocking count, so what is weak is visible without opening anything. When two places in the set state one id, priority, or link differently, mark 6 lists each difference with both values. The difference drawn is an example, not a fact of this set.

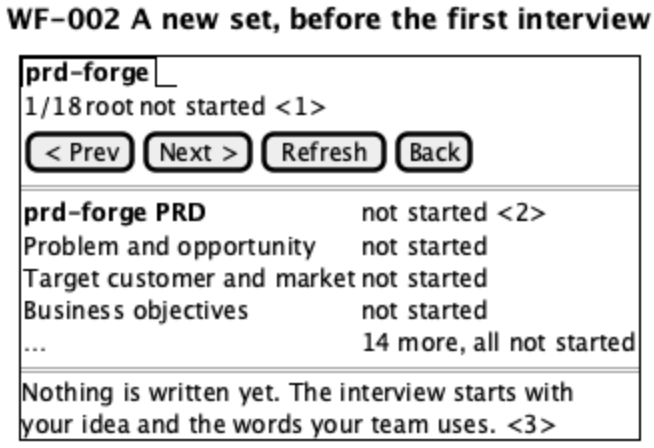



WF-001 drawing

### WF-002 A new set, before the first interview

Illustration, not a design. Illustrates FR-002, FR-017, and FR-018. PER-001 sees it at ST-001.

At ST-001 the set exists and nothing in it is written. Every section is listed and marked not started, so the expert sees the whole shape of the work before the first question.

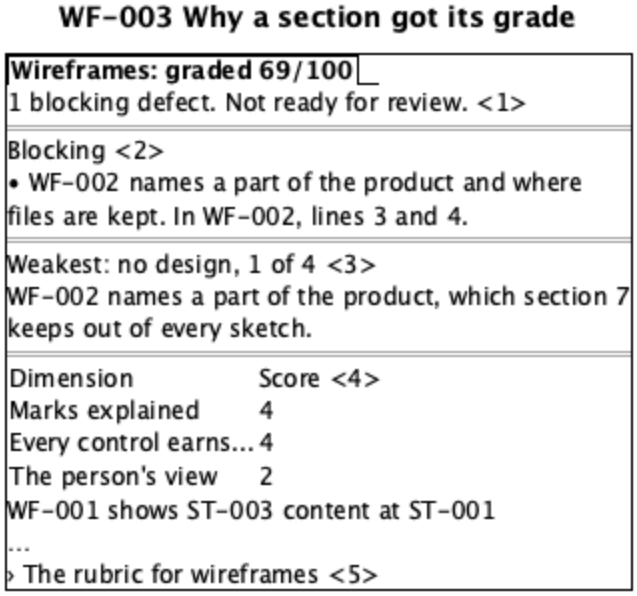



WF-002 drawing

### WF-003 Why a section got its grade

Illustration, not a design. Illustrates FR-009 and FR-017. PER-001 sees it at ST-003.

A score alone does not tell the expert what to fix. This view names each blocking defect and where it is, and names the weakest part, quoting the section.




WF-003 drawing

### WF-004 The standard a section is graded against

Illustration, not a design. Illustrates FR-009 and FR-017. PER-001 sees it at ST-003.

A grade against a stated standard is only fair if the expert can read the standard. This is the same rubric the graders used.

**WF-004 The standard a section is graded against**

| Rubric for functional requirements<br>Each dimension scores 0, 2 or 4. <1> | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| Dimension | 0 | 2 | 4 <2> |
| Atomicity | Several in one | Mostly single capability | One |
| Coverage | Stages with none | Most covered | Every stage has a must |
| ... | | | |
| Blocking defects <3><br>• A requirement that names a technology<br>... | | | |



WF-004 drawing

### WF-005 What a team could not build from this set

Illustration, not a design. Illustrates FR-012. PER-001 sees it at ST-005.

The values are prd-forge's own at version 0.4.0, a snapshot. The expert reads this before anyone has estimated anything, while a fix is still a sentence. Every finding quotes the set, so the expert can check it rather than trust it.

**WF-005 What a team could not build from this set**

| What a team could not build from this set<br>prd-forge PRD 0.4.0. Buildable with gaps. <1> |
|---|
| Release line <2><br>✓ ST-001 FR-001, FR-002, FR-015<br>✓ ST-003 FR-008, FR-009, FR-016, FR-017, FR-018<br>✓ ST-006 FR-013, FR-014<br>... |
| Cannot write a test from <3><br>1. FR-004: "two ways differing in meaning", no judge<br>2. FR-014: no test for a rejection |
| Blocked by an open question <4><br>Q-009 blocks FR-012: which rubric version applies.<br>Richard Hightower, by 2027-01-31 |
| Ask for first <5><br>1. Who judges FR-004's two meanings |

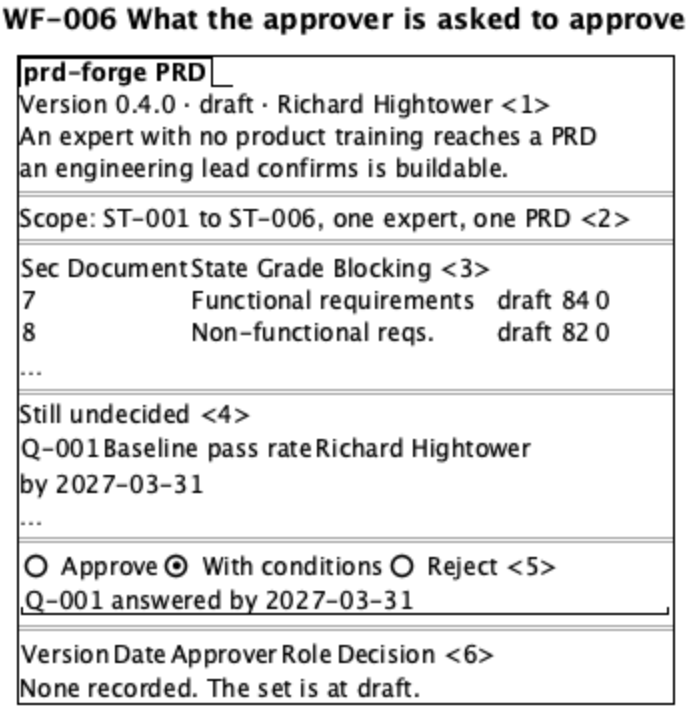


WF-005 drawing

### WF-006 What the approver is asked to approve

Illustration, not a design. Illustrates FR-013 and FR-014. PER-003 sees it at ST-006.

The values are prd-forge's own at version 0.4.0, a snapshot. The approver reads one document, not eighteen. It says what they are committing to, what is still open and who owns it, and where their decision is recorded.

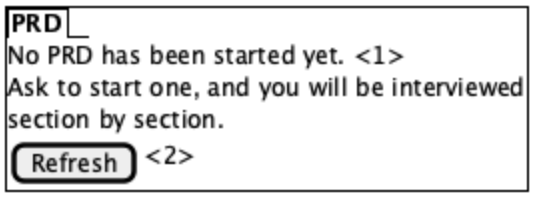



WF-006 drawing

### WF-007 Before any set exists

Illustration, not a design. Illustrates FR-018. PER-001 sees it at ST-001.

Before the first interview there is no set to list. The view says so plainly, and a refresh lists every section once the set is written.

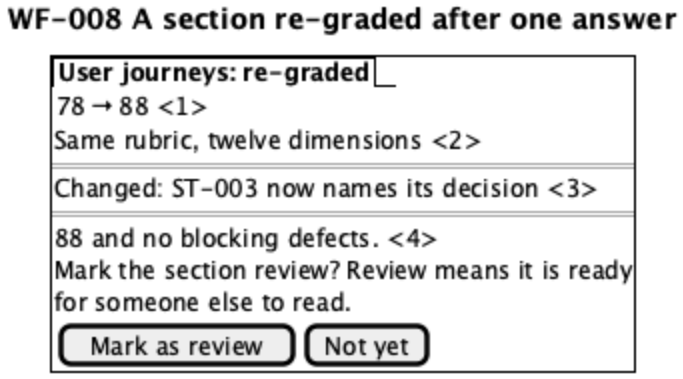



WF-007 drawing

### WF-008 A section re-graded after one answer

Illustration, not a design. Illustrates FR-011. PER-001 sees it at ST-004.

After one answer the section is graded again against the same rubric. Both scores are visible, and at 70 or more with no blocking defects the expert is offered review. The values are SC-001's.

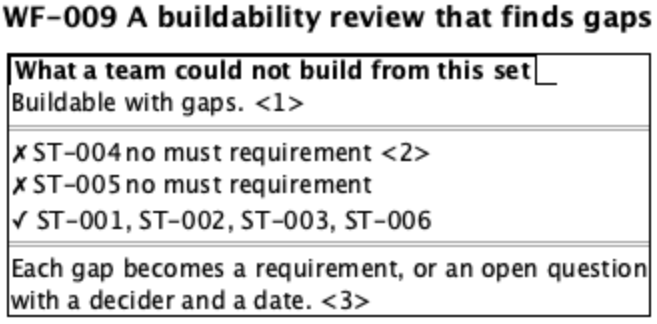



WF-008 drawing

### WF-009 A buildability review that finds gaps

Illustration, not a design. Illustrates FR-012. PER-001 sees it at ST-005.

SC-005 is the buildability review that finds work missing: two release-line stages have no must requirement behind them. The gaps are named first, before anything else in the buildability review.

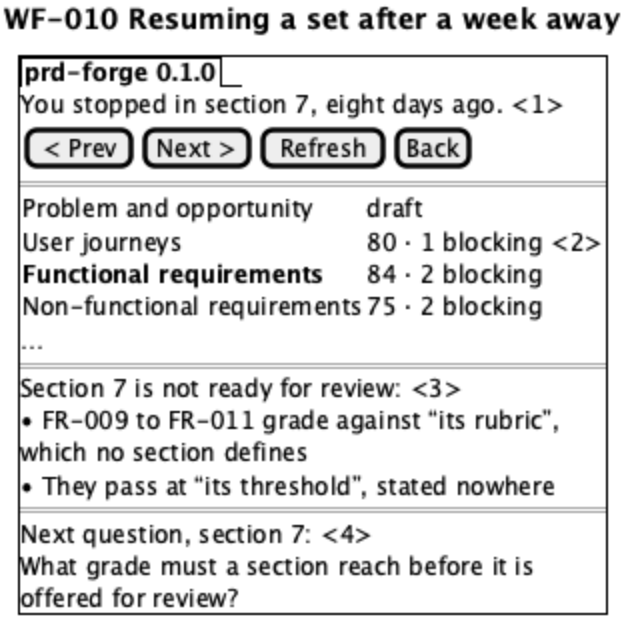



WF-009 drawing

### WF-010 Resuming a set after a week away

Illustration, not a design. Illustrates FR-002, FR-009, FR-015, FR-017, and FR-018. PER-001 sees it at ST-004.

SC-002 is the expert who returns after eight days and remembers nothing. The values are prd-forge's own at version 0.1.0, when section 7 scored 84 with two blocking defects: a grade of 70 or more that is still not offered as ready.

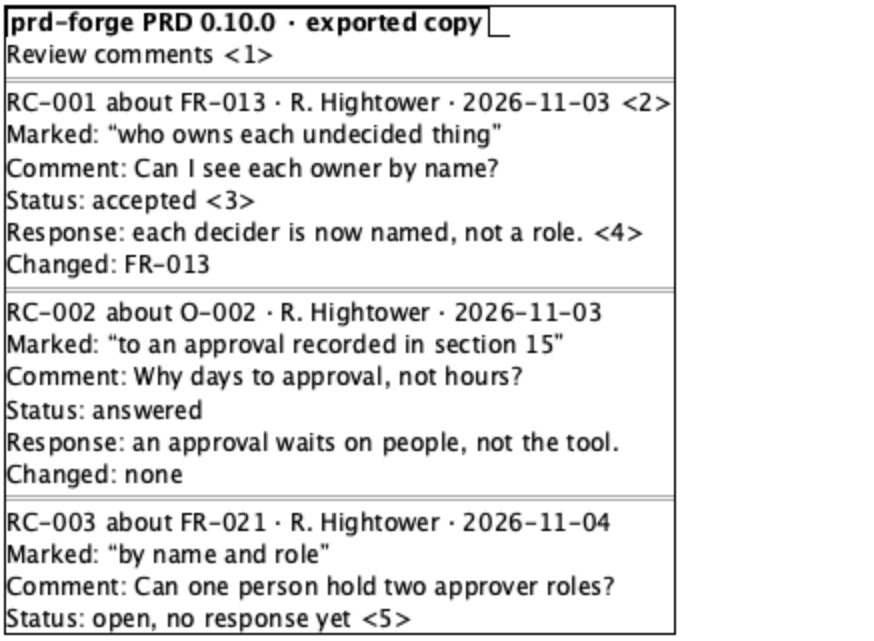



WF-010 drawing

### WF-011 Review comments with their responses in the next exported copy

Illustration, not a design. Illustrates FR-022. PER-003 sees it at ST-006.

The sponsor commented on an earlier copy, and this is the copy they read next. Each marked text is the item's own wording. The comments, responses, and dates are invented, to show the form.




WF-011 drawing

### WF-001 · The set with one section open

**TYPE** screen

**PERSONA** PER-001

**JOURNEY STAGE** ST-003

**ILLUSTRATES**

- FR-002
- FR-008
- FR-017
- FR-018
- FR-020

**SHOWS**

- Where they are in the set, the section's state, and its grade
- Next, previous, refresh, and back to the view before
- Each section's grade and blocking count; opening it shows why
- The section itself, as prose
- An ID that another section defines opens that section
- Each place where the set states one id, priority, or link two ways, with both values, and each place can be followed

### WF-002 · A new set, before the first interview

**TYPE** screen

**PERSONA** PER-001

**JOURNEY STAGE** ST-001

**ILLUSTRATES**

- FR-002
- FR-017
- FR-018

**SHOWS**

- Where they are, and that nothing is started yet
- Every section listed, each marked not started
- What happens first

### WF-003 · Why a section got its grade

**TYPE** screen

**PERSONA** PER-001

**JOURNEY STAGE** ST-003

**ILLUSTRATES**

- FR-009
- FR-017

**SHOWS**

- The score, and that the section is not ready
- Each blocking defect, and where it is
- The weakest part, and why, in three lines or fewer
- Each dimension's score, with the evidence for it
- The standard the grade was given against

### WF-004 · The standard a section is graded against

| | |
|---|---|
| TYPE | screen |
| PERSONA | PER-001 |
| JOURNEY STAGE | ST-003 |
| ILLUSTRATES | • FR-009<br>• FR-017 |
| SHOWS | • How a dimension becomes a grade<br>• What 0, 2 and 4 look like for each dimension<br>• What stops a section at any grade |

### WF-005 · What a team could not build from this set

| | |
|---|---|
| TYPE | report |
| PERSONA | PER-001 |
| JOURNEY STAGE | ST-005 |
| ILLUSTRATES | • FR-012 |
| SHOWS | • Which version of the set the buildability review read, and the verdict<br>• Each release-line stage, covered or a gap<br>• Each requirement an engineer could not test, quoted<br>• An open question that blocks a must, its decider and date<br>• What the buildability review would ask for first |

### WF-006 · What the approver is asked to approve

| | |
|---|---|
| TYPE | report |
| PERSONA | PER-003 |
| JOURNEY STAGE | ST-006 |
| ILLUSTRATES | • FR-013<br>• FR-014 |
| SHOWS | • The version, its state, its owner, and what it is for<br>• What release 1 covers<br>• Every section with its state and grade, and what blocks<br>• What is still undecided, who decides it, and by when<br>• The decision, with any condition tied to a question<br>• Who decided what, in which role, on which version |

### WF-007 · Before any set exists

| | |
|---|---|
| TYPE | screen |
| PERSONA | PER-001 |
| JOURNEY STAGE | ST-001 |
| STATE OF | WF-001 |
| ILLUSTRATES | • FR-018 |
| SHOWS | • That nothing has been started<br>• Look again once a set exists |

### WF-008 · A section re-graded after one answer

| | |
|---|---|
| TYPE | screen |
| PERSONA | PER-001 |
| JOURNEY STAGE | ST-004 |
| ILLUSTRATES | • FR-011 |
| SHOWS | • The new score beside the old one<br>• The same standard both times<br>• What changed in the section<br>• The offer of review, and what review means |

### WF-009 · A buildability review that finds gaps

| | |
|---|---|
| TYPE | report |
| PERSONA | PER-001 |
| JOURNEY STAGE | ST-005 |
| STATE OF | WF-005 |
| ILLUSTRATES | • FR-012 |
| SHOWS | • The verdict<br>• The release-line stages with no requirement, named<br>• That each gap must become a requirement or a question |

### WF-010 · Resuming a set after a week away

| | |
|---|---|
| TYPE | screen |
| PERSONA | PER-001 |
| JOURNEY STAGE | ST-004 |
| STATE OF | WF-001 |
| ILLUSTRATES | • FR-002<br>• FR-009<br>• FR-015<br>• FR-017<br>• FR-018 |
| SHOWS | • Where they stopped<br>• Every section's grade and blocking count<br>• Each blocking defect in the section, named<br>• The next question, not one already answered |

### WF-011 · Review comments with their responses in the next exported copy

| | |
|---|---|
| TYPE | report |
| PERSONA | PER-003 |
| JOURNEY STAGE | ST-006 |
| ILLUSTRATES | • FR-022 |
| SHOWS | • The comments, together in the copy<br>• Each comment, with what it is about, who left it, when, and the text they marked<br>• Its status, accepted, declined, or answered<br>• The response, and what changed because of it<br>• A comment with no response yet, marked open |

SECTION 8

# Non-functional requirements

DRAFT 89/100 NO BLOCKING DEFECTS

| ID | CATEGORY | TARGET |
|---|---|---|
| NFR-001 | performance | Next question under 20s at p95 |
| NFR-002 | performance | Section grade under 90s at p95 |
| NFR-003 | scale | 120 requirements, 10 journeys x 10 stages, 200 terms |
| NFR-004 | durability | 100% of a set readable with no part of the product running |
| NFR-005 | usability | 90% of sections completed without asking what a term means |
| NFR-006 | accessibility | Zero WCAG 2.2 AA violations on the golden-thread path |
| NFR-007 | observability | 100% of grades reconstructable after the session |
| NFR-008 | privacy | Zero destinations for the set's text or the expert's answers; domain research sends only standard and term names, and can be turned off |
| NFR-009 | supportability | 100% of older sets readable and gradable within a major product release |
| NFR-010 | retention | 100% retrievable from the organisation's own store, no expiry imposed by us |
| NFR-011 | availability | Zero answers lost per interruption; resume within 1 minute |
| NFR-012 | security | Zero read paths the organisation's own access rules do not govern |

### Where these came from

NFR-001 and NFR-002 come from PER-001's frequency: a burst of intense use. A 20-second wait is tolerable once; across 60 questions it is 20 minutes of dead time and the expert stops.

NFR-004 is the one that matters most and is cheapest to get wrong. PER-001 works in bursts weeks apart. If the set is only readable through this product, then a version change, a tool change or an expired session destroys weeks of an expert's thinking. The target is deliberately absolute.

NFR-005, NFR-006, NFR-007, NFR-008, and NFR-012 need people rather than instruments to measure. NFR-005 is the one most likely to be skipped, and it is the direct test of whether P-004 was solved.

NFR-006 covers the approver too, not only the expert: PER-003 reads this once and must not need a mouse to do it.

There is no concurrency target, and that is a decision rather than an omission. Under D-001 the product reaches one expert inside a session they are already in, so the session, not the product, carries simultaneous users; NFR-003 therefore reads scale as the size of one set, which is the dimension we do control. If D-001 or the separate-application non-goal in section 6 ever changes, concurrency comes back and this paragraph goes.

NFR-006 and NFR-012 set targets on things the non-goals in section 6 say we do not own: what the session renders, and where the customer keeps its documents. They are kept as `must` because a target nobody owns is how accessibility and access control get lost. Who owns them is Q-017 for NFR-006 and Q-021 for NFR-012.

NFR-010, NFR-011 and NFR-012 were added at version 0.2.0. Retention, availability and security had simply not been reached, and C-003, now assumption A-005, stated a retention rule that no measurable requirement stood behind. NFR-010 is the one that answers A-005's second half: the product retains nothing of its own, so the only retention question is how long the organization keeps the documents, and the answer must be that we impose no expiry on them.

NFR-011 waits on Q-010, whether an answer must survive the end of the session before its section is drafted, and NFR-007 waits on Q-016, whether a grade must show the rubric version it was made against.

### Requirements

#### NFR-001

| | |
|---|---|
| STATEMENT | An expert answering a question does not lose their train of thought waiting for the next one. |
| CATEGORY | performance |
| METRIC | 95th and 99th percentile elapsed time from the expert submitting an answer to the next question or the drafted section appearing. |
| TARGET | under 20 seconds at p95, and under 60 seconds at p99 |
| MEASUREMENT | At least 300 timed observations per release, taken across five scripted runs of all seventeen section documents on a set already holding 60 requirements, from the expert's own side of the conversation rather than from inside the product. |
| PRIORITY | must |
| APPLIES TO | • FR-004<br>• FR-010 |

#### NFR-002 · A grading pass does not make the expert wait so long that they stop asking for one.

| | |
|---|---|
| CATEGORY | performance |
| METRIC | 95th percentile elapsed time from the moment a section's draft is written to its grade being reported to the expert, measured from the expert's own side of the conversation, per grading pass on the section just drafted. |
| TARGET | under 90 seconds at p95 for a single section |
| MEASUREMENT | At least 200 grading passes per release, spread across all seventeen section documents and across sets of 20, 60 and 120 requirements. |
| PRIORITY | must |
| APPLIES TO | • FR-009<br>• FR-011 |

### NFR-003 · A set stays workable at the size real products reach.

| | |
|---|---|
| CATEGORY | scale |
| METRIC | The size of one set at which every requirement in section 7 still meets its acceptance criteria and every target in this section still holds. |
| TARGET | 120 functional requirements, 10 journeys of 10 stages, and 200 glossary terms |
| MEASUREMENT | A generated set at those sizes, run through every function in section 7, per release. |
| PRIORITY | must |

### NFR-004 · Work survives the expert stopping, and survives the tool they were using going away.

| | |
|---|---|
| CATEGORY | durability |
| METRIC | Share of a set's content recoverable after the authoring session ends, with no part of the product running. |
| TARGET | 100%, readable without this product |
| MEASUREMENT | End a session mid-section, then read the whole set with nothing but a text editor, once per release. |
| PRIORITY | must |
| APPLIES TO | • all |

### NFR-005

| | |
|---|---|
| STATEMENT | An expert with no product management training can complete a section without asking anyone what a word means. |
| CATEGORY | usability |
| METRIC | Share of sections a first-time expert completes without asking for the meaning of a product management term. |
| TARGET | 90% of sections, measured over 10 first-time experts |
| MEASUREMENT | Observed sittings with 10 first-time experts before release, questions to the observer counted and categorised. |
| PRIORITY | must |

### NFR-006

| | |
|---|---|
| STATEMENT | Everything the expert and the approver read is usable with a screen reader and without a mouse. |
| CATEGORY | accessibility |
| METRIC | Conformance to WCAG 2.2 AA of everything the product puts in front of the expert or the approver along the golden-thread journey. |
| TARGET | zero level-A or level-AA violations on the golden-thread path |
| MEASUREMENT | One manual screen-reader pass of the golden-thread journey per release, plus an automated check in the release pipeline of everything that journey shows. |
| PRIORITY | must |

### NFR-007 · An expert can tell why a section received the score it did, after the fact.

| | |
|---|---|
| CATEGORY | observability |
| METRIC | Share of grades for which the score per rubric dimension and the quotation behind each can be recovered after the session. |
| TARGET | 100% for any section at review or better |
| MEASUREMENT | Re-read a graded set a week later and reconstruct every score, once per release. |
| PRIORITY | should |
| APPLIES TO | • FR-009 |

### NFR-008

| | |
|---|---|
| STATEMENT | What the expert says about their domain stays within whatever boundary their organization already works in; this product adds no new place for it to go. The one outbound request is the domain check's research, on by default, which carries only the names of standards, terms of art, and the domain. An expert can turn it off for one set under TR-015, and an organization's own policy can forbid it for every set. |
| CATEGORY | privacy |
| METRIC | Number of destinations beyond the boundary A-005 names that the set's text or the expert's answers reach. An outbound query counts only when it holds more than the names of standards, terms of art, and the domain. |
| TARGET | zero |
| MEASUREMENT | Review of every outbound destination per release, recorded against A-005, and a review of the queries the domain check sent while grading the reference set, per release. |
| PRIORITY | must |

### NFR-009

| | |
|---|---|
| STATEMENT | A set written by an earlier release of the product is still readable and still gradable by a later release. |
| CATEGORY | supportability |
| METRIC | Share of sets written by product release N that product release N+1 reads and grades without the expert rewriting anything. |
| TARGET | 100% within a major product release |
| MEASUREMENT | Keep one set per product release and run the current product release against all of them, per product release. |
| PRIORITY | should |

### NFR-010

| | |
|---|---|
| STATEMENT | A set remains readable and retrievable for as long as the organization keeps the PRDs it builds from, without this product being involved. |
| CATEGORY | retention |
| METRIC | Share of a set retrievable and readable from the organization's own document store, with no part of this product present. |
| TARGET | 100%, for as long as the organization retains the set; no expiry imposed by us |
| MEASUREMENT | Retrieve a set written one release ago from the document store of a test organization, set up for the measurement because no customer organization exists at release, and read it with a text editor, once per release. |
| PRIORITY | must |
| APPLIES TO | • all |

### NFR-011

| | |
|---|---|
| STATEMENT | An interview in progress survives the product being unavailable; no session loses an answer the expert has already given. |
| CATEGORY | availability |
| METRIC | Answers lost per interruption, and time to resume after one. An interruption is the product becoming unavailable in the middle of a section. The resume clock starts when the product is available again and the expert asks to carry on. |
| TARGET | Zero answers lost, on every interruption; resume within 1 minute at p95 and within 3 minutes at p99 |
| MEASUREMENT | Interrupt a session mid-section 100 times per release, spread across all seventeen section documents, and count answers lost and seconds to resume. |
| PRIORITY | must |
| APPLIES TO | • FR-015 |

### NFR-012

| | |
|---|---|
| STATEMENT | Nobody but the people the organization has already given access to its documents can read a set. |
| CATEGORY | security |
| METRIC | Number of ways to read a set that the organization's own document access rules do not govern. |
| TARGET | zero |
| MEASUREMENT | Enumerate every read path to a set per release, in a test organization set up for the measurement because no customer organization exists at release, and check each against that organization's access rules. Recorded against the system-of-record non-goal in section 6 and A-005. |
| PRIORITY | must |

SECTION 9

# Constraints

DRAFT 95/100 NO BLOCKING DEFECTS

This section holds no constraints. No rule imposed from outside the team binds prd-forge itself. Each rule that this section once held was a decision of our own, a belief about customers, or the product's chosen response to a risk. The team could change each one by agreeing among themselves, so each one now lives where that kind of item belongs. The ids C-001 to C-004 are not reused.

An expert who uses prd-forge can still be bound by a professional code, a contract, or a firm policy. Those constraints belong in that expert's own PRD, not in this one.

### Where the rules live now

At version 0.8.1, C-001 to C-003 left this section.

- C-001, no separate application for the expert to open, install, or log into, is a non-goal in section 6. The session it needs is dependency D-001 in section 11.
- C-002, the output is plain documents and the product is not the system of record, is a non-goal in section 6.
- C-003, domain content stays in the expert's session and in the documents, is assumption A-005 in section 11.

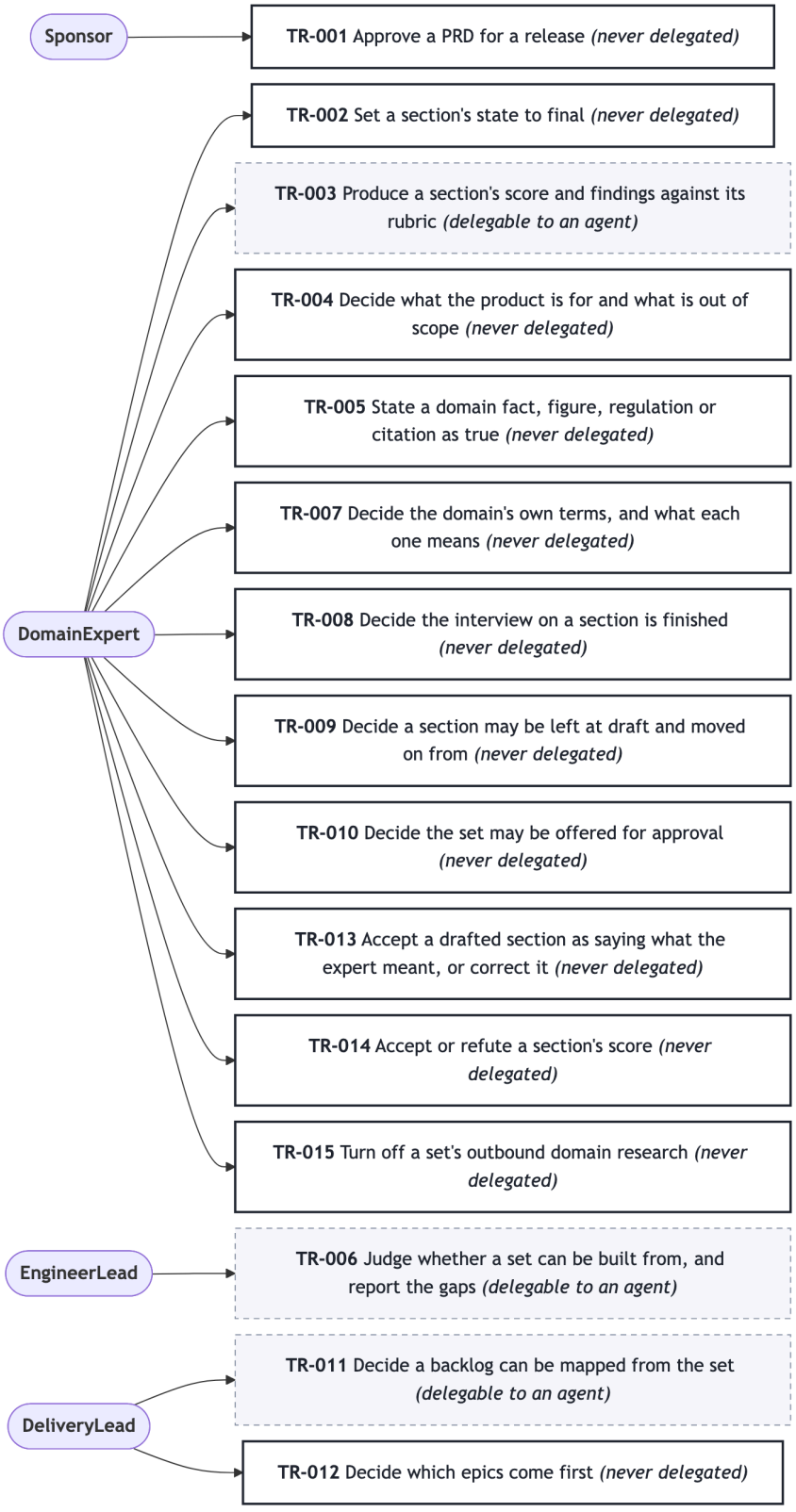
At version 0.9.0, C-004 left this section.

- C-004, no regulation, standard, clause, or statistic is stated as fact unless the expert supplied it or it was checked against its source, is trust rule TR-005 in section 10 and requirement FR-006 in section 7. TR-005 makes the expert the only one who can state such a fact as true, and it is never delegated. FR-006 records a fact the expert does not know as an open question with a decider and a date.

SECTION 10

# Decision rights and trust rules

DRAFT 84/100 NO BLOCKING DEFECTS




Who decides what

| ID | DECISION | DECIDER | DELEGABLE TO AN AGENT | NEVER DELEGATED |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| TR-001 | Approve a PRD for a release | PER-003 | no | yes |
| TR-002 | Set a section to final | PER-001 | no | yes |
| TR-003 | Produce a section's score and findings | PER-001 | **yes** | no |
| TR-004 | Decide scope | PER-001 | no | yes |
| TR-005 | State a domain fact as true | PER-001 | no | yes |
| TR-006 | Judge buildability, and report the gaps | PER-002 | **yes** | no |
| TR-007 | Decide the domain's own terms | PER-001 | no | yes |
| TR-008 | Decide a section's interview is finished | PER-001 | no | yes |
| TR-009 | Decide a section may be left at draft | PER-001 | no | yes |
| TR-010 | Decide the set may be offered for approval | PER-001 | no | yes |
| TR-011 | Decide a backlog can be mapped | PER-004 | **yes** | no |
| TR-012 | Decide which epics come first | PER-004 | no | yes |
| TR-013 | Accept or correct a drafted section | PER-001 | no | yes |
| TR-014 | Accept or refute a section's score | PER-001 | no | yes |
| TR-015 | Turn off a set's outbound domain research | PER-001 | no | yes |

Every decision named in a stage of section 5 appears here. TR-007 to TR-013 were added at version 0.2.0 to close that: five release-line stage decisions and both of J-002's had no rule, which meant gates a development team would have had to invent. TR-013 covers the one in the middle of the loop, the expert accepting that a draft says what they meant, which is distinct from scoring it (TR-003), from accepting or refuting the score (TR-014), from leaving it at draft (TR-009) and from setting it final (TR-002).

TR-015 was added at version 0.12.0. It settles a conflict between the domain check and NFR-008: the domain check researches the domain by default, because a citation it cannot confirm is worth less to the expert. The expert can turn it off for one set, and an organization's own policy can forbid it for every set. NFR-008 and A-005 now state that default.

TR-001's decider is the sponsor's role, PER-003. FR-021 names the person: before a set is offered for approval, the expert names each approver by name and role, and only a named approver's decision counts as an approval.

### The shape of the trust boundary

Only three of fifteen are delegable, and all three are **assessments**, not decisions: TR-003 produces a document's score, which the expert then accepts or refutes under TR-014, TR-006 judges whether it can be built from, and TR-011 judges whether a backlog can be mapped from it. All three produce evidence for a person. None changes a document, and none can set a state.

Everything that commits anyone to anything, such as approving, finalising, choosing scope, or asserting a fact, is never delegated. TR-005 is the strictest: a fact nobody can stand behind is not written at all, by anyone.

The delegable assessments all carry the same two obligations: **quote the document for every claim**, and **drop any finding the document does not support**. An assessment that cannot be refuted by pointing at the text is not evidence, it is an assertion, and the expert will correctly stop believing it. See R-002 in section 11.

### TR-001 · Approve a PRD for a release

| | |
|---|---|
| STAGES | • ST-006 |
| APPROVER | PER-003 |
| DELEGABLE TO AN AGENT | no |
| NEVER DELEGATED | yes |
| EVIDENCE REQUIRED | The summary, the scope, every section's state and grade, every blocking defect, and every open question with its decider and date. |
| ESCALATION | No substitute approver, and approval waits. Where no sponsor exists at all, such as a solo expert or an internal tool with no PER-003, the expert approves their own set under this rule, shown the same evidence, and the change log records that no separate approver existed. A set is never treated as approved because its score is high. A rejection goes back to the expert with its reason, and the set reads as not approved until a later version is approved. |
| ACCEPTANCE | • Given a set with any blocking defect, when approval is sought, then the approver is shown the defects and the set is not presented as fit to approve.<br>• Given a set with no recorded approval, when anyone reads its state, then it reads as not approved, whatever its scores are.<br>• Given an engagement with no sponsor, when the expert approves their own set, then the approval records that no separate approver existed.<br>• Given an approver who rejects the set, when the decision is recorded, then the rejection carries its reason, and the set reads as not approved.<br>• Given an approver who approves with conditions, when the approval is recorded, then each condition names the open question, requirement, or review comment it depends on and a date, and the set reads as approved-with-conditions until every condition is cleared by that same approver. |

### TR-002 · Set a section's state to final

| | |
|---|---|
| STAGES | • ST-004 |
| APPROVER | PER-001 |
| DELEGABLE TO AN AGENT | no |
| NEVER DELEGATED | yes |
| EVIDENCE REQUIRED | The section's grade, its blocking defect count, and the result of validating it. |
| ESCALATION | The expert may override the gate; the override and the score at the time are recorded in the change log. Nobody may set a section final on the expert's behalf while they are away: it waits. |
| ACCEPTANCE | • Given a section with one or more blocking defects, when final is requested, then it is not set without an explicit override from the expert.<br>• Given an override, when it is applied, then the change log records that it was an override and the score at the time. |

### TR-003 · Produce a section's score and findings against its rubric

| | |
|---|---|
| STAGES | • ST-003 |
| APPROVER | PER-001 |
| DELEGABLE TO AN AGENT | yes |
| NEVER DELEGATED | no |
| AGENT ROLE | proposes |
| EVIDENCE REQUIRED | The rubric's dimensions and a quotation from the document for every score below full marks. |
| ESCALATION | The score runs by itself after each draft, and nobody has to start it. The score does not count until the expert accepts it under TR-014, and a finding the document does not support is dropped (FR-016). |
| ACCEPTANCE | • Given a section that has just been drafted, when the draft is written, then its score and findings are produced without anyone asking for them.<br>• Given a score below full marks on a dimension, when it is reported, then a quotation from the document is given for it. |

### TR-004 · Decide what the product is for and what is out of scope

| | |
|---|---|
| STAGES | • ST-001 |
| APPROVER | PER-001 |
| DELEGABLE TO AN AGENT | no |
| NEVER DELEGATED | yes |
| EVIDENCE REQUIRED | What the consequence of the choice is, including any release-line stage it would leave uncovered. |
| ESCALATION | None, and no substitute. The expert decides; while they are away, scope does not change. Where the choice weakens the PRD the objection is stated once and the decision is recorded with the dissent noted. |
| ACCEPTANCE | • Given an expert decision that leaves a release-line stage uncovered, when it is recorded, then the consequence is stated to the expert once and the decision stands.<br>• Given a decision the expert reaffirmed after an objection, when later grading passes run, then the objection is not raised again as a new finding. |

### TR-005 · State a domain fact, figure, regulation or citation as true

| | |
|---|---|
| APPROVER | PER-001 |
| DELEGABLE TO AN AGENT | no |
| NEVER DELEGATED | yes |
| EVIDENCE REQUIRED | The expert's own statement of it, or a source that has been checked. |
| ESCALATION | Where neither exists the fact is not written at all; it becomes an open question with a decider and a date. Nobody may supply the fact on the expert's behalf while they are away. |
| ACCEPTANCE | • Given a figure or citation the expert did not supply and that has not been verified, when a section is drafted, then it does not appear in the document.<br>• Given a citation that was checked and could not be confirmed, when it is reported, then it is marked unverified rather than stated as fact. |

### TR-006 · Judge whether a set can be built from, and report the gaps

| | |
|---|---|
| STAGES | • ST-009 |
| APPROVER | PER-002 |
| DELEGABLE TO AN AGENT | yes |
| NEVER DELEGATED | no |
| AGENT ROLE | proposes |
| EVIDENCE REQUIRED | The release line, the requirements covering each stage, and a quotation for every gap claimed. |
| ESCALATION | The engineering lead's own judgement overrides any reported verdict; the report is evidence for them, not a substitute for them. In release 1 no engineering lead is in the loop, so the report goes to the expert, who decides what to do with it under TR-010. |
| ACCEPTANCE | • Given a reported verdict, when the engineering lead disagrees, then their judgement is recorded as the verdict and the report is kept alongside it.<br>• Given a reported gap, when it is stated, then the document is quoted for it. |

### TR-007 · Decide the domain's own terms, and what each one means

| | |
|---|---|
| STAGES | • ST-001 |
| APPROVER | PER-001 |
| DELEGABLE TO AN AGENT | no |
| NEVER DELEGATED | yes |
| EVIDENCE REQUIRED | Where the term is already used in the set, and any standard-setter's definition that differs from the expert's. |
| ESCALATION | None, and no substitute. Terms are the expert's; while they are away the vocabulary does not change. |
| ACCEPTANCE | • Given a term the expert has defined, when any later question or document uses that idea, then it uses the expert's word and not a synonym.<br>• Given a standard-setter's definition that differs, when the term is recorded, then both are stated and the expert says which the set uses. |

### TR-008 · Decide the interview on a section is finished

| | |
|---|---|
| STAGES | • ST-002 |
| APPROVER | PER-001 |
| DELEGABLE TO AN AGENT | no |
| NEVER DELEGATED | yes |
| EVIDENCE REQUIRED | What the section would score as it stands, and what is still missing from it. |
| ESCALATION | None. The expert ends the interview; nobody ends it for them, and no question list runs past the point they call it done. |
| ACCEPTANCE | • Given an expert who says they have nothing more to add, when they say it, then no further question is put to them in that section.<br>• Given an interview ended early, when the section is written, then what is missing is named to the expert, not hidden behind a score. |

### TR-009 · Decide a section may be left at draft and moved on from

| | |
|---|---|
| STAGES | • ST-004 |
| APPROVER | PER-001 |
| DELEGABLE TO AN AGENT | no |
| NEVER DELEGATED | yes |
| EVIDENCE REQUIRED | The section's score, its blocking defects, and which later sections depend on what is missing. |
| ESCALATION | None, and no substitute. While the expert is away the section stays where it is. |
| ACCEPTANCE | • Given a section below 70 or carrying a blocking defect, when the expert chooses to move on, then it is written at `draft` and what was left behind is recorded as an open question or named plainly to them. |

### TR-010 · Decide the set may be offered for approval

| | |
|---|---|
| STAGES | • ST-005 |
| APPROVER | PER-001 |
| DELEGABLE TO AN AGENT | no |
| NEVER DELEGATED | yes |
| EVIDENCE REQUIRED | Every section's state and grade, every blocking defect, and the buildability review's gaps with, for each, whether it is closed or owned. |
| ESCALATION | None, and no substitute. The expert offers the set; nobody offers it for them. |
| ACCEPTANCE | • Given a buildability gap that is neither closed nor given a decider and a date, when the expert offers the set for approval, then that gap is stated to them first.<br>• Given a set offered for approval, when the approver opens it, then what the expert was shown under this rule is what the approver sees. |

### TR-011 · Decide a backlog can be mapped from the set

| | |
|---|---|
| STAGES | • ST-007 |
| APPROVER | PER-004 |
| DELEGABLE TO AN AGENT | yes |
| NEVER DELEGATED | no |
| AGENT ROLE | proposes |
| EVIDENCE REQUIRED | Whether a golden thread exists, and which release-line stages have requirements behind them. |
| ESCALATION | The delivery lead's own judgement stands over any reported verdict, and an override is recorded with its reason. Where they are unavailable the workshop waits rather than proceeding without a backbone. |
| ACCEPTANCE | • Given a set with no journey, when the check runs, then it reports that a backlog cannot be derived, and names that as the reason.<br>• Given a reported verdict the delivery lead disagrees with, when they record their own, then their verdict stands and the override and its reason are recorded beside the report. |

### TR-012 · Decide which epics come first

| | |
|---|---|
| STAGES | • ST-008 |
| APPROVER | PER-004 |
| DELEGABLE TO AN AGENT | no |
| NEVER DELEGATED | yes |
| EVIDENCE REQUIRED | The release line, the dependencies in section 11, and the objective each epic moves. |
| ESCALATION | The delivery lead may re-order within the release line at any time; order never changes scope, which stays with TR-004. While they are away the order stands as last recorded, and nobody re-orders on their behalf. |
| ACCEPTANCE | • Given an ordering, when it is recorded, then each decision names whether value, dependency or the release line drove it. |

### TR-013 · Accept a drafted section as saying what the expert meant, or correct it

| | |
|---|---|
| STAGES | • ST-003 |
| APPROVER | PER-001 |
| DELEGABLE TO AN AGENT | no |
| NEVER DELEGATED | yes |
| EVIDENCE REQUIRED | The drafted section in readable form, and its grade, so the expert judges the words and not the score. |
| ESCALATION | None, and no substitute. An unaccepted draft stays at `draft`; nobody accepts a section's wording on the expert's behalf while they are away. |
| ACCEPTANCE | • Given a drafted section the expert has not accepted, when the set's state is read, then that section is not shown as ready for anyone else to read.<br>• Given an expert who corrects a drafted section, when the correction is applied, then it is their words that are kept, and the section is graded again before it advances. |

### TR-014 · Accept or refute a section's score

| | |
|---|---|
| STAGES | • ST-003 |
| APPROVER | PER-001 |
| DELEGABLE TO AN AGENT | no |
| NEVER DELEGATED | yes |
| EVIDENCE REQUIRED | The score, each finding with the quotation behind it, and the section's weakest part. The product asks as soon as the score is produced, so the expert's only action is to accept or to refute. |
| ESCALATION | None, and no substitute. While the expert is away the score waits, unaccepted, and the section does not advance. Nobody accepts a score on the expert's behalf. |
| ACCEPTANCE | • Given a score that has just been produced, when the expert sees it, then they are asked whether they accept it or refute it, and need take no other action.<br>• Given an expert who accepts a score, when they accept it, then the acceptance is recorded and the section may advance on that score.<br>• Given an expert who refutes a finding, when they give their reason, then the refutation and the reason are recorded, and the finding is checked against the document under FR-016. |

### TR-015 · Turn off a set's outbound domain research

| | |
|---|---|
| STAGES | • ST-003 |
| APPROVER | PER-001 |
| DELEGABLE TO AN AGENT | no |
| NEVER DELEGATED | yes |
| EVIDENCE REQUIRED | What the domain check sends out by default: the names of standards, terms of art, and the domain, and never the set's text or the expert's answers. |
| ESCALATION | While the expert has not decided, research stays on, carrying only the names of standards, terms of art, and the domain. Nobody turns it off or on for one set on the expert's behalf. An organization's own policy that forbids outbound research is a rule from outside the product, not a decision in it: the domain check obeys that rule for every set, and no decision of the expert overrides it. |
| ACCEPTANCE | • Given a set whose expert has turned off its outbound domain research, when a section is graded, then the domain check makes no outbound request, and marks each citation it cannot confirm from the set as unverified.<br>• Given a set whose expert has made no choice, when a section is graded, then the domain check may research the domain's standards and terms, and no query it sends holds the set's text or the expert's answers.<br>• Given an organization whose policy forbids outbound research, when any set is graded, then the domain check makes no outbound request, whatever the expert has decided for the set. |

SECTION 11

# Assumptions, risks and dependencies

DRAFT 96/100 NO BLOCKING DEFECTS

## Assumptions

| ID | ASSUMPTION | IF FALSE |
|---|---|---|
| A-001 | An expert will answer 50-100 questions across a few sittings | The method fails; sections 5-7 change completely |
| A-002 | An expert will act on a grade they did not produce | The grading is decoration |
| A-003 | An engineering lead accepts a PRD naming no technology | Test 5 becomes a liability |
| A-004 | Organizations permit drafting inside an assistant session | Section 6's separate-application non-goal and A-005 have to change, and FR-002, FR-015, and FR-018 with them |
| A-005 | Organizations accept that domain content stays in the session and the documents | NFR-008, NFR-010, and NFR-012 have to change |

A-001 and A-002 are the two the product stands on, and neither has been tested. Both are validated by the same ten observed sittings (D-002), which makes D-002 the single most load-bearing dependency in this PRD.

A-005 was constraint C-003 in section 9 until 0.8.1. It moved here because it is a belief about what customers accept, which a customer can falsify, and not a rule imposed from outside.

## Risks

| ID | RISK | L | I | RESPONSE | MITIGATED BY | STATUS | OWNER |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| R-001 | High score becomes false assurance | high | high | reduce | 2027-01-31 | open | Richard Hightower |
| R-002 | Unsupported findings destroy trust in all findings | high | high | reduce | 2027-01-31 | open | Richard Hightower |
| R-003 | A beautifully graded PRD for the wrong product | medium | high | reduce | none | open | Richard Hightower |
| R-004 | Interview too long, and sets abandoned | medium | medium | reduce | none | open | Richard Hightower |
| R-005 | A version change strands an expert's set | low | high | avoid | none | open | Richard Hightower |

R-001 and R-002 are high and high, and both mitigations must be in place by 2027-01-31, two months before REL-001.

**R-003 is not closed.** The mitigations listed reduce it and do not solve it. Nothing in this product checks whether the product being specified should exist. This section states it rather than hide it behind a mitigation that sounds adequate.

### Dependencies

| ID | NEED | FROM | BY | STATUS | OWNER |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| D-001 | An assistant session able to carry the interview | The assistant platform the customer already uses | 2027-01-31 | delivered | Richard Hightower |
| D-002 | 10 observed first-time experts | Early customers and the professional network | 2027-01-31 | requested | Richard Hightower |
| D-003 | 3 engineering leads to read a set cold | Early customers | 2027-01-31 | requested | Richard Hightower |

D-001 is delivered: this PRD was written and graded with prd-forge inside an assistant session, which carried the interview and read and wrote the documents.

D-002 and D-003 are both requested and both due by 2027-01-31, two months before REL-001's target in section 13. The questions they answer are due by 2027-02-28, so REL-001 can use the results. Q-019 and Q-022 decide, by 2027-01-31, whether REL-001 keeps its date and what happens to it if either slips.

### Assumptions

#### A-001

| | |
|---|---|
| ASSUMPTION | A domain expert will answer fifty to a hundred questions about their own field across a few sittings, if each one is clearly worth answering. |
| IF FALSE | The whole method fails. The product would have to produce a usable partial PRD from perhaps fifteen answers, which changes sections 5, 6 and 7 completely and makes the grading thresholds meaningless. |
| VALIDATED BY | Observed sittings with 10 first-time experts, counting where they stop, the same sittings NFR-005 uses (D-002). |
| OWNER | Richard Hightower |
| CATEGORY | usability |
| EVIDENCE | none |
| VALIDATE BY | 2027-02-28 |

#### A-002 · An expert will act on a grade they did not produce, rather than dismissing it.

| | |
|---|---|
| IF FALSE | The grading is decoration, and O-001 to O-003 and FR-009 to FR-011 measure something nobody uses. The product reduces to a structured interview. |
| VALIDATED BY | In the same observed sittings, whether the expert answers the one question or moves on regardless (D-002). |
| OWNER | Richard Hightower |
| CATEGORY | value |
| EVIDENCE | some |
| VALIDATE BY | 2027-02-28 |

### A-003

| | |
|---|---|
| ASSUMPTION | An engineering lead will accept a PRD that names no technology, rather than reading the absence as incompleteness. |
| IF FALSE | Test 5 becomes a liability rather than a discipline, and the candidate architecture decisions list in FR-007 has to become a first-class output rather than a hand-over note. |
| VALIDATED BY | Three engineering leads reading a completed set cold and saying what they would ask for first (D-003). |
| OWNER | Richard Hightower |
| CATEGORY | usability |
| EVIDENCE | none |
| VALIDATE BY | 2027-02-28 |

### A-004 · Organizations will let a PRD for their product be drafted inside an assistant session.

| | |
|---|---|
| IF FALSE | The separate-application non-goal in section 6 and A-005 are unacceptable as written and the delivery model has to change, which invalidates FR-002, FR-015, and FR-018, because each assumes the expert's own session. |
| VALIDATED BY | The information security review of the first three client contracts. |
| OWNER | Richard Hightower |
| CATEGORY | viability |
| EVIDENCE | none |

### A-005

| | |
|---|---|
| ASSUMPTION | Organizations accept that the domain content an expert enters stays in the expert's own session and in the documents. This product sends it nowhere else and keeps it nowhere else. They also accept the domain check's research, on by default, which sends only the names of standards, terms of art, and the domain, or they turn it off under TR-015. |
| IF FALSE | An organization whose information policy needs more than this cannot adopt the product as written, and NFR-008, NFR-010, and NFR-012, which are measured against this boundary, have to change. |
| VALIDATED BY | The information security review of the first three client contracts, the same review that tests A-004. |
| OWNER | Richard Hightower |
| CATEGORY | viability |
| EVIDENCE | none |
| VALIDATE BY | 2027-03-15 |

## Risks

### R-001

| | |
|---|---|
| RISK | The expert accepts a weak PRD because the score was high. The grade becomes false assurance, which is worse than no grade. |
| LIKELIHOOD | high |
| IMPACT | high |
| MITIGATION | Blocking defects are counted and reported separately from the score and no score clears them (FR-009); the non-goal in section 6 says explicitly that a grade is evidence, not a warrant; FR-012 puts a buildability verdict in front of the expert before approval. |
| OWNER | Richard Hightower |
| TRIGGER | An expert approves a set with a high score while its buildability review still reports a gap that is neither closed nor owned. |
| RESPONSE | reduce |
| MITIGATION BY | 2027-01-31 |
| STATUS | open |

### R-002

| | |
|---|---|
| RISK | The grading reports findings that are not in the document. The expert catches one, stops trusting all of them, and the grading becomes noise they skip. |
| LIKELIHOOD | high |
| IMPACT | high |
| MITIGATION | Every finding must quote the document, and anything unsupported is dropped before the expert sees it (FR-016, TR-003, TR-006); a refuted finding the document does not support is acknowledged as dropped rather than defended (SC-004). |
| OWNER | Richard Hightower |
| TRIGGER | An expert refutes a finding and the document does not support it. |
| RESPONSE | reduce |
| MITIGATION BY | 2027-01-31 |
| STATUS | open |

### R-003

| | |
|---|---|
| RISK | A fluent, well-structured, well-graded PRD is produced for the wrong product, and the structure makes the error harder to see rather than easier. |
| LIKELIHOOD | medium |
| IMPACT | high |
| MITIGATION | Section 3 asks what would move the objectives without this product at all; section 1 requires evidence per problem and names what is unmeasured. Neither is sufficient, and this risk is not closed. A reader should say so. |
| OWNER | Richard Hightower |
| TRIGGER | A sponsor or an engineering lead says that an approved set specifies the wrong product. |
| RESPONSE | reduce |
| STATUS | open |

### R-004

| | |
|---|---|
| RISK | The interview is too long to finish, so sets are abandoned half-written and the product is remembered as the thing that asked a hundred questions. |
| LIKELIHOOD | medium |
| IMPACT | medium |
| MITIGATION | FR-005 lets the expert end any section and records what was left; FR-015 makes resumption cheap; the working order in the method, which Q-007 tests, puts the sections that unlock the others first, and an abandoned set is still useful. |
| OWNER | Richard Hightower |
| TRIGGER | An expert stops a set with sections still pending and does not resume it (Q-006 and Q-020 count this). |
| RESPONSE | reduce |
| STATUS | open |

### R-005

| | |
|---|---|
| RISK | A set written by one version cannot be read or graded by a later one, and an expert loses weeks of thinking to an upgrade. |
| LIKELIHOOD | low |
| IMPACT | high |
| MITIGATION | NFR-004 makes every set readable with no part of the product running; NFR-009 requires older sets to stay gradable within a major version. |
| OWNER | Richard Hightower |
| TRIGGER | A set written by one version fails to read or grade in a later version with the same major number. |
| RESPONSE | avoid |
| STATUS | open |

## Dependencies

### D-001

| | |
|---|---|
| NEED | An assistant session the expert is already working in, able to carry a long interview and read and write the documents. |
| FROM | The assistant platform the customer already uses |
| BY | 2027-01-31 |
| STATUS | delivered |
| OWNER | Richard Hightower |
| BLOCKS | • ST-001<br>• ST-002 |

### D-002 · Ten first-time domain experts willing to be observed completing a PRD.

| | |
|---|---|
| FROM | Early customers and the professional network |
| BY | 2027-01-31 |
| STATUS | requested |
| OWNER | Richard Hightower |
| BLOCKS | • A-001<br>• A-002<br>• NFR-005 |

### D-003

| | |
|---|---|
| NEED | Three engineering leads willing to read a completed set cold and report what they would ask for first. |
| FROM | Early customers |
| BY | 2027-01-31 |
| STATUS | requested |
| OWNER | Richard Hightower |
| BLOCKS | • A-003<br>• O-001 |

SECTION 12

# Open questions

DRAFT 88/100 NO BLOCKING DEFECTS

| ID | QUESTION | DECIDER | BY | BLOCKS |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Q-001 | Today's first-pass buildability rate | R. Hightower | 2027-02-28 | O-001 |
| Q-002 | Today's days from the first question to an approval | R. Hightower | 2027-02-28 | O-002 |
| Q-003 | Today's share of testable `must` requirements | R. Hightower | 2027-02-28 | O-003 |
| Q-004 | How many organizations are in each segment | R. Hightower | 2027-06-30 | S-001, S-002 |
| Q-005 | Does FR-013 stay `must`, given what sponsors say about grades | R. Hightower | 2027-01-31 | FR-013, TR-001, OUT-003 |
| Q-006 | Sections completed per sitting | R. Hightower | 2027-02-28 | R-004 |
| Q-007 | Does writing the requirements send an expert back to the journeys | R. Hightower | 2027-02-28 | ST-004, FR-010, R-004 |
| Q-008 | Disciplined or incomplete, to an engineering lead | R. Hightower | 2027-02-28 | A-003 |
| Q-009 | Which version of the rubric and the checks release 1 grades against | R. Hightower | 2027-01-31 | FR-004, FR-009, FR-010, FR-011, FR-012, FR-019 |
| Q-010 | Must an answer survive the session before its section is drafted | R. Hightower | 2027-01-31 | FR-015, NFR-011 |
| Q-012 | Which segment converts first | R. Hightower | 2027-06-30 | S-001, S-002 |
| Q-013 | The day rate a buyer pays for a contracted product manager | R. Hightower | 2027-06-30 | S-002 |
| Q-014 | Does ST-004 keep its loop-back, given what experts say | R. Hightower | 2027-02-28 | ST-004, FR-010 |
| Q-015 | Who owns the rubric and the checks | R. Hightower | 2027-01-15 | FR-004, FR-009 to FR-012, FR-019 |
| Q-016 | Must a grade show the rubric version it was made against | R. Hightower | 2027-01-31 | NFR-007 |
| Q-017 | Who owns NFR-006's accessibility | R. Hightower | 2027-02-28 | NFR-006 |

| ID | QUESTION | DECIDER | BY | BLOCKS |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Q-018 | One counted cost per problem in section 1 | R. Hightower | 2027-01-31 | P-001 to P-004 |
| Q-019 | Will D-002 and D-003 commit in writing to report by 2027-01-31 | R. Hightower | 2027-01-31 | REL-001 |
| Q-020 | Which section experts stop at most | R. Hightower | 2027-02-28 | R-004 |
| Q-021 | Who owns NFR-012's access control | R. Hightower | 2027-02-28 | NFR-012 |
| Q-022 | Does REL-001 move or ship as an experiment if D-002 or D-003 is late | R. Hightower | 2027-01-31 | REL-001 |
| Q-023 | Does the delivery lead persona hold | R. Hightower | 2027-05-31 | PER-004 |

### The ones that matter most

**Q-001 to Q-003 are the baselines for all three objectives.** They are due by 2027-02-28, a month before REL-001, so its exit criteria are fixed before it ships. Until they are answered, section 3's targets are provisional. Nothing should be committed to a plan on the strength of them.

**Q-015, Q-009, and Q-010 block the most.** Q-015, who owns the rubric and the checks, is due first, by 2027-01-15, because Q-009 cannot fix a version without an owner. It blocks the same six requirements as Q-009. Q-009 blocks four `must` requirements, FR-004, FR-009, FR-010, and FR-012, and two `should` requirements, FR-011 and FR-019. Those six requirements sit on four release-line stages, ST-002 to ST-005, which can be scaffolded and not finished until Q-009 is answered. Q-010 blocks FR-015, a `should`, and NFR-011. It is the one where guessing breaks assumption A-005 rather than costing rework.

**Q-005 is the one that could invalidate the product's central idea.** If showing a sponsor a grade reduces their confidence rather than raising it, then FR-013 is wrong and the grading becomes an author's private tool rather than part of the approval. It takes two days, and it should be asked early.

**Q-019 and Q-022 are the schedule.** D-002 and D-003 report by 2027-01-31, and the questions they answer are due by 2027-02-28, a month before REL-001. Q-019 decides whether REL-001 keeps its date, and Q-022 decides what happens if either dependency is late.

**Q-008 tests the fifth of the five tests in the glossary: a requirement names no technology.** If engineering leads read the absence of technology as incompleteness, the discipline this whole product enforces is a liability, and A-003 fails.

### Candidate architecture decisions, not questions

Three things the set needs are design choices, not product questions. They go to the engineering lead as candidate architecture decisions, as FR-007 hands over a technology the expert names:

- Where the rubric and the eleven derivability checks live. Q-009 decides only which version release 1 grades against.
- How a grade records the rubric version it was made against. Q-016 decides only whether it must.
- Whether an interview in progress is a document of the set, and where an answer sits before its section is drafted. Q-010 decides only whether the answer must survive the end of the session.

### Honest note

Every decider here is the same person. For a one-person product that is accurate. For anything larger it is a defect, and the first thing to fix when there is a second person.

#### Q-001

| | |
|---|---|
| QUESTION | What share of specifications reaching a development team today pass a buildability review on first submission? |
| DECIDER | Richard Hightower |
| BY | 2027-02-28 |
| BLOCKS | • O-001 |
| SPIKE | Run the eleven derivability checks against ten specifications collected from real client projects done without this product, and count. Time-boxed to 3 days. It depends on Q-009, because the version of the checks must be fixed first. |

#### Q-002

| | |
|---|---|
| QUESTION | How many working days does it take today from the first question put to the domain expert about a product to an approved specification? |
| DECIDER | Richard Hightower |
| BY | 2027-02-28 |
| BLOCKS | • O-002 |
| SPIKE | Reconstruct the timeline from the first question put to the expert to the approval, for five recent projects done without this product. Time-boxed to 2 days. |

#### Q-003

| | |
|---|---|
| QUESTION | What share of `must` functional requirements in today's specifications can an engineer who was not in the interview write a test from? |
| DECIDER | Richard Hightower |
| BY | 2027-02-28 |
| BLOCKS | • O-003 |
| SPIKE | Three engineering leads score the requirements of the same ten specifications from Q-001, independently. Time-boxed to 3 days. |

#### Q-004 · How many organizations are in each segment in section 2?

| | |
|---|---|
| DECIDER | Richard Hightower |
| BY | 2027-06-30 |
| BLOCKS | • S-001<br>• S-002 |
| SPIKE | Name the register or source per segment, and count. Time-boxed to 3 days. |

### Q-005

| | |
|---|---|
| QUESTION | Given what three sponsors say about a set shown with and without grades, does FR-013 stay `must`, with each section's grade shown to the sponsor? |
| DECIDER | Richard Hightower |
| CONSULTED | the first three sponsors |
| BY | 2027-01-31 |
| BLOCKS | • FR-013<br>• TR-001<br>• OUT-003<br>• PER-003 |
| SPIKE | Show three sponsors the same set with and without grades and ask which they would approve. Time-boxed to 2 days. |

### Q-006 · How many sections does an expert complete in one sitting before stopping?

| | |
|---|---|
| DECIDER | Richard Hightower |
| BY | 2027-02-28 |
| BLOCKS | • R-004 |
| SPIKE | Count in D-002's ten observed sittings, held by 2027-01-31. Time-boxed to 1 day after the sittings. |

### Q-007 · Does writing the requirements send an expert back to the journeys?

| | |
|---|---|
| DECIDER | Richard Hightower |
| BY | 2027-02-28 |
| BLOCKS | • ST-004<br>• FR-010<br>• R-004 |
| SPIKE | Count loop-backs in D-002's ten observed sittings, held by 2027-01-31. The answer is yes if at least 3 of the 10 sittings loop back. Time-boxed to 1 day after the sittings. |

### Q-008

| | |
|---|---|
| QUESTION | Does an engineering lead read a PRD that names no technology as disciplined or as incomplete? |
| DECIDER | Richard Hightower |
| CONSULTED | the three engineering leads from D-003 |
| BY | 2027-02-28 |
| BLOCKS | • A-003 |
| SPIKE | Ask each lead, after reading a set cold, whether anything was missing and whether they wanted a technology named. Time-boxed to 1 day. |

### Q-009

**QUESTION** Which version of the rubric and the eleven derivability checks does release 1 grade against?

**DECIDER** Richard Hightower

**BY** 2027-01-31

**BLOCKS**

- FR-004
- FR-009
- FR-010
- FR-011
- FR-012
- FR-019

**SPIKE** List the rubric dimensions of each section and the eleven checks as they stand, and have the decider approve that list as release 1's version. Time-boxed to 1 day. Until it is answered, ST-002 to ST-005 can be scaffolded and not finished.

### Q-010

**QUESTION** Must an answer the expert gave survive the end of the session before its section is drafted, given A-005, that domain content stays in the expert's own session and in the documents?

**DECIDER** Richard Hightower

**BY** 2027-01-31

**BLOCKS**

- FR-015
- NFR-011

**SPIKE** List what an expert must find when they come back after a break (FR-015), and check each item against A-005's boundary. The answer is yes if any item the expert must find is an answer not yet drafted. Time-boxed to 2 days. Guessing this one breaks assumption A-005, which customers rely on, rather than merely costing rework.

### Q-011

**QUESTION** How does an approver record a decision, given that D-001 puts the product inside the expert's session and OUT-003 excludes any view of our own?

**DECIDER** Richard Hightower

**BY** 2027-02-28

**BLOCKS**

- FR-014

**ANSWER** Outside the product, in release 1. The sponsor reads the root document or an exported copy and gives a decision. The expert records it in section 15 under FR-014, with the sponsor's name, role, and date. Section 6 records ST-006 as outside the product.

**ANSWERED** 2026-10-27

### Q-012 · Which segment in section 2 converts first?

**DECIDER** Richard Hightower

**BY** 2027-06-30

**BLOCKS**

- S-001
- S-002

**SPIKE** For the first ten buyers spoken to in each segment, count how many buy by 2027-06-30, and compare the two counts. Time-boxed to 1 day at that date.

### Q-013 · What day rate does a buyer pay to contract a product manager for the writing of one set?

DECIDER Richard Hightower

BY 2027-06-30

BLOCKS
- S-002

SPIKE Ask the buyers in the first ten conversations what they paid the last time. Time-boxed to 1 day.

### Q-014

QUESTION Given how experts describe a loop-back in D-002's sittings, does ST-004 keep its step that sends the expert back to an earlier section?

DECIDER Richard Hightower

BY 2027-02-28

BLOCKS
- ST-004
- FR-010

SPIKE Ask each expert after a loop-back, in D-002's ten observed sittings, held by 2027-01-31. Time-boxed to 1 day after the sittings.

### Q-015 · Who owns the rubric and the eleven derivability checks?

DECIDER Richard Hightower

BY 2027-01-15

BLOCKS
- FR-004
- FR-009
- FR-010
- FR-011
- FR-012
- FR-019

SPIKE Name the person accountable for the content of the rubric and the checks, and confirm with that person that they accept it, before Q-009 fixes a version. Time-boxed to 1 day.

### Q-016 · Must a grade show which version of the rubric it was made against?

DECIDER Richard Hightower

BY 2027-01-31

BLOCKS
- NFR-007

SPIKE Regrade one section of this set against an earlier rubric, and ask three readers whether they need to tell the two grades apart. Time-boxed to 1 day.

### Q-017

QUESTION Whom does the decider record as owner of NFR-006's accessibility, given that the product's output is read in places the non-goals in section 6 say we do not own?

DECIDER Richard Hightower

BY 2027-02-28

BLOCKS
- NFR-006

SPIKE List each place the product's output is read and who controls it, and get that party's written confirmation that they own it. The decider then records the owner. Time-boxed to 2 days.

### Q-018 · What does each problem in section 1 cost, as one counted case per problem?

DECIDER Richard Hightower

BY 2027-01-31

BLOCKS
- P-001
- P-002
- P-003
- P-004

SPIKE For one recent project done without this product, count the engineer days spent re-deriving the specification, the gaps found during build, and the plans changed after approval. Time-boxed to 2 days.

### Q-019

QUESTION Will both parties behind D-002 and D-003 commit in writing to report by 2027-01-31, so that REL-001 keeps 2027-03-31?

DECIDER Richard Hightower

BY 2027-01-31

BLOCKS
- REL-001

SPIKE Ask each party behind D-002 and D-003 for a written date. The answer is yes if both written dates are 2027-01-31 or earlier, and no otherwise, in which case Q-022 decides. Time-boxed to 1 day.

### Q-020 · Which section do experts stop at most often?

DECIDER Richard Hightower

BY 2027-02-28

BLOCKS
- R-004

SPIKE Note the section at each stop in D-002's ten observed sittings, held by 2027-01-31. Time-boxed to 1 day after the sittings.

### Q-021

QUESTION Whom does the decider record as owner of NFR-012's access control, given that a set is stored where the organization already stores documents?

DECIDER Richard Hightower

BY 2027-02-28

BLOCKS
- NFR-012

SPIKE List every path by which someone can read a set and who grants access to it, and get that party's written confirmation that they own it. The decider then records the owner. Time-boxed to 2 days.

### Q-022 · If D-002 or D-003 reports after 2027-01-31, does REL-001 move or ship as an experiment?

DECIDER Richard Hightower

BY 2027-01-31

BLOCKS
- REL-001

SPIKE For each outcome, list which of REL-001's exit criteria can still be judged with the late results, and choose the outcome that leaves more of them judgeable. Time-boxed to 1 day.

## Q-023

**QUESTION** Do delivery leads run a story-mapping workshop about once per release and want a backbone agreed before it, as PER-004 assumes?

**DECIDER** Richard Hightower

**BY** 2027-05-31

**BLOCKS**

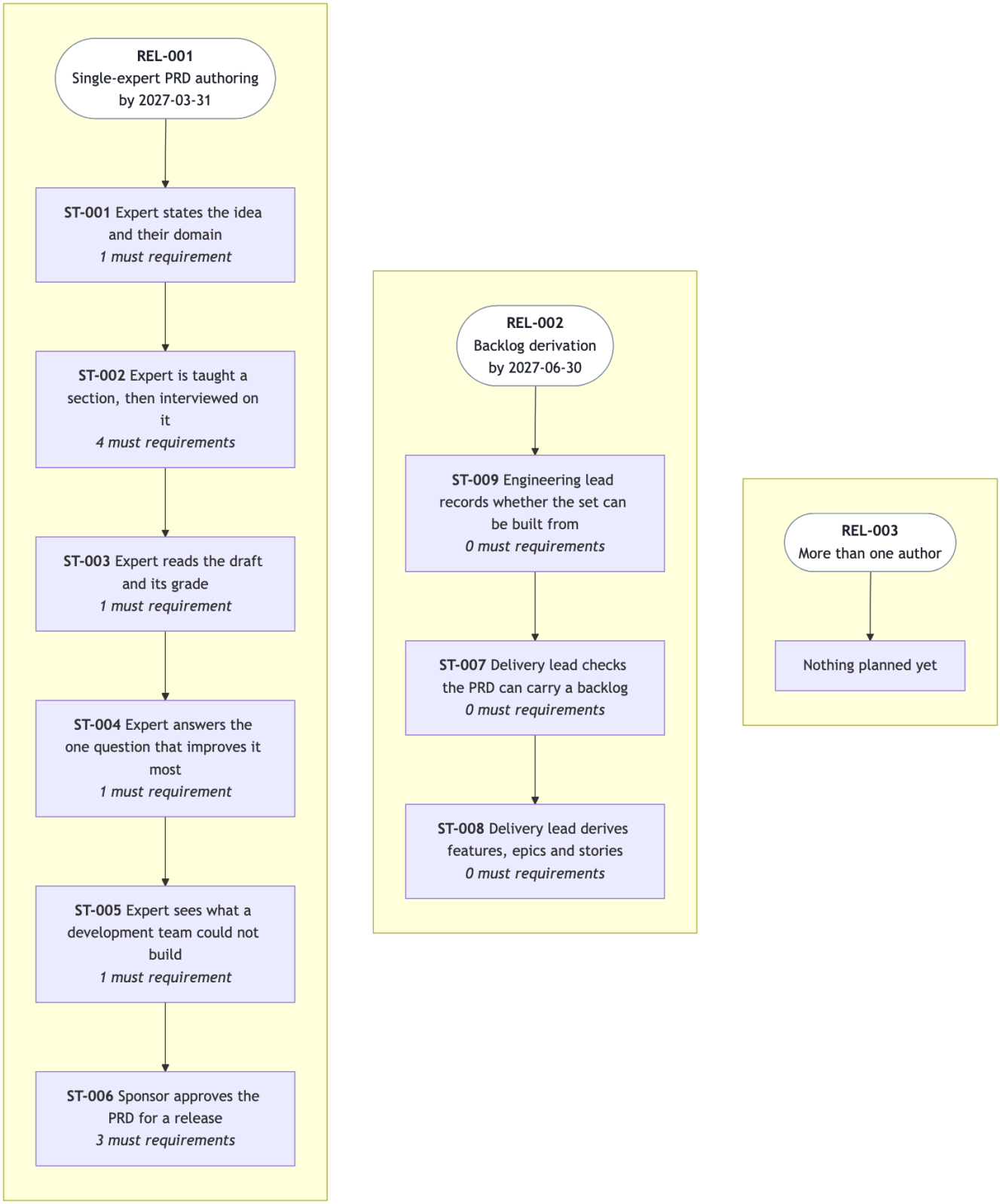
- PER-004

**SPIKE** Ask three delivery leads how often they run the workshop and what they need agreed before it. Time-boxed to 2 days.

SECTION 13

# Release plan

DRAFT 88/100 NO BLOCKING DEFECTS




The release line

| ID | RELEASE | STAGES | TARGET |
|---|---|---|---|
| REL-001 | Single-expert PRD authoring | ST-001..ST-006 | 2027-03-31 |
| REL-002 | Backlog derivation | ST-009, ST-007, ST-008 | 2027-06-30 |
| REL-003 | More than one author | none | none |

### Why this order

REL-001 is exactly the release line in section 6. It is the smallest release in which anyone gets anything: an expert reaching an approved PRD with its buildability review.

REL-002 is deferred rather than cut because the PRD REL-001 produces already has to carry everything a backlog needs, and FR-012 checks precisely that. Deferring the derivation costs nothing; deferring what it needs would have cost a rewrite.

REL-003 waits for evidence that one author's path works at all. It starts when OUT-002's condition holds: three real engagements have each reached an approved set that passed the buildability review on first submission. Building for two authors before one is proven would be building on A-001 and A-002 before either is tested. A sponsor can already comment on an exported copy in REL-001, under FR-022. REL-003 adds comments inside the set, by a reviewer who does not hold the pen, which OUT-005 defers.

### How you know each release worked

REL-001 exits when the pilot PRDs meet the three objective targets in section 3: at least 4 of the 5 pilot PRDs, 80%, pass the buildability review on first submission, the median reaches approval in under 5 working days, and 95% of `must` requirements are testable as written. REL-002 exits when every derived story names its requirement and a delivery lead runs a workshop from the backlog without re-deriving it.

Both target dates are indicative, not committed. The schedule problem below is the reason.

### The schedule problem, stated plainly

REL-001 targets 2027-03-31. D-002 and D-003 in section 11, the ten observed experts and the three engineering leads, are due by 2027-01-31 and are only *requested*. The questions they answer are due by 2027-02-28, a month before REL-001, so REL-001 can use what they find. If either slips, REL-001 moves or ships knowingly as an experiment. Q-019 decides whether the date holds, Q-022 decides what happens if it does not, and Richard Hightower decides both by 2027-01-31.

REL-002 carries no requirements yet. Section 7 holds none for ST-007, ST-008, or ST-009, and they are written when REL-002 is planned.

### Not in this section, deliberately

No tasks, no estimates, no sizing, no team assignments, and no technology milestone. Those come from engineering design and iteration planning.

### REL-001 · Single-expert PRD authoring

**OUTCOMES**

- An expert with no product training, a domain expert or a product manager who speaks for one, can take one product idea to an approved PRD. Only the sponsor's reading, comments, and decision at ST-006 happen outside the product.
- The expert can see, before anyone estimates, which parts of their own PRD a development team could not build from.
- A sponsor can see what they are approving, what is still open, and who decides each open question, in one document.

**JOURNEY STAGES**

- ST-001
- ST-002
- ST-003
- ST-004
- ST-005
- ST-006

**REQUIREMENTS**

- FR-001
- FR-002
- FR-003
- FR-004
- FR-005
- FR-006
- FR-007
- FR-008
- FR-009
- FR-010
- FR-011
- FR-012
- FR-013
- FR-014
- FR-015
- FR-016
- FR-017
- FR-018
- FR-019
- FR-020
- FR-021
- FR-022
- FR-023

**OBJECTIVES**

- O-001
- O-002
- O-003

**DEPENDS ON**

- D-002
- D-003
- Q-019
- Q-022

EXIT CRITERIA

- At least 4 of the 5 pilot PRDs, 80%, pass the buildability review on first submission, where a pass is the verdict `buildable`, or `buildable with gaps` with every gap closed or owned (O-001). The pilot PRDs are as O-001 defines them: the first 5 PRDs written with release 1 by people other than the product's author, between 2027-03-31 and 2027-09-30.
- The median pilot PRD reaches a recorded approval in under 5 working days from the first interview question (O-002).
- An engineer who was not in the interview judges 95% of the pilot PRDs' `must` requirements testable as written (O-003).

TARGET DATE: 2027-03-31

DATE STATUS: indicative

### REL-002 · Backlog derivation

OUTCOMES

- A delivery lead can walk into a story-mapping workshop with features and a release line already derived from the approved PRD.
- A delivery lead sees every story name the requirement id it came from, so nobody has to ask why it exists.
- An engineering lead can record their own verdict on whether an approved set can be built from, with the report of its buildability review kept beside it.

JOURNEY STAGES

- ST-009
- ST-007
- ST-008

OBJECTIVES

- O-001

EXIT CRITERIA

- Every story derived from a pilot PRD names the requirement id it came from.
- A delivery lead runs a story-mapping workshop from a derived backlog without re-deriving any feature from the PRD.

TARGET DATE: 2027-06-30

DATE STATUS: indicative

### REL-003 · More than one author

OUTCOMES

- Two experts can work on different sections of the same set without overwriting each other.
- A reviewer, such as the engineering lead (PER-002), can comment on a section inside the set, not on an exported copy, without being able to change it.

OBJECTIVES

- O-002

DEPENDS ON

- A-001
- A-002

SECTION 14

# Glossary

DRAFT 85/100 NO BLOCKING DEFECTS

| TERM | MOST OFTEN CONFUSED WITH |
|---|---|
| PRD | A design document |
| Golden thread | The most important journey |
| Release line | A date |
| Stage | A screen |
| Rubric | A checklist |
| Blocking defect | A low score |
| Score | A judgement on the product idea |
| Spike | A piece of the product |
| Open question | A risk |
| Non-goal | Out of scope |
| Grade | Score |
| State | Threshold |
| Assumption | An open question |
| Candidate architecture decision | A requirement |
| Buildability review | A grading pass |
| Finding | A blocking defect |
| Root document | Section 1 |
| Approver | The expert |
| Condition | A constraint |
| Constraint | A requirement |
| Objective | A requirement |
| Baseline | A target |
| Version | A release of the product |
| Dependency | A requirement's wait on an open question |
| Backlog | The set |
| Feature | A requirement |

| TERM | MOST OFTEN CONFUSED WITH |
|---|---|
| Story | A requirement |
| Expert | The approver |
| Sponsor | The expert |
| Engineering lead | The expert |
| Delivery lead | The engineering lead |
| Item | A line or a field of an entry |
| Pass | Meeting the gate |
| Scenario | A journey |
| Objection | A refuted finding the document does not support |
| Refute | Showing a finding wrong |
| Gate | The threshold |
| Bet | An objective |
| Buildable | A pass of the buildability review |
| Product manager | The sponsor |
| Out of scope | A non-goal |
| Outcome | A feeling |
| Ready | Offered for approval |
| Offered for approval | Ready |
| Sitting | A session |
| Experiment | A spike |
| Agent | A person |
| Exported copy | The set |
| Escalation | An open question |
| Satisfaction | A measure of the product |
| Pain point | The problem |
| Review comment | A finding |
| Capability | A capability the system needs |
| Delegated | A person deciding on someone's behalf |
| Verdict | A grade |
| Reviewer | A grading pass |

| TERM | MOST OFTEN CONFUSED WITH |
|---|---|
| Approval | An override |
| Engagement | A unit of work |
| Handoff | The handover |
| Journey | A use case |
| Step | A stage |
| Override | An approval |
| Release | The release line |
| Non-functional requirement | A requirement in section 7 |
| Acceptance criteria | Exit criteria |
| Epic | A feature |
| Vocabulary | The glossary |
| Persona | A user |
| Buyer | The user |
| Risk | An assumption |
| Decider | The approver |
| Review | The buildability review |
| Exit criteria | Acceptance criteria |
| Unit of work | An engagement |
| Gap | A blocking defect |
| Wireframe | A design |
| Session | A sitting |

The "Most often confused with" column above is the one that earns its keep. Three of them, golden thread, blocking defect and score, carry a cost when confused: a team picks the wrong journey for release 1, ships a section with a known fault because the number looked good, or believes a well-written PRD means a sound product.

## References

Eight terms come from established practice, and each entry's `source` names where. Where this set departs from the source, the entry says so.


- MoSCoW: "What is MoSCoW Prioritization?", Agile Business Consortium, accessed 2026-10-27, https://www.agilebusiness.org/?p=1907
- Given/When/Then: "Introducing BDD", Dan North, 20 Sep 2006, https://dannorth.net/blog/introducing-bdd/

- Story, epic, and feature: "Epics, Features and User Stories", Mountain Goat Software, last updated 28 Apr 2025, https://www.mountaingoatsoftware.com/blog/stories-epics-and-themes
- Story map and backbone: "The New User Story Backlog is a Map", Jeff Patton & Associates, 8 Oct 2008, updated 12 Apr 2023, https://www.jpattonassociates.com/the-new-backlog/
- Spike: "Spike Solutions", in The Art of Agile Development, 1st ed., James Shore and Shane Warden, 3 Jun 2010, https://www.jamesshore.com/v2/books/aoad1/spike_solutions

### PRD

**MEANING** A written statement of what to build, for whom, why, and how you know it works, plus what not to build. It does not say how to build it.

**SEE ALSO**
- section
- document set

**NOT** A design document. A PRD that names components or technologies has stopped being a PRD and has started being an architecture sketch.

### Document set

**MEANING** The documents that together are one PRD: a root document and one document per section, each linking to the others.

**ABBREVIATION** set

**SEE ALSO**
- PRD

### Golden thread

**MEANING** The one user journey that release 1 must deliver from end to end.

**SEE ALSO**
- journey
- release line

**NOT** The most important journey in general. It is the journey chosen for release 1, which is often the simplest rather than the most valuable.

### Release line

**MEANING** The smallest set of journey stages that completes the golden thread, and so the boundary of what release 1 contains.

**SEE ALSO**
- golden thread
- scope

**NOT** A date or a deadline. It is a line across the journey, not across a calendar.

### Stage

**MEANING** One part of a journey, naming a person, an input, an output and a decision, and holding its steps.

**SEE ALSO**
- journey
- step

**NOT** A screen or a system step. A stage survives a redesign.

### The five tests

**MEANING**

The five properties a statement must have to be a requirement, numbered 1 to 5 in this order: a named user, an outcome a person can see, a pass-or-fail acceptance test, a priority, and no named component or technology.

**SEE ALSO**

- blocking defect

### Rubric

**MEANING**

The stated standard a section is scored against: a set of dimensions, each with written anchors for what a score of 0, 2 and 4 look like.

**SEE ALSO**

- score
- blocking defect

**NOT**

A checklist. A checklist asks whether something is present; a rubric asks how good it is, against written anchors.

### Blocking defect

**MEANING**

A named fault that stops a section advancing however high its score is, such as a requirement that names a technology or an id that refers to nothing.

**SEE ALSO**

- rubric
- score

**NOT**

A low score. Score and blocking defects are counted separately and a high score never clears a blocking defect.

### Score

**MEANING**

A section's total against its rubric, 0 to 100, written by a grading pass and never by hand.

**SEE ALSO**

- rubric
- blocking defect

**NOT**

A measure of whether the product is a good idea. It measures how well the section is written, nothing else.

### Spike

**MEANING**

A piece of work, usually time-boxed, whose only output is an answer to an open question, or a recorded decision. This set widens the source because some of its open questions ask what people will accept, as Q-005 does, and only work with those people answers them.

**SEE ALSO**

- open question

**NOT**

A piece of the product. A spike produces knowledge, not a feature. This set departs from the source, where a spike is a technical investigation. Here a spike may be research with people, as in Q-005, and some run inside a dependency's observed sittings, as Q-006 and Q-007 run in D-002's.

**SOURCE**

Spike Solutions, The Art of Agile Development, 1st ed., James Shore and Shane Warden, 3 Jun 2010, https://www.jamesshore.com/v2/books/aoad1/spike_solutions

### Open question

**MEANING** Something not yet decided, recorded with the one person who decides it and the date by which they must.

**SEE ALSO**
- spike
- assumption

**NOT** A risk. A risk is something that might happen and nobody can simply decide; an open question has a decider.

### Non-goal

**MEANING** Something a reasonable reader would expect the product to do, that it will not do, with no plan to.

**SEE ALSO**
- scope

**NOT** Out of scope. Out of scope means not yet, with a point at which it is revisited. A non-goal means not ever, with a reason.

### Journey

**MEANING** The stages one user goes through to reach one goal with the product, from start to end, in order.

**SEE ALSO**
- stage
- golden thread

**NOT** A use case. A journey covers the whole path to a goal, including steps outside the product.

### Step

**MEANING** What a user does, sees or decides at one point inside a stage.

**SEE ALSO**
- stage
- journey

**NOT** A stage. A stage holds many steps.

### Section

**MEANING** One of the fifteen numbered parts of a PRD, each held in its own document. Section 5 holds two documents, journeys and scenarios, and section 7 holds two, functional requirements and wireframes, so a set has seventeen section documents across fifteen sections. Cross-references in a set are by section number.

**SEE ALSO**
- document set

### Scope

**MEANING** What a release contains and what it does not, set against the journey stages it completes.

**SEE ALSO**
- release line
- non-goal

**NOT** The release line. The release line is the path of stages a release completes, and scope is everything the release includes and leaves out along it.

### Assumption

**MEANING** Something taken on faith that the product depends on, recorded with what would break if it turned out false.

**SEE ALSO**
- open question
- risk

**NOT** An open question. Nobody can simply decide an assumption true; it is validated or falsified.

### Risk

**MEANING** Something that may happen and would damage the product, recorded with a likelihood, an impact, a mitigation and one named owner.

**SEE ALSO**
- assumption
- spike

**NOT** An assumption. An assumption is believed true and must be tested. A risk is an event that may happen, and it is mitigated.

### Readable form

**MEANING** The part of a section a person reads: its prose, its headings and its tables, written to be judged by the expert who gave the answers.

**SEE ALSO**
- section

### Threshold

**MEANING** The score at or above which a section may advance: 70. A score at the threshold is not enough on its own, because the gate also needs no blocking defect.

**SEE ALSO**
- score
- blocking defect

### Grade

**MEANING** A section's score together with its blocking-defect count and its weakest part, the rubric dimension that scored lowest. A grade is what an expert is shown, and a score is one number inside it.

**SEE ALSO**
- score
- grading pass

**NOT** A score. The score is part of the grade, not the whole of it.

### Grading pass

**MEANING** One run of a section or a set against its rubric, producing a grade. It is the only thing that writes a score, and it never changes the document.

**SEE ALSO**
- grade
- rubric

### State

**MEANING** Where a section stands: the state pending, shown to the expert as not started; `draft`, written; `review`, ready for someone else to read, reached through the gate; or `final`, set by the expert under TR-002. LC-001 in section 5 shows each move. The set as a whole reads as not yet approved, approved, approved with conditions, or rejected, by the approval recorded in section 15.

**NOT** A threshold. The threshold is the score a gate needs. The state is where the section stands.

**SEE ALSO**

- threshold
- blocking defect

### Override

**MEANING** An expert's decision to advance a section past a gate it has not met, recorded in the change log with the score at the time.

**SEE ALSO**

- state
- threshold

**NOT** An approval. An override moves one section past its gate, and an approval covers the whole set.

### Verdict

**MEANING** What a buildability review concludes, one of three: `buildable`, `buildable with gaps`, `not buildable`. In ST-009 the engineering lead may record their own verdict, and where it differs, theirs is the verdict and the buildability review's is kept beside it.

**SEE ALSO**

- derivability checks

**NOT** A grade. A grade scores one section against its rubric, and a verdict is the buildability review's conclusion on the whole set.

### Derivability checks

**MEANING** The eleven checks a buildability review runs to decide whether a backlog can be derived from a set. Q-009 asks which edition of them release 1 grades against.

**SEE ALSO**

- verdict
- rubric

### Candidate architecture decision

**MEANING** A technology or design preference the expert stated during the interview, kept out of the requirements and handed to the engineering lead as a topic for an architecture decision record.

**SEE ALSO**

- the five tests

**NOT** A requirement. It is deliberately not one, because it would fail test 5.

### Unit of work

**MEANING** What the expert's domain counts one piece of work as: a load, a claim, a case, a patient. Every question the expert is asked uses their word for it.

**NOT** An engagement. An engagement is the writing of one set with this product, and the unit of work is what the expert's own domain counts.

### Unverified

**MEANING**

A citation that was checked and could not be confirmed against its source. It is marked as such and never stated as fact.

**SEE ALSO**

- expert

### MoSCoW

**MEANING**

The priority scale this set uses: `must`, `should`, `could`, `wont`. This set uses MoSCoW and not RFC 2119's MUST and SHOULD. `wont` keeps the source's meaning, won't have this time: a `wont` item is out of scope and revisited later, not a non-goal.

**SEE ALSO**

- the five tests
- out of scope

**SOURCE**

What is MoSCoW Prioritization?, Agile Business Consortium, accessed 2026-10-27, https://www.agilebusiness.org/?p=1907

### Wireframe

**MEANING**

A sketch of one screen a person works in or one report a person reads. It shows what the person sees and does there, and names the requirements it makes concrete. Every requirement shown in a screen or a report has one, in section 7.

**SEE ALSO**

- the five tests

**NOT**

A design. A wireframe is labeled an illustration, and the development team decides how the screen looks.

### Buildability review

**MEANING**

A reading of the whole set as the engineering lead who has to build it. It runs the eleven derivability checks and reports a verdict and, for each release-line stage, whether a requirement covers it or it is a gap.

**SEE ALSO**

- verdict
- derivability checks
- finding

**NOT**

A grading pass. A grading pass scores one section against its rubric; a buildability review reads the whole set and asks whether a backlog can be derived from it.

### Finding

**MEANING**

One fault that a grading pass or a buildability review reports, with the document it is in quoted. A finding is checked against the document before the expert sees it, and is dropped when the document does not support it.

**SEE ALSO**

- blocking defect
- grading pass
- buildability review

**NOT**

A blocking defect. A blocking defect is one kind of finding, the kind that stops a section advancing. Every blocking defect is reported as a finding, but most findings only lower a score or name a weak dimension.

### Root document

**MEANING**

The one document of a set that every other document names as its parent. It carries the summary, the scope, every section's state and grade, and every open question with its decider and date, and it is what an approver reads.

**SEE ALSO**

- document set
- approver

**NOT**

Section 1. The root document has no section number; section 1 is the problem and opportunity.

### Approver

**MEANING**

A person the set names, by name and role under FR-021, who approves, approves with conditions, or rejects the whole set for a release under TR-001. A set names one or more approvers: the sponsor, or the expert when no sponsor exists. Only a named approver's decision counts. A set approved with conditions reads that way until the approver who stated each condition clears it.

**SEE ALSO**

- condition
- root document
- trust rule

**NOT**

The expert. The expert decides the state of each section; the approver decides on the whole set. They are one person only when no sponsor exists.

### Condition

**MEANING**

What an approver who approves with conditions requires before the approval is unconditional. Each condition names the open question, requirement, or review comment it depends on and a date, and only the approver who stated it clears it. When the sponsor approves while a review comment has no response, the sponsor states a condition on that comment, and the expert records it (FR-014).

**SEE ALSO**

- approver
- open question

**NOT**

A constraint. A condition belongs to one approval and is cleared; a constraint holds for the product and is never cleared.

### Constraint

**MEANING**

A rule the product must obey that the team cannot change by agreeing among themselves, recorded in section 9 with its category, the authority that imposes it by name, and how compliance is shown. A regulation or a standard appears in a constraint only when the expert named it.

**SEE ALSO**

- condition

**NOT**

A requirement. A requirement states what a user can do and has a priority; a constraint limits how every requirement it applies to may be met, and is not prioritized or deferred.

### Objective

**MEANING**

A business result the product is expected to produce, recorded in section 3 with the problems it addresses, one metric, a baseline, a target with a date, and one owner. If the product ships and the metric does not move, the product did not work.

**SEE ALSO**

- baseline

**NOT**

A requirement. An objective says what the business gains; a requirement says what a user can do, and names the objective it serves.

### Baseline

**MEANING**

The value an objective's metric has today, before the product. When it is not known, the baseline says unknown and names the open question that will establish it, and the target is an intention rather than a commitment until the question is answered.

**SEE ALSO**

- objective
- open question

**NOT**

A target. The baseline is where the metric stands now; the target is where the objective says it will be by a date.

### Requirement

**MEANING**

A statement of what one named user can do with the product and the outcome they can see, recorded in section 7 with its acceptance criteria, a priority, the journey stage it serves, and the objective it serves. A statement is a requirement only when it meets the five tests.

**SEE ALSO**

- the five tests
- acceptance criteria
- objective

**NOT**

A story or a feature. A requirement is stated in the PRD, and stories and features are derived from requirements in the backlog.

### Acceptance criteria

**MEANING**

The pass-or-fail statements on a requirement or a journey stage. Each is written as Given a situation, When the person acts, Then what they see, and each is one an engineer who was not in the interview could write a test from. A story derived from a requirement takes the requirement's criteria as its acceptance criteria.

**SEE ALSO**

- requirement
- stage
- the five tests

**NOT**

Exit criteria. Acceptance criteria decide whether one requirement or stage passes, and exit criteria decide whether a whole release is done. This set also departs from the source: North writes acceptance criteria as scenarios, and in this set a scenario is a different thing, a path through journey stages in section 5. The set departs because it writes Given/When/Then on one stage or one requirement, and it needs a separate word for a walk across several stages with real values, which section 5 calls a scenario.

**SOURCE**

Introducing BDD, Dan North, 20 Sep 2006, https://dannorth.net/blog/introducing-bdd/

### Gap

**MEANING**

Something the set does not say that a team needs in order to build: most often a release-line stage that no requirement covers, as a buildability review reports it. A gap is closed with a requirement, or owned as an open question with a decider and a date.

**SEE ALSO**

- buildability review
- release line
- open question

**NOT**

A blocking defect. A gap is a thing the set leaves unsaid, and the buildability review reports each gap as a finding. A blocking defect is a finding that stops a section moving on.

### Version

**MEANING**

A numbered state of the set, recorded in section 15 with its date, its author, and the sections it changed. An approval names the one version it covers, and a change written after an approval records a new version that the approval does not cover.

**SEE ALSO**

- approver
- condition

**NOT**

A release of the product. The product's releases are numbered too, and a set written by one release is read by later ones; a version of the set counts changes to the set.

### Domain

**MEANING**

The field of work the expert specifies software for, such as freight. The expert names it before the first section. It sets the unit of work, the vocabulary every question uses, and the examples each section is taught with. The expert supplies knowledge of the domain; the product does not.

**SEE ALSO**

- unit of work

### Reading order

**MEANING**

The order in which the documents of a set are read: the root document, then the section documents by section number, from section 1 to section 15. Where a section holds two documents, journeys come before scenarios and functional requirements come before wireframes. The next and the previous section of any document follow this order.

**SEE ALSO**

- section
- root document

### Interview

**MEANING**

The questions the expert answers about one section in stage ST-002, after reading what the section is for. It ends as the question list says. Only the expert answers in it, so an engineer who reads the set later was not in the interview.

**SEE ALSO**

- section
- candidate architecture decision

### Handover

**MEANING**

The point at which the approved set reaches the engineering lead who has to build from it. Journey J-002 starts there: its trigger is that the PRD has been approved for a release, and its first stage, ST-009, takes the approved set and the report of its buildability review. A set is handed over only once it is approved.

**SEE ALSO**

- approver
- candidate architecture decision

### Dependency

**MEANING**

Something outside the product that the product relies on, recorded in section 11 with what happens if it is not there, such as D-001, an assistant session the expert is already working in.

**SEE ALSO**

- assumption
- risk

**NOT**

A requirement's wait on an open question. A requirement that waits on a question names the question, and the question lists the requirement in what it blocks.

### Backlog

**MEANING**

The features, epics and stories a delivery lead derives from an approved set, in stages ST-007 and ST-008 of journey J-002. Every level of it names the id it came from.

**SEE ALSO**

- feature
- epic
- story

**NOT**

The set. The set says what the product must do; the backlog is derived from it once it is approved.

### Feature

**MEANING**

The backlog item for one journey stage, carrying the ids of the requirements on that stage. The set departs from the source here: the source makes a feature any story big enough to be released, and this set makes it one journey stage, so every story traces to the backbone, which in this set is the journey stages.

**SEE ALSO**

- backlog
- stage

**NOT**

A requirement. A feature holds every requirement of one stage. Also not the everyday sense in section 1, where a "feature list" is a list of features with no named user.

**SOURCE**

Epics, Features and User Stories, Mountain Goat Software, updated 28 Apr 2025, https://www.mountaingoatsoftware.com/blog/stories-epics-and-themes

### Epic

**MEANING**

A group of backlog items that one release delivers. The source defines an epic as a large user story. This set keeps that it is large, and fixes its size by the release rather than by judgment, so that each release's backlog is one group a delivery lead can plan, as ST-008's epics scoped by the release line need.

**SEE ALSO**

- backlog
- release line

**NOT**

A feature. A feature covers one journey stage, and an epic covers the stages one release delivers.

**SOURCE**

Epics, Features and User Stories, Mountain Goat Software, updated 28 Apr 2025, https://www.mountaingoatsoftware.com/blog/stories-epics-and-themes

### Story

**MEANING**

The backlog item for one requirement, in the persona's own words, with the requirement's acceptance criteria as its own.

**SEE ALSO**

- backlog
- requirement
- acceptance criteria

**NOT**

A requirement. The requirement is in the set; the story is derived from it. This set departs from the source, where a story is anything a user wants. Here each story is bound to exactly one requirement, so every story carries the requirement id it came from, which is J-002's need.

**SOURCE**

Epics, Features and User Stories, Mountain Goat Software, updated 28 Apr 2025, https://www.mountaingoatsoftware.com/blog/stories-epics-and-themes

### Expert

**MEANING**

The person who holds the domain knowledge in the interview, persona PER-001: the domain expert, or a product manager who speaks for one. The expert answers the interviews, owns the set, decides what the product must do, the domain's own terms, and the state of each section, and is the only one who may state a domain fact as true.

**SEE ALSO**

- domain
- interview
- sponsor

**NOT**

The approver. The expert approves their own set only when no sponsor exists, under TR-001.

### Sponsor

**MEANING**

The person who commits budget and a date, persona PER-003, and who approves the set for a release under TR-001. The sponsor may approve, approve with conditions, or reject.

**SEE ALSO**

- approver
- expert

**NOT**

The expert. Where no sponsor exists, the expert approves their own set under TR-001, and the change log records that no separate approver existed.

### Engineering lead

**MEANING**

The person who has to build from the approved set, persona PER-002. The engineering lead receives the set at handover, records their own verdict on its buildability review in ST-009, and receives each candidate architecture decision.

**SEE ALSO**

- handover
- buildability review
- candidate architecture decision

**NOT**

The expert. The engineering lead was not in the interview and builds from what the set says, not from what the expert meant.

### Delivery lead

**MEANING**

The person who turns an approved set into a backlog and runs the story-mapping workshop, persona PER-004, in stages ST-007 and ST-008.

**SEE ALSO**

- backlog
- engineering lead

**NOT**

The engineering lead. The delivery lead plans the work from the set, and the engineering lead builds it.

### Persona

**MEANING**

A named role from section 4, such as PER-001, the expert. Every requirement, journey, and trust rule names the persona it serves or who acts.

**SEE ALSO**

- expert
- journey

**NOT**

A user. Anyone who uses the product is a user, and a persona is one named role with its own goals.

### Item

**MEANING**

One numbered entry in a section with its own id, such as a problem, a persona, a stage, a requirement, or an open question. A section is made of its items and the prose around them.

**SEE ALSO**

- id
- section

**NOT**

A line or a field of an entry. A requirement and all its acceptance criteria are one item.

### Id

**MEANING**

The label that names one item, such as FR-008 or Q-001. Each id is unique in the set, and ids are never renumbered or reused.

**SEE ALSO**

- item
- link

### Link

**MEANING**

A reference from one item to another by its id, such as the journey stage a requirement serves or the requirements an open question blocks.

**SEE ALSO**

- id

### Priority

**MEANING**

How much a requirement or a scenario matters to a release, stated in MoSCoW terms. Only the expert gives a priority.

**SEE ALSO**

- MoSCoW

### Teaching

**MEANING**

What the expert is told about a section before its interview: what it is, why it matters, and what belongs in it, in no more than ten lines and with an example from the expert's domain.

**SEE ALSO**

- interview
- domain

### Decider

**MEANING**

The one named person who makes one decision: who answers an open question by its date, or who decides under one trust rule in section 10, whose table names that person in its Decider column.

**SEE ALSO**

- open question
- trust rule

**NOT**

The approver. The approver decides only whether the whole set is approved for a release, under TR-001, and is the decider of that one rule.

### Release

**MEANING**

A numbered release, such as REL-001, with its outcomes, its exit criteria, and the journey stages it completes when it has any. The first release holds exactly the release line.

**SEE ALSO**

- release line
- scope
- exit criteria

**NOT**

The release line. The release line is the smallest set of stages that completes the golden thread, and a release is what ships. Release 1 ships exactly the release line.

### Vocabulary

**MEANING**

The unit of work and the words the expert says an outsider would misread, each with the expert's own meaning. The expert states it once, before the first section. Every later question uses it, and it does not change when the expert resumes.

**SEE ALSO**

- unit of work
- domain

**NOT**

The glossary. The vocabulary is the few words the expert states at the start, and the glossary holds every domain term of the set.

### Engineer

**MEANING**

Anyone on the team who builds from the set and was not in the interview. The engineering lead is one. An acceptance criterion is good only when an engineer could write a test from it.

**SEE ALSO**

- engineering lead
- acceptance criteria

**AVOID**

- builder

### Scenario

**MEANING**

One concrete path a persona takes through one or more journey stages, recorded in section 5 with its steps and the outcome they see. A scenario shows a stage working, or failing, with real content.

**SEE ALSO**

- journey
- stage

**NOT**

A journey. The journey names the stages, and a scenario walks one path through them.

### Trust rule

**MEANING**

A rule in section 10 that names who decides one decision, at which stages, on what evidence, and what happens when that person is away. A person decides every rule. A rule marked never delegated also has no agent proposal behind it.

**SEE ALSO**

- approver
- override

### Story-mapping workshop

**MEANING**

The meeting in which the delivery lead and the team map a backlog against the journeys of an approved set. It needs a backbone agreed before it starts.

**SEE ALSO**

- backbone
- backlog
- delivery lead

**SOURCE**

The New User Story Backlog is a Map, Jeff Patton & Associates, 8 Oct 2008, updated 12 Apr 2023, https://www.jpattonassociates.com/the-new-backlog/

### Backbone

**MEANING**

The ordered journey stages that a story-mapping workshop maps features against, because a story map needs an order of work to hang its stories on. A set with no journey gives the workshop no backbone, so the workshop invents one in the room. This set departs from the source, where the backbone is the capabilities the system needs. In this set the backbone is the journey stages, including stages that happen outside the product.

**SEE ALSO**

- journey
- story-mapping workshop

**SOURCE**

The New User Story Backlog is a Map, Jeff Patton & Associates, 8 Oct 2008, updated 12 Apr 2023, https://www.jpattonassociates.com/the-new-backlog/

### Question list

**MEANING**

The questions an interview may put for one section. The interview ends when the list is finished, when the expert says they have nothing more to add, or earlier, when the expert's answers would already meet the gate.

**SEE ALSO**

- interview

### Gate

**MEANING**

What a section must meet to move to its next state. For `review`, a score at or above the threshold with no blocking defect, in a set that checks clean. The expert may override a gate, and the override is recorded.

**SEE ALSO**

- state
- override
- threshold

**NOT**

The threshold. The threshold is the score alone, and a gate also needs no blocking defect. Also not the everyday sense in sections 1 and 10, where "gates an engineer would have to invent" means decision points the set left unstated.

### Out of scope

**MEANING**

Something the product will not do in a release, with a point at which it is revisited, recorded in section 6.

**SEE ALSO**

- non-goal
- scope

**NOT**

A non-goal. A non-goal is never done, and an out-of-scope item is not done yet.

### Objection

**MEANING**

A finding that the document supports and that the expert refutes. Its reason is stated to the expert once, and the expert's decision is recorded. The decision is reaffirmed when the expert keeps it after hearing the reason. A finding that names the same item for the same reason is the same objection, and a later grading pass does not raise it again as new.

**SEE ALSO**

- finding
- grading pass

**NOT**

A refuted finding the document does not support. A finding of this kind is dropped, not kept as an objection.

### Refute

**MEANING**

To challenge a finding, or a score through its findings. The finding is then checked against the document. If the document does not support it, it is dropped and the expert is told. If the document supports it, it stays as an objection, and the expert's decision is recorded.

**SEE ALSO**

- finding
- objection

**AVOID**

- dispute

**NOT**

Showing a finding wrong. A refuted finding can still stand, when the document supports it.

### Session

**MEANING**

The assistant conversation the expert is already working in, which the product works inside, as dependency D-001 records. The session shows what the product shows, and it carries any number of people working at once. A session ends when that conversation ends, and the set stays where it was written.

**SEE ALSO**

- dependency

**NOT**

A sitting, which is a stretch of time spent on the work and can span more than one session.

### Change log

**MEANING**

Section 15, which records each version of the set with its date, its author, and the sections it changed, and every approval and override.

**SEE ALSO**

- version
- approver
- override

### Target

**MEANING**

The value a measure must reach: where an objective says it will be, or what a non-functional requirement must meet, such as under 20 seconds at p95.

**SEE ALSO**

- objective
- baseline

### Exit criteria

**MEANING** What must be true before a release counts as done, stated with each release in section 13.

**SEE ALSO**
- release

**NOT** Acceptance criteria. Acceptance criteria decide one requirement or stage, and exit criteria decide the whole release.

### Non-functional requirement

**MEANING** A quality the product must have, such as speed, accessibility, or retention, recorded in section 8 with a measure and a target. It applies across requirements, not to one user's capability.

**SEE ALSO**
- requirement
- target

**NOT** A requirement in section 7. A requirement names a user and what they can do.

### Bet

**MEANING** The one outcome the product stakes itself on, stated in the root document's summary: what the expert reaches with the product. The summary's objective and measure say how anyone will know it happened.

**SEE ALSO**
- summary
- objective

**NOT** An objective. An objective is measured, and the bet is the outcome the objective measures.

### Summary

**MEANING** The opening of the root document, which states in a few sentences the problem, the users, why now, the bet, the one objective that proves it, and how it is measured. An approver reads it first.

**SEE ALSO**
- root document
- objective

### Glossary

**MEANING** Section 14, this section. It gives each domain term one meaning, and every requirement and acceptance criterion uses those words.

**SEE ALSO**
- vocabulary

### View

**MEANING** What the expert has in front of them at one moment, such as one section or its grade.

**SEE ALSO**
- section

### Topic

**MEANING** One subject inside a section's interview, such as one requirement or one stage. A follow-up question finishes a topic before the next one opens.

**SEE ALSO**
- interview
- question list

### Ready

**MEANING** The condition a section meets before it moves to the state `review`: it meets the gate and the expert accepts it, or the expert overrides the gate and the override is recorded.

**SEE ALSO**
- state
- gate

**NOT** Offered for approval. Ready describes one section. The expert decides, under TR-010, whether the whole set may be offered for approval. Ready is also not a verdict of the buildability review.

### Capability

**MEANING** The first part of a requirement: what one named user can do with the product, in their own words.

**SEE ALSO**
- requirement
- outcome

**NOT** A capability the system needs, as the backbone's source uses the word. In this set a capability belongs to one user, and the backbone is the journey stages.

### Outcome

**MEANING** The second part of a requirement: what the user sees or has once the capability exists, stated so that someone else could check it.

**SEE ALSO**
- requirement
- capability

**NOT** A feeling. "They feel confident" is not an outcome a tester can check.

### Problem

**MEANING** A condition a named persona suffers today, recorded in section 1 with counted evidence, why it matters now, and what it costs to leave it.

**SEE ALSO**
- persona
- objective

### Approval

**MEANING** The approver's recorded decision on one version of the set: approve, approve with conditions, or reject, with the approver, their role, the date, and the version. A rejection is an approval record too. An approval covers only the version it names, and a later change records a new version that it does not cover.

**SEE ALSO**
- approver
- condition
- version

**NOT** An override. An override moves one section past its gate, and an approval is a decision on the whole set.

### Engagement

**MEANING** One piece of work in which one expert writes one set with this product, from the first question to the approval. TR-001 covers an engagement with no sponsor.

**SEE ALSO**
- expert
- sponsor

**NOT** A unit of work. The unit of work is what the expert's own domain counts.

### Lifecycle

**MEANING** The states one thing passes through and the moves between them, with the person who makes each move, recorded in section 5. LC-001 is the lifecycle of a section of the set.

**SEE ALSO**
- state
- scenario

### Handoff

**MEANING** The point at which one stage's work passes to the next person or the next stage, named on each journey stage.

**SEE ALSO**
- stage
- handover

**NOT** The handover. The handover is the one handoff at which the approved set reaches the engineering lead.

### Segment

**MEANING** A group of organizations that would buy the product for the same reason, recorded in section 2 with its buyer and its user, such as S-001.

**SEE ALSO**
- buyer

### Buyer

**MEANING** The person in a segment who decides to pay for the product, such as a principal or a practice lead.

**SEE ALSO**
- segment

**NOT** The user. The buyer pays, and the user is the person who works with the product, such as the consultant with the domain knowledge.

### Status quo

**MEANING** What a buyer does today with no product: a smart practitioner, a document, and a willing engineer. Section 2 records it as a competitor, because every buyer already has it.

**SEE ALSO**
- segment

### Delegated

**MEANING** Given to an agent to propose. Section 10 marks for each trust rule whether an agent may propose its outcome, and the person the rule names still decides. A rule that is never delegated has no agent proposal at all.

**SEE ALSO**
- trust rule
- agent

**NOT** Decided by a person on someone else's behalf. A person who decides while the decider is away does so under the rule's escalation, and that is not delegation.

### Definition of done

**MEANING** The conditions every backlog item must meet before the team counts it as done. The delivery lead needs the set's constraints to arrive as items of it, not as surprises, in J-002.

**SEE ALSO**
- backlog
- constraint

### Checks clean

MEANING

Every id and every link in the set resolves to an item or a document that exists, and every document has the parts its section needs.

SEE ALSO

- gate
- link

### Pilot PRD

MEANING

One of the first 5 PRDs written with release 1 by people other than the product's author. O-001 and REL-001's exit criteria count them.

SEE ALSO

- first submission
- release

### First submission

MEANING

The first time a PRD goes through the buildability review. Only that first verdict counts, so no gap fixed after it changes the result.

SEE ALSO

- buildability review
- pilot PRD

### Reviewer

MEANING

A person who comments on a section inside the set without being able to change it, as REL-003 plans. No persona in release 1 is a reviewer. In release 1 a sponsor comments on an exported copy instead, as a review comment.

SEE ALSO

- review

NOT

A grading pass. The grading pass that scores a section is not a person.

### Iteration

MEANING

One fixed period of the development team's work after the PRD is approved. "Iteration three" means late in the build, after the plan is made.

SEE ALSO

- release

### Review

MEANING

The state `review`, which a section enters once it is ready. In this state, someone other than the expert may read it.

SEE ALSO

- state
- buildability review
- reviewer

NOT

The buildability review, which is its own term, or the expert reading a draft, which the set calls reading.

### Pass

**MEANING**

A PRD passes the buildability review when its verdict is `buildable`, or `buildable with gaps` with every gap closed or owned, as O-001 defines.

**SEE ALSO**

- buildability review
- verdict
- first submission

**NOT**

Meeting the gate, or a grading pass. A section meets the gate, a grading pass is one run of the rubric, and a PRD passes the buildability review.

### Indicative

**MEANING**

Said of a release date the plan aims at and has not committed to, marked indicative in section 13.

**SEE ALSO**

- release

### Follow-up

**MEANING**

A further question about the answer just given, asked before the next topic opens, when the answer leaves something the section needs unanswered or could be written into the section in two ways.

**SEE ALSO**

- interview
- topic

### Specification

**MEANING**

In the general sense only: a requirements document written without this method, as section 1 and Q-001 use the word. This set calls itself a PRD, and calls the documents that make it up the set.

**SEE ALSO**

- prd
- document set

### Development team

**MEANING**

The people who build from an approved set: the engineering lead, the delivery lead, and the engineers, as section 4 names them.

**SEE ALSO**

- engineering lead
- delivery lead
- engineer

### Offered for approval

**MEANING**

Said of a set the expert has decided, under TR-010 in stage ST-005, may go to the approver, as its root document or an exported copy. A set offered for approval reads as not approved until the approver decides.

**SEE ALSO**

- ready
- approver
- exported copy

**NOT**

Ready. Ready describes one section, and a set is offered for approval as a whole.

### Sitting

**MEANING** A stretch of time an expert spends on the work, such as one of the 6 to 9 working sittings per PRD in section 4, or one of D-002's ten observed sittings. One sitting can span more than one session.

**SEE ALSO**
- session

**NOT** A session. A session is the assistant conversation the product works inside.

### Loop-back

**MEANING** A return to an earlier section because a later one showed it was incomplete, such as writing the requirements sending the expert back to the journeys. ST-004 allows it, and Q-007 counts loop-backs in D-002's observed sittings.

**SEE ALSO**
- section
- sitting

### Experiment

**MEANING** A release shipped while assumptions it depends on are still untested, and said to be so. Section 13 names this as REL-001's course if D-002 or D-003 reports late, and Q-022 decides it.

**SEE ALSO**
- release
- assumption

**NOT** A spike. A spike produces an answer, and an experiment ships a release.

### Agent

**MEANING** Software that proposes an outcome under a trust rule section 10 marks as delegable to an agent, such as TR-003's score and findings. The person the rule names accepts or refutes what it proposes.

**SEE ALSO**
- delegated
- trust rule

**NOT** A person. Every decider in section 10 is a person.

### Exported copy

**MEANING** The set in a form the sponsor reads outside the product, in place of the root document, as in ST-006.

**SEE ALSO**
- root document
- offered for approval

**NOT** The set. The set is its documents, and an exported copy is one form of them for reading.

### Review comment

**MEANING**

A comment a person reading an exported copy leaves in that copy. In release 1 that person is the sponsor (FR-022). The expert brings it back into the set and records a response with one of three statuses: accepted, when the set changed because of it; declined, when the set did not change, with the reason; or answered, when it asked a question and the set did not need to change (FR-023). Until it has a response, it is open, which is not an open question in section 12.

**SEE ALSO**

- exported copy
- sponsor
- finding
- reviewer

**NOT**

A finding. A finding comes from a grading pass or a buildability review, and a review comment comes from a person reading a copy.

### Buildable

**MEANING**

Said of a set a development team can estimate and build from without re-deriving it, which a buildability review reports as the verdict `buildable`.

**SEE ALSO**

- verdict
- buildability review

**NOT**

A pass. A set with gaps can pass the buildability review when every gap is closed or owned, and it is still not buildable while any gap is left.

### Product manager

**MEANING**

A person who writes product requirements for a living. PER-001 is a product manager who is, or speaks for, the domain expert, and the set calls that person the expert.

**SEE ALSO**

- expert

**NOT**

The sponsor. A product manager writes the set, and the sponsor approves it.

### Re-grade

**MEANING**

A later grading pass on the same section, against the same rubric, after the section changed.

**SEE ALSO**

- grading pass
- grade

### Escalation

**MEANING**

What happens to a decision when its decider is away or disagrees, as each trust rule in section 10 states.

**SEE ALSO**

- trust rule
- decider

**NOT**

An open question. An open question waits for an answer. An escalation names who acts when the decider cannot.

### Satisfaction

**MEANING** How one journey stage feels to the person today, from 1 (worst) to 5 (best), as the expert scores it in section 5. Only the expert gives it.

**SEE ALSO**

- stage
- journey
- expert

**NOT** A measure of the product. The product never estimates it.

### Pain point

**MEANING** What is hard for a person at one journey stage today, recorded in section 5 with the need that answers it.

**SEE ALSO**

- stage
- problem

**NOT** The problem in section 1. The problem is the whole cost. A pain point is one part of it at one stage.

SECTION 15

# Change log and approvals

DRAFT 75/100 NO BLOCKING DEFECTS

| VERSION | DATE | AUTHOR | WHAT CHANGED |
|---|---|---|---|
| 0.12.0 | 2026-10-30 | Richard Hightower | The root names its approver by name and role (FR-021) and shows the approver the scope, each section's state and grade, the open questions, and any blocking defect (FR-013); TR-015 keeps the domain check's research on by default and lets the expert turn it off for a set, PER-001's authority includes that right, and an organization's own policy can forbid it; NFR-008 and A-005 state that default |
| 0.11.0 | 2026-10-29 | Richard Hightower | FR-023 split out of FR-022 for the expert's import and response; the open-comment approval rule moved into FR-014, and the sponsor sets each condition's date; OUT-005 defers comments inside the set to REL-003; WF-011 shows an open comment; NFR-009 counts product releases; ST-009 hands off to the development team; section 10 says "delegable to an agent"; the glossary adds escalation, satisfaction, and pain point, and separates ready from review |
| 0.10.0 | 2026-10-28 | Richard Hightower | FR-022 added as a should: a sponsor's comments on an exported copy come back, each with a response, and an open one at approval becomes a condition; WF-011 shows the answered copy; IN-007, REL-001, TR-001, and the glossary include it; REL-003 keeps comments inside the set |
| 0.9.0 | 2026-10-27 | Richard Hightower | Counted evidence and sourced why-now claims; persona roles and frequencies; satisfaction scores; ST-006 outside the product; FR-019 to FR-021 added; FR-014 rejection; TR-014 for accepting a score; LC-001 back to draft; C-004 out of section 9; single questions due before REL-001; sourced glossary terms with one meaning each; the versioning policy |
| 0.8.1 | 2026-10-27 | Richard Hightower | Glossary terms, observable scenario outcomes, open questions named in section 7, competitor edges; C-001 to C-003 and S-003 moved; ST-009 for the engineering lead |
| 0.8.0 | 2026-10-27 | Richard Hightower | Requirement and scenario priorities, SC-007, release exit criteria, single deciders |
| 0.7.0 | 2026-10-27 | Richard Hightower | Root objective, primary persona and approver; release id in scope; LC-001 rule |
| 0.6.0 | 2026-10-27 | Richard Hightower | Links between problems, personas, objectives, competitors, trust-rule stages, and scenario views |
| 0.5.0 | 2026-10-26 | Richard Hightower | Given/When/Then acceptance on every stage; LC-001; scenario wireframe links; persona short names |
| 0.4.0 | 2026-10-26 | Richard Hightower | Navigation and refresh requirements; wireframes rewritten from their grading |
| 0.3.0 | 2026-10-26 | Richard Hightower | Wireframes for the requirements shown on a screen or in a report, and the term wireframe |
| 0.2.0 | 2026-10-26 | Richard Hightower | J-001's goal without the engineering lead's confirmation; FR-003 and FR-004 outcomes; FR-015 and FR-016 split out; the threshold stated as 70; NFR-010 to NFR-012; TR-007 to TR-012 |
| 0.1.0 | 2026-10-23 | Richard Hightower | First draft of sixteen section documents across fifteen sections |

### 0.9.0, what changed

- **Section 1:** each problem has one counted case with its source and date, and each why-now claim cites the General Assembly survey of product managers. Desired outcomes name no mechanism, and Q-018 asks for one counted cost per problem.
- **Section 2:** ChatPRD is the direct competitor. Why-we-win is one sentence we expect the sponsor to say, each buyer is PER-003, and "client contract" names the contract where "engagement" did.
- **Section 3:** O-001 counts the 5 pilot PRDs and defines a pass, O-002 counts the pilot PRDs with one journey, and O-003 counts a requirement testable when two of three engineering leads agree.
- **Section 4:** on the expert's decision, PER-001 is a senior product manager in a consultancy or an in-house product team who is, or speaks for, the domain expert. Each persona has a population, a frequency per organization, a basis, a context, and its problems, and no persona is external.
- **Section 5:** each stage carries the expert's satisfaction score, and each pain point names its stage. ST-006 happens outside the product. LC-001 makes final the expert's decision under TR-002, and lets a section at review or final go back to draft. SC-004 splits into SC-004 and SC-008.
- **Section 6:** ST-006 is outside the product, and teams new to a domain are covered by the first non-goal.
- **Section 7:** FR-019 and FR-020, both `should`, split out of FR-004 and FR-008. FR-014 records a rejection. FR-015 moves to ST-004. WF-001 draws FR-020, and the wireframes name no tool.
- **Section 8:** the NFRs name what they time, and NFR-010 and NFR-012 are measured in a test organization.
- **Section 9:** on the expert's decision, C-004 leaves, and the section may be empty. Its rule now lives in TR-005 in section 10 and FR-006 in section 7.
- **Section 10:** TR-003 only produces a score, and TR-014 has the expert accept or refute it. TR-001 covers a rejection. The three delegable rules propose and never decide.
- **Section 11:** R-001 and R-002 are mitigated by 2027-01-31, and D-002 and D-003 report by 2027-01-31.
- **Section 12:** each question is single, and those that block REL-001, including the baselines Q-001 to Q-003, are due by 2027-02-28. Q-011 is answered. Q-019 splits into Q-019 and Q-022, and Q-023 tests PER-004.
- **Section 13:** REL-001 depends on D-002, D-003, Q-019, and Q-022.
- **Section 14:** eight terms cite a verified source, and review, pass, refute, approval, and engagement each have one meaning. Session, buildable, development team, and the general sense of specification are defined. Ready describes one section, and offered for approval describes the set. Sitting, loop-back, experiment, agent, and exported copy are defined.
- **Section 15:** the versioning policy, a 0.5.0 entry, and the date the set is offered for approval, 2027-03-15.
- **Section 7 and section 10:** on the expert's decision, FR-021, a `must`, lets the expert name each approver by name and role before offering the set. TR-001's decider stays the sponsor's role.

None of this is structural under the policy. Richard Hightower decided this on 2026-10-27. ST-006 stays on the release line with the same goal and end state, and no stage is added, removed, or reordered. PER-001's new wording changes no stage. The release line's text now quotes the existing end state, and ST-006 is done outside the product.

### Versioning policy before 1.0

The set and the product share one version number. The number changes by these rules:

- A patch, such as 0.9.0 to 0.9.1, is for a correction that changes what a sentence means. A typo fix gets no version.
- A minor version, such as 0.8 to 0.9, is for new content in the set or in the product.

- A change to the release line or to the golden thread takes the set to the next major version. From 0.x, the next major version is 1.0.

A change to the golden thread or to the release line is structural: adding, removing, or reordering a stage, or changing the journey's goal or end state. Rewording a stage's text or its acceptance is not such a change, and it takes a minor version at most.

The expert set this policy at 0.9.0, and it applies from 0.9.0 onward. From 0.9.0, a reader can rely on the version number to follow it. Earlier version numbers stay as recorded. Two earlier versions do not follow it, and neither is reissued:

- 0.8.1 added stage ST-009 and moved items between sections. Under this policy it would have been the next minor version.
- 0.2.0 changed the golden thread. Under this policy it takes the set to 1.0.

Product 0.5.1 changed only the product, so the log has no entry for it.

### 0.2.0, what the grading changed

The reviewers that graded 0.1.0 were the product's own, run against its own PRD. They found twelve blocking defects and four failed derivability checks. The largest single finding was that FR-009, FR-010 and FR-011 were written against "its rubric" and "its threshold" with neither defined anywhere in the set: the threshold is now stated as 70 in the requirements themselves, and the rubric, the section states and the derivability checks are defined in section 14 as the product content they are.

Two findings were checked and **rejected**: the claim that "see section 6" pointed at the wrong document, and the claim that the section count was contradicted. Both came from reading file numbers as section numbers. The references were right; the numbering was unexplained, which is now fixed in the root document.

### 0.1.0, what to know

Written as prd-forge's own first exercise. Three things a reader should carry forward:

1. **No baselines.** All three objectives carry an explicit unknown with a matching open question (Q-001 to Q-003). The targets are intentions, not commitments.
2. **C-001 is the tension.** The product is delivered inside an assistant session. Naming that in a requirement would fail test 5, so it is recorded as a constraint. A reviewer may fairly call it architecture. At 0.8.1 it moved to section 6 as a non-goal, and the session it needs is dependency D-001 in section 11.
3. **R-003 is not closed.** Nothing in this product checks whether the product being specified should exist at all.

### Approvals

None sought. This set is at `draft` and has not been offered for approval. It cannot be approved for a release without an approval recorded here, under TR-001. A section reaches `final` when the expert sets it final, under TR-002.

The set is offered for approval by 2027-03-15. Under FR-021 its one named approver is Richard Hightower, the owner of the place where this PRD is kept, in the sponsor's role, PER-003. Richard Hightower is also its author and owner, so this is a self-approval, and the entry will say so. When an outside reader reviews the set, their review is recorded beside the approval.

Each approval is recorded with the version, the approver's name and role, the date, and the decision. An approval with conditions records each condition as "conditional on <id> by <date>", where the id is the open question, requirement,

or review comment the condition depends on, as FR-014 and FR-022 require. Only the approver who stated a condition clears it. A rejection records its reason.

At 0.9.0 the expert holds every other section to a score over 80, except section 2 until Q-004 and Q-005 are answered, and accepts this section below 80 until the set is offered for approval on 2027-03-15, because its rubric cannot score approvals and conditions higher before an approval exists.

> **The root names its approver by name and role under FR-021, and its details block now carri**
>
> VERSION 0.12.0
>
> DATE 2026-10-30
>
> AUTHOR Richard Hightower
>
> SECTIONS
> - 4
> - 8
> - 10
> - 11

> **FR-023 split out of FR-022: FR-022 is what the sponsor sees in the next copy, and FR-023 i**
>
> VERSION 0.11.0
>
> DATE 2026-10-29
>
> AUTHOR Richard Hightower
>
> SECTIONS
> - 5
> - 6
> - 7
> - 8
> - 10
> - 13
> - 14
> - 15

> **FR-022 added as a should in REL-001: a sponsor comments on an exported copy without using**
>
> VERSION 0.10.0
>
> DATE 2026-10-28
>
> AUTHOR Richard Hightower
>
> SECTIONS
> - 6
> - 7
> - 10
> - 13
> - 14
> - 15

**Problems carry counted, sourced evidence. Personas have named roles and frequencies, and e**

| | |
|---|---|
| VERSION | 0.9.0 |
| DATE | 2026-10-27 |
| AUTHOR | Richard Hightower |
| SECTIONS | • 1<br>• 2<br>• 3<br>• 4<br>• 5<br>• 6<br>• 7<br>• 8<br>• 9<br>• 10<br>• 11<br>• 12<br>• 13<br>• 14<br>• 15 |
| RESOLVES | • Q-011 |

**The glossary defines buildability review, finding, root document, approver, condition, con**

| | |
|---|---|
| VERSION | 0.8.1 |
| DATE | 2026-10-27 |
| AUTHOR | Richard Hightower |
| SECTIONS | • 2<br>• 4<br>• 5<br>• 6<br>• 7<br>• 8<br>• 9<br>• 10<br>• 11<br>• 12<br>• 13<br>• 14 |

**Sets the expert's priorities. Ten requirements stay must and eight become should; SC-002 a**

VERSION 0.8.0

DATE 2026-10-27

AUTHOR Richard Hightower

SECTIONS
- 5
- 7
- 12
- 13

**Names the root's objective, primary persona, and approver, from section 3, the personas do**

VERSION 0.7.0

DATE 2026-10-27

AUTHOR Richard Hightower

SECTIONS
- 4
- 5
- 6

**Each problem names its persona, and each objective names the problems it addresses and the**

VERSION 0.6.0

DATE 2026-10-27

AUTHOR Richard Hightower

SECTIONS
- 1
- 2
- 3
- 5
- 10
- 11

**Every journey stage gains Given/When/Then acceptance. The scenarios document gains LC-001,**

VERSION 0.5.0

DATE 2026-10-26

AUTHOR Richard Hightower

SECTIONS
- 4
- 5

**Adds FR-017, moving between sections without losing one's place, and FR-018, seeing the se**

VERSION 0.4.0

DATE 2026-10-26

AUTHOR Richard Hightower

SECTIONS
- 6
- 7
- 8
- 13
- 14

**Adds wireframes to section 7. Each functional requirement now says where its user meets th**

VERSION 0.3.0

DATE 2026-10-26

AUTHOR Richard Hightower

SECTIONS
- 7
- 14

**Fixes every defect the adversarial grading and the buildability review found in 0.1.0. J-0**

VERSION 0.2.0

DATE 2026-10-26

AUTHOR Richard Hightower

SECTIONS
- 4
- 5
- 6
- 7
- 8
- 10
- 13
- 14

**First draft of the whole set, written with prd-forge's own conventions as the product's fi**

| | |
|---|---|
| VERSION | 0.1.0 |
| DATE | 2026-10-23 |
| AUTHOR | Richard Hightower |
| SECTIONS | 1<br>2<br>3<br>4<br>5<br>6<br>7<br>8<br>9<br>10<br>11<br>12<br>13<br>14<br>15 |